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Political resistance will continue, says Rahul after meeting allies and activists

- Leader of the Opposition hosts allies for tea to discuss future course of agitation
- Political parties' representatives, student leaders, and civil society activists take part
- Gandhi's office tried reaching out to CJP but the effort didn't work out, say sources

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

There are no parallel protests, but only one movement to restore democracy, Rahul Gandhi, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, said on Tuesday as he hosted Opposition politicians, civil society activists, and student leaders for tea to discuss the future course of the agitation demanding the suspension of the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and the removal of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar.

Sources told *The Hindu* that leaders of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) were not present at the meeting. Mr. Gandhi's office had tried reaching out to them through an intermediary, but it did not work out. The CJP had been among the groups that issued a call for Saturday's protest, triggering a harsh police crackdown.

Mr. Gandhi, who hosted the discussion a day after a march to the Supreme Court to file a petition to halt the SIR, made it clear that political resistance will continue, regardless of the court's response. "We have extreme respect for the Supreme Court, for the Chief Justice of India, for the judicial system. They have a role to play; we hope they will play that role but we are also political people. No matter what happens, no matter which institution plays a role or not, political resistance will continue, people's resistance will continue, and it will triumph," he said after the meeting.



INDIA bloc members, student leaders, and activists with the Leaders of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha, Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge, after a meeting on Tuesday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Sources said it was decided at the meeting that though there may be breaks in large-scale protest actions because of the Navratri and Durga Puja festivities, the agitation will continue, with Delhi remaining the main focus. Parties belonging to the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) will coordinate every day among each other for joint action.

Opposition leaders from 16 parties attended, including M.A. Baby (CPI-M), D. Raja and P. Sandosh Kumar (CPI), Tejashwi Yadav and Manoj Jha (RJD), Mahua Maji (JMM), Harender Malik, Anand Bhadauria, and Mohibullah Nadvi (SP), Sanjay Raut (Shiv Sena-UBT), Sagarika Ghose and Mahua Moitra (Mamata Trinamool Congress), G. Deverajan (Foward Bloc), and Dipankar Bhattacharya (CPI-ML)L.

All India Students' Association (AISA) chief Neha Bora and advocate Prashant Bhushan also attended the tea party at Mr. Gandhi's No. 5 Sunehri Bagh Road residence. Top Congress leaders, including party chief Mallikarjun Kharge, Sonia Gandhi, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, and K.C. Venugopal, were also present.

'Net is closing'

Mr. Gandhi said that people who "destroy India's Constitution and the election system" could not be allowed to get away with it, vowing that action will be taken against those who have indulged in alleged "vote *chori* (theft)".

"It is our commitment that the people who have done this – [Prime Minister Narendra] Modi, who is the main architect, [Union Home Minister] Amit Shah, who is implementor, [CEC] Gyanesh Kumar and others – they need to understand that the net is closing around them... We assure you that all would be brought to justice," the Opposition leader asserted.

Several leaders objected to the government denotifying the designated protest site at Jantar Mantar and vowed to reclaim it.

"The one method of expression of democracy was Jantar Mantar, and now, the government has decided that Jantar Mantar can no longer be used to express democratic feelings. Well, we are going to challenge that idea," Mr. Gandhi said.

Mr. Yadav called it a "sign of the ruling party's fear". He alleged that the CEC had tried to "trample" democracy at the behest of Mr. Modi and Mr. Shah.

"Earlier, they [BJP] were indulging in vote *chori* but now they are resorting to protest site *chori*," said Mr. Baby.

Mr. Raja said, "We will fight to regain it."

Mr. Raut said the government had kept the country in "fear and intimidation, but now it's their turn to be afraid". The Sena (UBT) leader added: "Gyanesh Kumar is a mafia, he is such a mafia who has criminalised the entire [electoral] system. We know how to fight and deal with such mafias."

MORE REPORTS ON
» PAGES 3, 4, & 5

Be ready to face defeat in 2029 polls: Amit Shah

NEW DELHI

In his first remarks on the ongoing protests for the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and scrapping of SIR, Home Minister Amit Shah on Tuesday said the Congress had been engaged in 'negative politics'. Lashing out at party leader Rahul Gandhi and the Opposition, he said that they should be prepared once again for a "crushing defeat" in 2029 as people are with the BJP, NDA and Prime Minister Narendra Modi. » PAGE 4

Muslims over-flagged in Delhi SIR, data show

Illogical skew

While the share of Muslims in the draft SIR rolls was close to their share of 12.9% of Delhi's population in Census 2011, the list of 'logical discrepancies' seems to have targeted the community disproportionately

- Total electors in Delhi's draft SIR rolls: **97.56 lakh**
- Share of Muslims in the draft SIR rolls: **~13.6%**
- Electors in draft SIR rolls marked for 'logical discrepancies': **19.33 lakh**
- Share of Muslims among those marked for 'logical discrepancies': **~20.3%**

Pon Vasanth B.A.
Srinivasan Ramani
CHENNAI

An analysis of Delhi's draft SIR rolls by *The Hindu* shows that the ECI's software-driven process flagged a disproportionately high number of Muslims for "logical discrepancies".

Muslims made up 13.6% of Delhi's 97.54 lakh draft-roll electors but 20.3% of the 19.33 lakh flagged for "logical discrepancies". In the five reasons for logical discrepancies that are linked to family size such as six or more children naming the same parent, or small age gaps between generations, Muslims were nearly three times as likely as others to be flagged. The logical discrepancies process was first introduced in West Bengal, without any formal announcement. The ECI, which flags electors through its centralised ERONET software, has not explained the eight reasons behind "logical discrepancies".

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 5

Response to pleas needs fine-tuning: Centre to SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday extended time till Thursday for the Union government to file a reply affidavit on petitions alleging illegal detentions and shutdown in Delhi on October 10. A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant gave more time after the Centre informed it that its response is "ready" but needs more fine-tuning.

The top court also agreed to urgently hear fresh petitions on the continued police action against journalists covering the SIR protests.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 4

INSIDE



11 sailors missing after drone sinks ship off Bulgaria

SOFIA

Eleven sailors were missing at sea on Tuesday from a ship sunk by a drone attack off the coast of Bulgaria, the second sinking of a cargo vessel in the area in a week, prompting Bulgaria to summon Russia's Ambassador. Two cargo ships were hit and one was sunk, Bulgaria said. » PAGE 14

Adani defers plan to shift flights to Navi Mumbai

NEW DELHI

The Adani Group has put on hold its plan to shift 30% of international flight slots at Mumbai's Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport to Navi Mumbai International Airport, with no transfers planned for the upcoming winter schedule. The proposed shift has been deferred to the summer schedule. » PAGE 12

13 children killed in Bihar as boat capsizes on the Ganga

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

At least 13 children died after a boat capsized in the Ganga in the Raghopur area of Bihar's Vaishali district on Tuesday night.

According to local people, the boat was carrying about 20 passengers from one village to another for a feast. A team rushed to the spot and started rescue operations.

All the deceased children were below the age of 15, Vaishali District Magistrate Varsha Singh said.

"We received the information around 8.30 p.m. that a private boat carrying children overturned. Seven have been rescued and their condition is stable. Rescue operation will continue throughout the night. So far, 13 bodies have been recovered," she said. An SDRF team and divers are also on site.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi expressed grief over the incident and announced ex gratia of ₹2 lakh each to the families of the deceased and ₹50,000 to those injured.

"The loss of lives in the boat capsizing incident in Vaishali, Bihar, is deeply painful. My thoughts are with the bereaved families in this difficult time," Mr. Modi said in a post on X.



First responders gather at a local hospital after a boat capsized in the Ganga in Vaishali district, Bihar, on Tuesday night. PTI

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary also expressed grief over the incident and announced ₹4 lakh ex gratia for the families of each of the deceased. "The news of the innocent lives lost in the boat accident in Raghopur, Vaishali, is extremely heartbreaking and soul-wrenching. In this difficult time, my deepest condolences are with the bereaved families. May God grant peace to the departed souls and provide the families with the strength to bear this immense sorrow," Mr. Choudhary wrote.

He further wrote, "Instructions have been given to the administration to swiftly complete relief and rescue operations and ensure better treatment for the injured."

Raghopur MLA and Leader of Opposition in the Bihar Legislative Assembly, Tejashwi Yadav, too expressed shock.

"I am deeply shocked by the heart-wrenching incident of the boat capsizing in Raghopur. May God grant peace to the departed souls and strength to the grieving families to bear this sorrow," Mr. Yadav said in a video message posted on X.

Centre postpones rollout of UPI fee beyond Deepavali on traders' appeal

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) has postponed the implementation of Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on UPI transactions, originally scheduled for Thursday, to a date "immediately after Deepavali", without specifying an exact date.

The MDR was to be levied at 0.4% on UPI transactions exceeding ₹2,000 at medium and large merchant establishments. Transactions related to the capital market and those done in strategic sectors will face different MDR rates.

According to government sources, the decision to delay the implementation of MDR on UPI was made in the Prime Minister's Office following strong appeals from traders.

"The UPI and Services Steering Committee today decided that, keeping in mind the festive season, Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on select Person-to-Merchant (P2M) UPI transactions shall be implemented immediately post Deepavali at a date to be notified separately," the NPCI said in a statement on Tuesday.



Black ribbon seen across payment codes at a shop in Bhopal last week as traders protested the proposed fee for UPI transactions. ANI

It is to be noted that the Supreme Court has directed the NPCI, the Union government, and the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) to file affidavits by late October explaining the rationale for imposing MDR on specified UPI transactions.

'Welcome decision'

The Confederation of All India Traders (CAIT) described the decision to delay the MDR rollout as "timely and pragmatic", particularly during the festive and wedding season, when millions of traders and MSMEs depend on higher business volumes.

Praveen Khandelwal, founder and secretary-general of CAIT and a Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) MP, welcomed the decision, saying that it would protect traders' interests and sustain digital payment momentum during the festive season.

CAIT said the decision followed a meeting on September 30, when a delegation of 20 trade leaders led by Mr. Khandelwal met Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and "highlighted the implications of the proposed 0.40% MDR on UPI transactions exceeding ₹2,000". Its statement said, "Additional transaction costs [during the festive season] could have placed an avoidable burden on merchants operating on thin margins and discouraged the wider acceptance of digital payments."

Separately, *The Hindu* has learnt that, earlier this month, liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) distributors had approached the Petroleum and Natural Gas Ministry seeking a complete exemption from MDR or any other payment infrastructure-related levies.

The distributors argued that they have no autonomy to regulate cylinder prices and receive fixed commissions on sales, and that MDR levies would not bode well for their earnings.

They also added that this could create conditions for a return to cash or a payment economy where consumers pay in a staggered manner to circumvent the ₹2,000 threshold, creating a "logistical inconvenience".

(With inputs from Saptaparno Ghosh)

INBRIEF



Bhagwant Mann's former OSD joins Congress in Punjab

A former officer on special duty to Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann, Manjit Singh Sidhu, on Tuesday joined the Congress in the presence of State unit chief Pargat Singh in Chandigarh. Mr. Singh said Mr. Sidhu played a role in building the Aam Aadmi Party in Punjab, but was later sidelined. Mr. Sidhu had long been looking for a political platform that prioritises harmony, public welfare and the future of Punjab, he said as he welcomed the ex-scribe into the party fold. Mr. Sidhu said Mr. Mann perhaps prefers to stand by his chair but "I stand by Punjab". PTI

Patna HC acquits 13 accused in 1996 Jehanabad murder case

The Patna High Court on Tuesday set aside a trial court's conviction order and acquitted 13 appellants in a 1996 quadruple murder case. A Division Bench comprising Justice Rajeev Ranjan Prasad and Justice Kumar Manish delivered the ruling, citing grave lapses in the police investigation, lack of credible identification, and a failure by the prosecution to prove guilt beyond a reasonable doubt. The case dates back to August 1996 when a group of armed men stormed into a hut where villagers were keeping watch over water meant for irrigation. The violent attack claimed the lives of four persons.

Anger mounts in Punjab after anti-drug crusader killed in broad daylight

Confronted over illegal sale of addictive substances, medical store owner shoots down activist; Mansa residents stage protests; family refuses to cremate body; Opposition corners AAP govt.

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

An anti-drug crusader was shot dead on Tuesday at a local medical store in Punjab's Mansa district, sparking widespread outrage and putting the ruling Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on the back foot over the State's deteriorating law and order.

According to the police, Parvinder Singh Jhota was shot dead by a medical store owner when he confronted the latter for selling illegal addictive substances to a man. Though he was rushed to the hospital, doctors declared Jhota brought dead. The accused fled the spot soon after the incident, and police teams have been formed to nab him.

Police said, Jhota was also recording the arguments on his mobile phone. In a purported video that surfaced online, Jhota could be heard saying that the medical store owner, Ashwani, had taken out his pistol.



Family members of the victim, Parvinder Singh Jhota, outside a hospital in Mansa on Tuesday. ANI

Bathinda Range DIG Harjeet Singh said: "The accused appeared to have used a licensed weapon for committing the crime. His accomplice has been arrested. Efforts are on to apprehend Ashwani."

The DIG said the incident could stem from an old personal enmity between the two. The case is being investigated thoroughly and the accused will be arrested within 24 hours," said Senior Superintendent of Police, Mansa, Vaibhav Choudhary said.

Mr. Singh, a former boxer, had been running a campaign against drug abuse through 'Nasha Roko, Rozgaar Do campaign'.

After the incident, scores of people staged a protest outside Mansa civil hospital. Shops were also shut down in the town. Protesters vandalised the medical store of the accused. Mr. Singh's family refused to cremate the body, blaming the State government for its failure to curb substance abuse.

The Opposition tore into the AAP government even as supporters of the deceased blocked the Barnala-Sirsa road in Mansa, expressing their anger.

BJP national president Nitin Nabin said the brazen daylight murder of Jhota, who raised his voice against drugs in Mansa, exposed the extremely poor state of law and order in Punjab under the AAP government.

'CM must resign'

Demanding Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann's resignation, senior Shiromani Akali Dal leaderHarsimrat Kaur Badal said, "The drug mafia had become so emboldened under his [Bhagawant Mann] regime that it was now resorting to daylight killing of anti-drug activists. The manner in which Jhota had been killed proved that the drug mafia did not have any fear of the law."

Leader of the Opposition in the Punjab Assembly Partap Singh Bajwa said, Jhota's murder has exposed the grim reality behind the AAP government's much-publicised 'Yudh Nasheyan Virudh' campaign.

Khandu agrees to withdraw FIRs over Siang dam protest

Press Trust of India
ITANAGAR



Arunachal CM Pema Khandu

Arunachal Pradesh Chief Minister Pema Khandu on Tuesday agreed in principle to reduce the number of security personnel deployed in the Siang Valley and withdraw FIRs registered during protests against the proposed 11,200 MW hydropower project in the region –two of the key demands of the agitators.

This is being seen as the government's willingness to take confidence-building measures amid growing tensions over the mega dam that has been projected as a driver of economic growth and a means of strengthening water and energy security for the State and the nation.

In a post on X after a meeting with the Adi Baane Kebang Youth Wing and the Adi Students' Union, Mr. Khandu said his government remained committed to dialogue and finding a way forward over the issue through mutual understanding.

The CM also said he has received requests from the two organisations for a reduction in the number of security forces deployed in the valley and withdrawal of FIRs. "I agree to these proposals in principle as confidence-building measures to facilitate dialogue," he said. Mr. Khandu expressed hope that both organisations would work constructively to create an atmosphere of trust.

The development comes amid heightened tension in the Siang Valley, where sections of the Adi community have been opposing the pre-feasibility report for the proposed hydropower project. The deployment of security personnel to facilitate the preparatory work has further sharpened the differences between the State government and sections of the local populace.

Officials said that Mr. Khandu's announcement was expected to open the way for further engagement, although the broader disagreement over the Siang dam project remains unresolved.

DSP slaps advocate in dispute over parking, apologises amid protests by lawyers in Ajmer

The Hindu Bureau
JAIPUR

Lawyers in Ajmer district's Kishangarh town boycotted work and staged a protest on Monday after a woman Circle Officer allegedly slapped an advocate during a dispute over vehicle parking in the market. A video footage of the incident went viral on social media, prompting the lawyers to demand action against the police officer.

Lawyers at the Ajmer district headquarters took to streets, leading to disruption of traffic on Ajmer-Jaipur road. The matter was resolved after the police officer, Anju Yadav, recorded a video with the advocate, Babulal Bagaria, and tendered an apology.

Mr. Bagaria had parked his car on the roadside in the town's main market over the weekend and gone to buy vegetables. When he returned, Ms. Yadav, looking after the traffic management, questioned him about the parking, saying parking was not allowed at the spot.

Matter was resolved after the official tendered an apology in a video shot with the advocate sitting beside her

'Slapped, threatened me'

The advocate later said in a statement that he apologised and assured the officer that he would park the vehicle at a designated space in the future. "Despite this, Ms. Yadav took my car key, slapped me in front of numerous bystanders and threatened me," Mr. Bagaria said.

Following the incident, members of the Bar Association gathered at the market and staged a protest demanding suspension of the police officer.

Meanwhile, Ms. Yadav made an allegedly offensive comment showing off her power on a social media platform.

Later, on the intervention of senior police officers, Ms. Yadav met Mr. Bagaria and expressed regret over the incident.

In a video shot with the advocate sitting beside her, Ms. Yadav said she had no malice towards Mr. Bagaria and she should not have behaved in that manner during the arguments.

Kishangarh Bar Association president Dinesh Kumar Jat said both the sides had reached an agreement and the lawyers had accepted Ms. Yadav's apology, after which the issue had been resolved.

Shivraj's twin remarks fuel buzz of rift in M.P. BJP

NEWS ANALYSIS

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

Two statements from former Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Sunday – one a sharp rebuke and the other a soft political reminder – were enough to heat up the State's politics and fuel speculation that all may not be well within the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). The latest row hints at mounting pressure on Chief Minister Mohan Yadav amid reports of differences between him and other senior party leaders, including Cabinet Ministers and State BJP president Hemant Khandelwal.

Mr. Chouhan, now Union Agriculture Minister, criticised the State government over the demolition of houses of 12 tribal families at Kosmi village in Vidisha, his Lok Sabha constituency. The remarks are being seen as a message of his discontent with his successor's administration. The eviction drive, carried out on grounds of alleged encroachment on forest land, was undertaken despite Mr. Chouhan having intervened in the matter.



Madhya Pradesh CM Mohan Yadav (right) with his predecessor and Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan. FILE PHOTO

However, another statement made by him at an event in neighbouring Raisen district on the same day may hold greater political relevance. Referring to the Ladli Behna scheme that he launched in his final year as Chief Minister in 2023, Mr. Chouhan said, "The Chief Minister has continued this scheme and every government will have to keep it going. *Sabko pata hain ki behenein gussa ho gayi toh phir khair nahi hain* (Everybody knows that if sisters get angry, you are done for)."

'Calculated move'

The former CM's remarks came a week after Mr. Yadav said in jest at an event on October 4 that the scheme had proved to be a "very expensive affair".

Political observers who have followed Mr. Chouhan's politics see various women-centric schemes as his legacy, which earned him the sobriquet '*Mama* (maternal uncle)'. Observers and BJP insiders believe that the timing of Mr. Chouhan's twin remarks could be a "deliberate and calculated" move.

A senior BJP leader in Bhopal, on condition of anonymity, said, "Shivraj*ji* is well aware of the current power dynamic in the State BJP and that resentment is rising against the man who replaced him [Mr. Yadav]. So, his statements could be a calculated move to put his weight behind that resentment and add to the Chief Minister's pressure. He also specifically said he spoke to the State [BJP] president [on the tribals' issue] because he knows of the recent rumours of differences between him and the Chief Minister."

The leader also pointed out that Mr. Chouhan's "unusually harsh words" for Forest officials over the eviction drive hold significance as Mr. Yadav himself heads the department.

Senior journalist and political observer Rashid Kidwai also linked Mr. Chouhan's recent remarks to his efforts to remain "relevant in the State while growing his stature in the national BJP". "Shivraj knows that he is only important in Delhi as long as he remains relevant in Madhya Pradesh," he said.

Mr. Kidwai also pointed out that while the BJP has many regional satraps in Madhya Pradesh, Mr. Chouhan could be the only leader with a pan-State appeal. "And he wants to keep it that way."

"Mohan Yadav's relevance will depend on the U.P. poll results, whether they are in the BJP's favour or not. Till then, he may continue to enjoy Delhi's backing as he has these past three years," he said.

The Opposition Congress, meanwhile, has linked the Kosmi incident to a "power tussle". "This action is a new chapter in the open conflict brewing between the Chief Ministers of the BJP," State unit president Jitu Patwari said.

Waqf Board takes U-turn on uniform Friday sermons in J&K mosques after facing flak

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

In the face of opposition by Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, Kashmir chief cleric Mirwaiz Umar Farooq, and Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) president Mehbooba Mufti to the J&K Waqf Board's move to introduce uniform Friday sermons in mosques, senior BJP leader and chairperson of the board Darakshan Andrabi on Tuesday took a U-turn and said "such decisions will be taken by preachers and not politicians".

"There is no order to have uniform sermons. In a meeting on Sunday, religious scholars and preachers suggested to fight social evils collectively. *Ulemas* (scholars) and *khateebs* (preachers) will decide the topics for Friday sermons through a board. It's them (preachers) and not politicians who get to decide on such matters," she said.



> This is an unacceptable attempt by the BJP to interfere in the religious affairs of Muslims and won't be accepted under any circumstances
>
> **OMAR ABDULLAH**
> Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister

Ms. Andrabi said the idea was to "forcefully and unitedly raise voice over social issues like drugs, late marriages, waywardness, and recent cases of damaging of orchards".

The U-turn came two days after Ms. Andrabi proposed to have a core committee of preachers to predecide topics for sermons in J&K mosques.

Public outcry

Ishtiyaq Mohi-ud-Din, an executive magistrate on the board, had informed the preachers about the board's directive that "only one topic will be highlighted [in the sermons]".

The move, however, evoked public outcry and drew criticism from the regional parties. "This is an unacceptable attempt by the BJP to interfere in the religious affairs of Muslims and will not be accepted under any circumstances. The BJP-appointed chairperson must immediately halt this misplaced attempt to please her masters," Mr. Abdullah said.

Mr. Farooq, who also heads a pan-J&K conglomerate of religious bodies, Mutahida Majlis-e-Ulema, said, "Even the suggestion that a statutory body could determine or regulate what is to be preached from the pulpit is ridiculous, and will never be accepted by the Muslims of Jammu and Kashmir."

PDP president Mehbooba Mufti termed the move "totally unacceptable".

Madras HC upholds Speaker's decision to accept resignation of six AIADMK MLAs

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court on Tuesday upheld the decision of Tamil Nadu Assembly Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar to accept the resignation of six AIADMK MLAs, who later joined the ruling TVK, between May 26, 2026 and June 29, 2026. But it directed him to decide within two months the disqualification proceedings pending against four of them.

The First Division Bench of Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dharmadhikari and Justice G. Arul Murugan said the Speaker was duty-bound to rise above his individual predilections and respect the robe which the Constitution had gifted to him. "The Speaker is expected to respect the sensitive constitutional trust by acting on the said disqualification proceedings with utmost expedition," it added.



J.C.D. Prabhakar

The judges expressed surprise over the disqualification proceedings kept pending for the last four months against the four resigned MLAs – Esakki Subaya (Ambasamudram), S. Jayakumar (Perundurai), Maragatham Kumaravel (Maduranthakam) and P. Sathyabama (Dharapuram) – with the last two having been re-elected to the Assembly recently from the same constituencies.

The Speaker has been asked to decide in two months the disqualification proceedings pending against four of them

The court directed the Speaker to prepare a timetable within seven days providing specific timelines and deadlines for various stages of the proceedings such as filing of replies by the defecting MLAs, receiving the complainant's objections to those replies, finalisation of pleadings, and hearing the final arguments. Such a timetable must be made public for the benefit of all stakeholders, it ordered.

The Bench also directed the Speaker not to allow any of the defecting MLAs to unnecessarily delay the proceedings by seeking adjournments on flimsy grounds. In any case, not more than two adjournments should be given to the defecting MLAs since the proceedings were pending at the stage of issuance of notices to them for the last four months, the Bench reiterated.

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INBRIEF



Sugar cane farmers block highway for higher prices

Sugar cane farmers in Karnataka began a protest for higher prices by blocking the Pune-Bengaluru National Highway at Hire Bagewadi and Hattaragi in Belagavi district on Tuesday. Their demands include doubling the minimum selling price of sugar to ₹60 per kg, increasing the fair and remunerative price to ₹5,500 per tonne of sugar cane, and transparency in weighing in factories. The farmers also urged authorities to buy more ethanol from Karnataka.

Court issues gag order on airing videos on Siddaramaiah

A Bengaluru civil court on Tuesday issued an ad-interim ex-parte temporary injunction restraining further circulation of two videos telecast on two private YouTube channels making allegedly defamatory remarks against former Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah. The interim order restrains 42 media houses from disseminating the impugned videos. Mr. Siddaramaiah had filed a suit in which he denied all the allegations made in the two videos.

Cannabis seized, passenger arrested at Hyderabad airport

The Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) seized 7.75 kg of high-grade cannabis from an Indian passenger arriving from Bangkok at the Rajiv Gandhi International Airport in Hyderabad on October 12 and arrested him. The contraband, suspected to be hydroponic cannabis, is worth approximately ₹2.71 crore on the black market. The DRI officers intercepted him at the airport on specific intelligence alert. The contraband was concealed in an electric geyser.

Shivakumar seeks report on police action at SIR protest

Will take action if there was 'unnecessary use of force', says Karnataka CM; his assurance comes a day after police manhandled protesters; govt. says people can hold peaceful protests without fear

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar said on Tuesday that he had taken note of the police action against protesters and members of the media on Monday, and had sought a full report on the circumstances that led to it.

"If there has been any unnecessary use of force or excess, accountability will follow," he said.

On Monday, the Bengaluru police detained over 100 persons for attempting to march to the office of the Chief Electoral Officer, Karnataka, in protest against the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. The police also manhandled journalists and photographers, apart from protesters, on a day Mr. Shivakumar was participating in an anti-SIR rally in New Delhi, drawing widespread criticism.



Dissent hour: A protest under way in Bengaluru on Tuesday against SIR and the assault on protesters. K. MURALI KUMAR

"The right to peaceful protest is fundamental to our democracy. We cannot demand that right for ourselves in Delhi and deny it to others in Bengaluru. Karnataka must hold itself to the democratic standards that we expect from the rest of the country. There will be no double standard," the Chief Minister said. "Let me be clear: disagreement with the Election Commission, disagreement with my government or disagreement with me personally does not diminish anyone's right to peacefully express it," he added.

Home Minister Priyank Kharge said he had told the police to ensure that no peaceful demonstration is disrupted. "Our responsibility is not merely to maintain law and order, but to create an environment where every citizen can express dissent freely, peacefully and without fear. In a democracy, peaceful dissent is not a threat to law and order. It is a right that law and order must protect," Mr. Kharge said on X.



A.P. Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu and T.N. Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay during a meeting at Undavalli. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

During visit to A.P., T.N. CM seeks more water for Chennai

G.V.R. Subba Rao
VIJAYAWADA

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Tuesday sought the release of more water from Andhra Pradesh to meet the drinking water requirements of Chennai. However, the Andhra Pradesh government did not give any assurance, saying it would consider the request depending on the availability of water in Krishna River and the requirements of the State.

Mr. Vijay met Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu at the latter's camp office in Vijayawada and discussed inter-State water issues, including the proposed Godavari-Cauvery link and drinking water supply to Chennai.

Mr. Naidu said the Andhra Pradesh government was sympathetic to Chennai's drinking water needs, despite a decline in water availability in Krishna River due to the El Niño effect this year and the consequent water scarcity. He informed Mr. Vijay that Andhra Pradesh had already released 4.08 tmc to Chennai. "The Andhra Pradesh government will consider releasing additional water to Chennai, depending on water availability and the requirements of the State," he told his Tamil Nadu counterpart.

Mr. Vijay, who arrived in the State to take part in the Vijayawada Utsav, was accorded a warm welcome by Mr. Naidu and Human Resources Development Minister Nara Lokesh. The two Chief Ministers held discussions on issues of mutual interest. During the meeting, Mr. Naidu explained the importance of linking the Godavari and the Cauvery, describing it as a permanent solution to drought.

Mr. Vijay, meanwhile, requested Andhra Pradesh to release additional water to Chennai through the Telugu Ganga project.

Mr. Vijay also offered prayers at the Sri Kanaka Durga Temple.

Life-saving drugs in short supply in Keralam govt. hospitals: Opposition

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Opposition Left Democratic Front (LDF) and the ruling Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) traded barbs in the Keralam Assembly on Tuesday over the state of the health sector, with the former citing medicine shortages, arbitrary staff retrenchments and transfers, and cases of medical negligence.

Moving an adjournment motion to discuss the shortage of medicines in government hospitals across the State, K.V. Sumesh, MLA, said the health sector had been put "on a ventilator" since the UDF came to power. "Thousands of patients are struggling to obtain medicines for lifestyle diseases from government hospitals, while a critical shortage of life-saving drugs had compounded the crisis," said Mr. Sumesh, citing an alleged leaked audio recording of senior health officials.

Dismissing the Opposition's allegations, Health Minister K. Muraleedharan maintained that the situation in the health sector was "under control". He remarked that "the only medicine in short supply was one that could cure the Opposition of its ailment of having lost power". He also alleged that the Opposition was working in the interests of private hospitals.

The Minister's remarks triggered an uproar in the Assembly. Opposition leader Pinarayi Vijayan accused the Minister of downplaying the crisis.

The Opposition members subsequently staged a walkout after they were denied permission to discuss the issue.

After Kochi road accident, Minister warns bars of strict action

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Keralam Excise Minister M. Liju on Tuesday said that strict action would be taken against bars that serve alcohol to people below the legal drinking age of 23. His assurance came after the fatal road accident near Nedumbassery in Kochi that claimed the lives of three young people.

Responding to a question raised by Ernakulam MLA T.J. Vinod in the Kerala Legislative Assembly on Tuesday, Mr. Liju said the Excise department has registered cases against three bars for allegedly serving alcohol to the 19-year-old driver involved in the accident. The government was considering stricter guidelines to prevent violations of the existing law, he said.

'Frequent violations'

Raising the issue in the House, Mr. Vinod pointed out that Abkari Act prescribes 23 years as the minimum age for consuming alcohol at bars.

He expressed concern that the rule was frequently violated and asked what measures the government intended to take to enforce age verification more rigorously and punish establishments that served alcohol to underage customers.

Mr. Liju said that after the accident, he had directed senior Excise Department officials to act immediately.

The department subsequently initiated legal proceedings against the three establishments who are suspected of serving alcohol to the underage driver.

Dasara lights



Bright and beautiful: The K.R. Circle in Mysuru city has been illuminated as part of the 10-day Dasara festivities. The celebrations will conclude with Jamboo Savari on October 21. M.A. SRIRAM

'Keralam did not stand up to ED like other non-BJP States'

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The CPI(M) on Tuesday accused Keralam Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan of "slyly playing second fiddle" to the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh's (RSS) agenda to weaken the secular opposition to the BJP-led Centre by using the Enforcement Directorate (ED) to foist false charges against Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan and others in the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case.

CPI(M) State secretary M.V. Govindan told the meida that Mr. Satheesan's statement that the government would not appeal the High Court single Bench order to register an FIR against Mr. Vijayan, his daughter T. Veena, and former Minister P.A. Mohamed Riyas, based on a "dubious" ED report, corroborated Mr. Satheesan's "symbiotic association" with the Sangh Parivar.



CPI(M) leader M.V. Govindan

(A Division Bench on Tuesday declined to stay the single Bench order)

Mr. Govindan said the UDF indicted Mr. Vijayan and his family in an anti-corruption case at the drop of a hat, "ignoring the Advocate General's advice that the ED's demand for an immediate FIR without a preliminary inquiry was opaque". In contrast, the non-BJP governments in Tamil Nadu and Punjab had shown the grit to protect their constitutionally guaranteed jurisdictional mandate over law-enforcement matters by rejecting such ED demands, he said.

"The All India Congress Committee should state whether Mr. Satheesan's dalliance with the RSS and its allied agencies had the national leadership's imprimatur," he said.

Telangana sceptical of Naidu's suggestion

M. Rajeev
HYDERABAD

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu recently said that the two Telugu States, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh, should adopt the 'principle of give and take' for arriving at mutually acceptable solutions to the pending bifurcation issues.

Mr. Naidu reiterated this during the recent Southern Zonal Council meeting, while requesting Telangana Deputy Chief Minister Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka to come forward and resolve all the pending issues once and for all. The suggestion is, however, being viewed with scepticism by the Telangana government, as officials claim it as yet another attempt to bypass the provisions of the AP Reorganisation Act, 2014.

The Telangana government too has been seeking resolution to pending issues, such as division of assets, strictly adhering to the provisions of the Reorganisation Act.

Officials say the 'principle of give and take' was in reference to the apportionment of Schedule IX and X institutions as well as the institutions not mentioned anywhere in the Act which are located in Telangana and hence belong to the State. Officials cite a similar instance pertaining to the apportionment of public debt related to externally aided projects.

Centre approves double-decker elevated corridor, ropeway projects in Telangana

R. Ravikanth Reddy
HYDERABAD

Union Minister for Road Transport and Highways Nitin Gadkari has approved the L.B. Nagar-Hayathnagar double-decker elevated corridor and five ropeway projects in Telangana, besides agreeing to several other proposals to improve road connectivity in the State.

The approvals were conveyed at a meeting between Mr. Gadkari and the State Minister for Roads and Buildings Komatireddy Venkat Reddy in New Delhi on Tuesday.

They discussed several infrastructure projects, including highways, bridges, elevated corridors and ropeways.



Telangana Ministers Komatireddy Venkat Reddy, Jupally Krishna Rao with Union Minister Nitin Gadkari in New Delhi on Tuesday.

Mr. Gadkari also directed officials to prepare a fresh detailed project report (DPR) for the proposed elevated corridor on the Hyderabad-Srisailam National Highway (NH-765).

He responded positively to the proposal for a Hyderabad-Amaravati greenfield highway.

Mr. Reddy said the Union Minister approved the proposal to lay the foundation stone for a cable bridge across the Krishna river on NH-167K, which is expected to improve connectivity between Telangana and Andhra Pradesh and promote transport and tourism.

Rail overbridges

Three railway overbridges were also approved under the Setu Bandhan scheme. Mr. Reddy sought Central Road and Infrastructure Fund (CRIF) allocations for 34 works in Telangana.

The meeting also discussed upgrading several State highways into national highways. The proposed routes include Pullur-Alampur-Jatrapole stretch.

Mr. Reddy also invited Mr. Gadkari to the Indian Road Congress (IRC) event scheduled to be held in Hyderabad from November 19 to 22.

IAS officer booked on assault charge in Bengaluru

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

An IAS officer of the Andhra Pradesh cadre and three more people have been booked for allegedly assaulting a police inspector and other police personnel, abusing them, and obstructing them from discharging their duty during a late-night inspection at a bar and restaurant in Bengaluru.

The case was filed on Saturday against Vikas Marmat, an IAS officer serving as Special Officer of the Kuppam Area Development Authority, and three others – Abhay Uday Singh, Nitish, and Roshan.

SC gives Centre more time to reply to pleas against detentions, transport shutdown

Bench headed by CJI Surya Kant allows govt. to file reply affidavit on Thursday; Solicitor-General says the affidavit is ready but needs fine-tuning; top court also agrees to urgently hear petitions for probe and contempt proceedings against police action on journalists covering anti-CEC-SIR protests

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Union government informed the Supreme Court on Tuesday that its response to petitions alleging illegal detentions, shutdown of public and rail transport, including Metro service, in Delhi on October 10 is "ready" but needs more fine-tuning.

A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant extended the time for the government to file the reply affidavit till Thursday. Multiple petitions, including ones seeking contempt proceedings, were adjourned to October 15 as one of the judges on the Bench was unwell.

Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, for the Centre, said he had gone through the prepared affidavit. It was final, but he wanted to make it "more comprehensive". On the petitioners' request, the court asked him to share the affidavit, if possible, by October 14, a day before the hearing so that the lawyers of the petitioners were suitably well-versed with the contents of the affidavit and the hearing would be a meaningful one.

The court also agreed to urgently hear fresh petitions seeking independent probe and contempt proceedings against authorities on the continued police action against journalists, especially women media professionals, covering the anti-CEC/SIR protests despite an apex court order against it on October 11.

Chief Justice Kant asked the petitioners to cure defects, after which the pleas would also be put up for a comprehensive hearing on Thursday.



Police action: A protester being detained during the anti-CEC demonstration in New Delhi on Saturday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

The court asked for a senior police officer to be present during the next hearing, when allegations of assault on women are raised in the courtroom.

Members of the Supreme Court Bar Association and Supreme Court Advocates-on-Record Association, of which petitions were adjourned on Tuesday, gathered at the Supreme Court lawns to express solidarity with the advocates who were assaulted and detained by the police during the October 10 and 11 protests.

A separate petition was orally mentioned by senior advocate Gaurav Bhatia about the "sad" incident which happened in the Supreme Court on Monday.

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi and other Opposition leaders had come to the Supreme Court Registry after filing a petition seeking a probe into SIR and allegations of arbitrary functioning and misconduct against CEC Gyanesh Kumar.

Mr. Gandhi's arrival had drawn a crowd of lawyers within the court premises, and the participants of his 'March for Democracy' converged in large numbers at the outer gates of the court.

Mr. Bhatia said a plea by advocate Divyansh Bisht has sought initiation of criminal contempt against Mr. Gandhi and other Opposition leaders for obstructing justice, a ban on political demonstrations inside court premises, a "neutral framework" to regulate protests near courts, and safeguards against political interference in *sub judice* cases.

The court also saw the urgent mentioning of petitions by organisations of media professionals, including Free Speech Collective and Network of Women in Media, India, which said the violence visited upon journalists were "not merely isolated obstruction, but an asserted course of police action comprising unlawful detention, forcible removal, physical assault, manhandling, intimidation, disregard of press credentials and the calculated exclusion and removal of journalists from places where public power was being exercised".

Senior advocate Nitya Ramakrishnan said "documentary proof of students being abused in police stations" have been placed on record before the top court and should be taken up for hearing on Thursday.

Congress is living in denial over election defeats: BJP, JD(U)

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



Piyush Goyal

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and its ally, the Janata Dal-United (JD-U), on Tuesday accused the Congress of undermining constitutional institutions and creating disorder in an attempt to regain power.

The BJP and JD(U) alleged the principal Opposition questioned the Election Commission of India (ECI)'s credibility after electoral defeats but accepted the process whenever it won.

In a joint press conference at the BJP headquarters, Union Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh of the JD(U) shared the platform with senior BJP leader and Union Minister Piyush Goyal. Both the Ministers condemned the alleged mistreatment of a pregnant journalist covering the Congress-led protest on Monday.

Mr. Goyal said if the Congress genuinely doubted the impartiality of the ECI and the integrity of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process, the six Chief Ministers of States where the party was in power or part of the ruling coalition should resign. He referred to Karnataka, Telangana, Himachal Pradesh, and Keralam, besides Jharkhand and Tamil Nadu.

'Double standards'

Accusing the Congress of double standards, Mr. Goyal said the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, and his party had a "delulu is the solulu" ("delusion is the solution") mindset, suggesting that they were living in denial over electoral setbacks.

Mr. Goyal asked Mr. Gandhi why he had repeatedly been alleging "vote theft" without submitting an affidavit or evidence; and why the Congress opposed the SIR when some of its own leaders had demanded electoral roll purification and even acknowledged its benefits.

The Congress and Mr. Gandhi were questioning the impartiality of the ECI, Mr. Goyal said, but had forgotten their own track record of allegedly rewarding former election officials with political appointments. The Modi government, in contrast, introduced a law in 2023 providing for a selection panel, which includes the Leader of the Opposition, to decide on the appointment of Election Commissioners, he said.

"I don't think Rahul Gandhi, the Congress party, or the Aam Aadmi Party, by sending its B-team [an apparent reference to the Cockroach Janta Party], can undermine Indian democracy," Mr. Goyal said, claiming the protests had drawn a limited number of participants.

'Wants to seize power'

Alleging Mr. Gandhi wanted "institutions that remain loyal to him", the JD (U) Minister cited two instances of former judges during the Congress regime. He alleged the Congress was now trying to discredit institutions and pressure them through protests.

The Congress also questioned Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs) after losing elections, but accepted the results whenever it won, Mr. Singh said. Recalling Mr. Gandhi's allegations against Mr. Modi over the Rafale deal, he said the Congress leader had later tendered a written apology to the Supreme Court.

Accusing Mr. Gandhi of "creating disorder to seize power", Mr. Singh said, "I think Rahul Gandhi is following in the footsteps of his grandmother. He wants to take the Congress party back to the 1974-75 period, when the Emergency was imposed in the country and everyone's fundamental rights were taken away, including those of journalists, judges and the High Courts."

Supreme Court registers Rahul's plea on SIR, CEC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

A petition filed by Opposition leaders led by Rahul Gandhi in the Supreme Court for a complete disclosure of records and decisions of the Election Commission of India (ECI) on the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) and an independent probe into allegations of unilateral exercise of power by Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar, which led to voter deletions and modifications, was successfully registered on Tuesday for judicial hearing.

The Supreme Court Registry cleared and numbered the petition, filed by advocate Prasanna S., within 24 hours of its filing on Monday. The petition was filed on Monday evening by Mr. Gandhi's legal team headed by senior advocate A.M. Singhvi even as the Congress leader led a march to the Supreme Court. Leaders across the Opposition political spectrum had walked to the SC to mark their presence as petitioners in the case.

Clerical defects

Mr. Gandhi's petition reportedly had featured over 10 clerical defects, including a deficit in court fees and missing *vakalatnamas* for some of the petitioners.

When contacted in the morning on Tuesday, Mr. Gandhi's legal team said such defects were "contemplated under the Supreme Court Rules and would be cured in due course". They said the Registry had found no fault in the substantive legal and constitutional arguments raised in the petition.

Shah slams SIR protests, tells Rahul to be ready for defeat in 2029 polls

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



Amit Shah

The Congress will suffer its fourth consecutive defeat, while the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) will return to power with an overwhelming majority in the 2029 Lok Sabha elections, Union Home Minister Amit Shah said on Tuesday, following the Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP) victory in Gujarat's local body elections.

"The trust of the people cannot be earned through manufactured media events and the echo of falsehoods. Gathering 8,000 people within a 1.5-km area by bringing together cadres from 14 parties cannot be described as voice of the nation," he said.

The Congress, he said, should recognise that the voice of the nation also resonated in farms, villages, remote hills, forests and along riverbanks, where the principal Opposition had "little or no reach". He cited Bihar, Uttar Pradesh and Tamil Nadu as States where, according to him, voters had repeatedly rejected the Congress over several decades.

'Negative politics'

The Home Minister questioned Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi's allegations concerning the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process, asking whether the BJP's victory in Gujarat was also attributable to the SIR.

"Ever since Rahul Gandhi became the principal leader of the Congress, then its president, and now the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, the Congress has continued to lose elections. He needs to introspect," Mr. Shah said.

The Home Minister said the Congress's continued pursuit of "negative politics" would not benefit the party and urged Mr. Gandhi to understand public sentiment and establish direct contact with voters.

He also accused the Congress of attempting to protect illegal infiltrators on the pretext of opposing the SIR, saying people understood what he described as the party's "strategy" and would no longer be misled by it.

"The BJP's resounding victory in the local body elections in Gujarat and the recently concluded by-elections and local elections in other States has once again proven that the people have completely rejected the lies of Rahul Gandhi and the INDIA bloc," Mr. Shah said.

In the elections to three municipalities and municipal corporations in Gujarat, the BJP won 90 of the 104 seats. In the Gandhinagar corporation, which falls under Mr. Shah's constituency, the party secured 38 of the 44 seats.

Responding to Mr. Shah's statement, Congress communications chief Jairam Ramesh said, "The co-architect of 'vote *chori*' has, not surprisingly, 'predicted' the 2029 Lok Sabha election for which undoubtedly he has already begun the rigging process. But it is not going to happen."

Suspend MP Akoijam, BJP women MPs tell President

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Women MPs from the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Tuesday met President Droupadi Murmu and sought her intervention in suspending Congress MP and former Jawaharlal Nehru University academic Angomcha Bimol Akoijam, from the Lok Sabha.

The JNU administration dismissed Mr. Akoijam on October 9, after an internal inquiry found him guilty of sexual harassment and inappropriate conduct following complaints from women students.

He was a Professor at the university's Centre for the Study of Social Systems in the School of Social Sciences. The meeting followed a protest by the BJP Mahila Morcha on Monday.

BJP Mahila Morcha president Roop Kumari Choudhary said after the meeting that the delegation also urged the President to ensure the safety of those who had reported the alleged harassment.

Cong. accuses Centre of facilitating attendance fraud in jobs scheme

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Tuesday accused the Union government of facilitating fraud in the rural employment scheme Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) through the alleged use of a cloned attendance application, with Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh citing a news report on a case from Uttar Pradesh.

The government said the incident cited by the party predates the new employment programme and is already under investigation.

In a post on X, Mr. Ramesh alleged that after "an assault on the right to 100 days of employment under MGNREGA", the government was now "looting the poor through fake attendance in VB-G RAM G". He claimed that the ruling BJP was undermining both workers' rights and public trust.



Serious charge: The Centre is now 'looting the poor through fake attendance in VB-G RAM G scheme', the Congress said. FILE PHOTO

Mr. Ramesh referred to media reports that a cloned version of the National Mobile Monitoring System (NMMS) application, which is used to record worker attendance, had allegedly been used to register attendance fraudulently. A case in this regard was reportedly registered in Chandauli district of Uttar Pradesh.

"First, the theft of donations made in the name of Lord Shri Ram; then an assault on the right to 100 days of employment under MGNREGA; and now, a scheme of state-sponsored plunder of the poor through fake attendance in the VB-G RAM G programme. The name invoked is Ram's, the blow falls on the poor, and the loot is of the right to employment," Mr. Ramesh said.

Responding to the allegation, the Union government said the incident cited by the Congress pertained to June, when MGNREGA was operational and before the implementation of the VB-G RAM G Act.

Criminal action

The Rural Development Ministry said that criminal action had already been initiated in the case and maintained that such complaints were taken seriously. It also underlined that multiple safeguards were available to prevent wage pilferage.

The government said attendance at worksites is recorded through the NMMS application and supplemented by face authentication. It added that an AI-based photo de-duplication system has been introduced to identify suspicious photographs and attendance entries, including those potentially linked to cloned applications. "Entries flagged by the system are subjected to verification before wage payments are processed," it said.

India and Canada together contributing to prosperous, stable world: Modi to Carney

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

India and Canada are together contributing to a "more stable and prosperous world", said Prime Minister Narendra Modi after a call with Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney, during which they agreed to conclude a trade agreement soon.

The phone call on Tuesday night came even as senior Canadian Ministers, including Foreign Minister Anita Anand and Minister of International Trade Maninder Sidhu, are in Delhi for talks with their counterparts – External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar and Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal – and to firm up plans for Mr. Modi's visit to Ottawa in December.

Last week, National Security Advisor Ajit Doval also hosted Canadian Senior Diplomatic and International Affairs Advisor David Morrison, during which the two sides discussed cooperation on "security and law enforcement", without mentioning the Nijjar killing case that had led to the suspension of relations between the two nations from 2023 to 2025.



Narendra Modi and Mark Carney shake hands during the 2025 G20 Summit. FILE PHOTO

On Wednesday morning, Ms. Anand and Mr. Jaishankar will be part of a panel discussion to discuss the "Middle Power Moment", along with former British Prime Minister Rishi Sunak and former Australian Prime Minister Kevin Rudd.

'Warm talks'

Mr. Modi said his conversation with Mr. Carney had been "warm and productive". "We agreed to build on the positive momentum in India-Canada ties and work towards concrete outcomes across key areas of our Strategic Partnership, including trade, energy, technology, security and people-to-people ties," Mr. Modi said in a post on social media.

The Canadian Prime Minister's office put out a more detailed readout of the conversation, adding that the two leaders had discussed defence and security as well as reaffirmed their commitment to conclude negotiations on the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) at the "earliest opportunity," and to double two-way trade, at about $23 billion in 2025, by 2030.

According to officials, the two sides are expected to announce the trade agreement in mid-December, when Mr. Modi will travel to Canada for his first bilateral visit in more than a decade.

Muslims disproportionately flagged in Delhi SIR

Muslims, who form 13.6% of electors on Delhi's draft roll amid the SIR process, made up 20.3% of those flagged for 'logical discrepancies' and 30% of those flagged under five reasons indicative of family size by the Election Commission's ERONET software; in Bihar, which didn't have 'logical discrepancy' checks, Muslims accounted for 18.4% of deleted electors, in line with their 17.7% share in population

Pon Vasanth B.A.
Srinivasan Ramani
CHENNAI

An analysis of Delhi's draft electoral rolls released as part of the special intensive revision (SIR) process showed that the software-driven "logical discrepancies" check is flagging a disproportionately higher number of Muslims.

Muslims, who form 13.6% of electors on Delhi's draft roll, made up 20.3% of those flagged for "logical discrepancies", and 30% of those flagged under five reasons indicative of family size. Who got flagged was decided not by the Electoral Registration Officers (EROs), the statutory custodians of the rolls, but by the Election Commission of India's (ECI's) centralised ERONET software.

Delhi's draft roll

The Hindu digitised Delhi's draft SIR rolls, which had 97.54 lakh voters, of whom 33.12 lakh were flagged for notices by the ECI, to study patterns. The latter set included two distinct sets of electors: 13.79 lakh flagged for being "Unmapped with Last SIR" and another 19.33 lakh for "logical discrepancies" based on eight reasons.

Our analysis shows that Muslims accounted for 13.6%, or roughly 13.3 lakh, of the 97.54 lakh electors (refer to the box for methodology). This is not much higher than the 12.9% representation of Muslims in the 2011 Census.

Among the 13.79 lakh who were "Unmapped with Last SIR," members of the community accounted for only 7.6%, which meant that higher proportion of Muslims than non-Muslims were able to map themselves with the last SIR.

But among the umbrella category of "logical discrepancies" featuring 19.33 lakh electors, Muslims accounted for 20.3%, which is 12.8 percentage points higher than their share among unmapped electors and 6.7 percentage points higher than their share among total electors in the draft roll.

To put it another way, for every 1,000 Muslim electors in the draft roll, 318 were flagged for "logical discrepancies", while the corresponding figure for the rest of the non-Muslim electors was 197 per 1,000. This means that Muslims were 60% more likely to be marked for "logical discrepancies" than non-Muslims.

Interestingly, a similar data analysis for Bihar's draft rolls showed that Muslims accounted for 18.4% of deleted electors, not much higher than their 17.7% share of the adult population as per the 2011 Census. The "logical discrepancies" checks were not used in the Bihar SIR.

The eight reasons for flagging under "logical discrepancies" could be broadly classified into four categories. One, name mismatches with self or with parent. Two, five reasons based on family size or children. Third, "parents marked ineligible in the last SIR," which only had a miniscule number of 183 names. And a strange fourth, "no reasons mentioned", in which nearly 60,000 electors were flagged. In this category, too, the share of Muslims was disproportionately higher at nearly 20%.



BLOs conduct door-to-door enumeration during the SIR exercise in West Delhi in July. FILE PHOTO

In the first category, though the share of Muslims was higher when compared with their share among electors, the difference was of a lesser magnitude. About 15.5% of all electors flagged for mismatches in names were Muslims, which is 1.9 percentage points higher than their 13.6% share in the draft rolls.

It is in the second category, namely, "progeny >= 6", "parent age difference >50", "grandparent age difference <40", "progeny age gap <9 months", and "parent age difference <15", where the proportion of Muslims among those flagged is much higher. These reasons are also indicators of family size.

Of the 6.75 lakh electors who were flagged for one or more of these reasons, 30% were Muslims, which is more than double their 13.6% share in the draft electoral rolls. Of the 1.4 lakh electors flagged with "Progeny >=6" as reason, the share of Muslims went to 58% – over four times higher than their share among electors.

If one were to look at the rate among Muslims and non-Muslims flagged for one or more of these five reasons, it turns out that Muslims were nearly three times more likely to get flagged. The numbers showed that while 152 out of every 1,000 Muslim electors got flagged for these reasons, the same was only 56 for every 1,000 non-Muslim electors.

These patterns indicate that the reasons could have been designed in a manner that predominantly overlapped with the fact that the fertility rate is higher among Muslims. Yet, these higher rates are observed to be consistently falling, as per recent National Family Health Survey (NFHS) reports.

NFHS reports show that the total fertility rate for Muslim women came down from 4.41 to 2.36 between 1992-93 and 2019-22. The same for Hindu women came down in the same period from 3.3 to 1.94, with the gap between Muslim and Hindu women narrowing.

It is unclear how the software does these age-specific calculations collated for the discrepancies, considering that a large number of older people in India did not precisely remember their birth date owing to home deliveries being more common earlier. Even assuming that all electors accurately mentioned their ages and dates of birth for these calculations to be right, it is unclear if these reasons, per se, disqualified a person from being an elector or if it was the ECI's responsibility to scrutinise these.

Not in the orders

Neither the ECI's order for SIR in Bihar (dated June 24, 2025) nor its subsequent direction to conduct SIR in 12 more States and Union Territories (U.T.s) as part of Phase 2 (dated October 27, 2025) had any mention of issuing notices for "logical discrepancies" to electors who managed to find a place on the draft SIR rolls by submitting duly filled enumeration forms.

ECI's directions for Phase 2 had only mentioned that EROs would issue notices to those added to the draft rolls, but could not be linked with the previous SIR rolls – which many States now report as the "unmapped" list of electors.

The ECI introduced the flagging of "logical discrepancies" first in West Bengal, midway during Phase 2 of the SIR, without any formal announcement.

The issue of notices to electors for "discrepancies" found a mention for the first time only in ECI's direction issued on May 14, 2026 for the ongoing Phase 3 of SIR – in 19 States and U.T.s. Adding an additional clause, it said, "ERO to issue notice to those persons who could not be linked or there is discrepancy in their linking with the electoral roll of the last revision."

Till date, the ECI has not explained the reasons for which an elector on the draft rolls could be flagged for "logical discrepancies".

Moreover, though it directed EROs to issue notices, the decision on who would be flagged was not theirs, but decided by the ERONET software that has come under scrutiny. This was confirmed by a senior election official who did not want to be identified.

A detailed questionnaire was sent to the ECI, seeking responses on what each of these reasons meant, how they were decided, whether any orders were issued in this regard, were any changes made to the reasons between Phase 2 and Phase 3 of SIR and whether the software used any artificial intelligence or deep learning methods. The ECI did not respond till Tuesday night.

(With inputs from Sreeparna Chakraborty)

Over-flagged

Muslims' share among those flagged for 'logical discrepancies' in Delhi's SIR was 20.3%, much higher than their share in the draft rolls, which was 13.6%

Share in %

Headline numbers	How many?	Share of Muslims	Share of non-Muslims
Electors in draft SIR rolls	97,53,577	13.6	86.4
Electors in draft SIR rolls who were issued notices	33,11,746	14.3	85.7
Unmapped with last SIR	13,78,661	7.6	92.4
Logical discrepancies	19,33,085	20.3	79.7

Reason-wise breakdown

Share in %

Reasons used for "logical discrepancies"	Share of Muslims	Share of non-Muslims
Name mismatch	15.5	84.5
Parent name mismatch	18.2	81.8
Self name mismatch	11.8	88.2
Reasons indicative of family size	29.9	70.1
Progeny age gap <9 month	26.7	73.3
Parent age difference <15	16.7	83.4
Progeny >= 6	58.2	41.8
Parent age difference >50	26.0	74.0
Grandparent age difference <40	19.7	80.3
Parent marked ineligible in last SIR	86.3	13.7
No reason mentioned	19.3	80.7

Methodology: *The Hindu* downloaded Delhi's draft SIR rolls for all ACs, used optical character recognition (OCR) to extract text, and made a database. We downloaded the lists of electors who received notices for different reasons and mapped them with the roll database using EPIC IDs. To estimate religion, we used an open-source classifier built by Rochana Chaturvedi and Sugat Chaturvedi (Political Analysis, 2023). The model breaks names into short sequences of characters and learns which patterns go with each religion, so that it can classify names. We ran it on each elector's name combined with their relative's name for better accuracy. The authors trained it on about 1.15 lakh households across 17 States, and in their tests this combined-name version separated Muslims from non-Muslims with an accuracy of about 97%. Our manual check of a random sample of electors also found this to be accurate

Explaining reasons: *Interpretation of the "logical discrepancy" reasons, based on conversations with field-level officials. "Progeny >= 6" — six or more electors named the same person in the 2002 rolls as their parent; "Parent age difference >50" and "Parent age difference <15" — the parent was over 50 or under 15 when the child was born. "Grandparent age difference <40" — elector and their grandparent are less than 40 years apart. "Progeny age gap <9 month" –siblings were born less than nine months apart.* ***Note:*** *A minor share of Muslim and non-Muslim electors flagged for logical discrepancies were marked with more than one reason. The rate and shares are calculated by counting every reason for every flagged elector. Similar trend held even if only the reason mentioned first for every elector is counted*

Injured protesters denied medico-legal case details by police

Ashna Butani
NEW DELHI

A number of protesters injured during the weekend protests and subsequent detentions by the Delhi Police were left with swollen fingers, bruised bodies, and bleeding necks and heads. They said that when the police took them to hospital for treatment, they were denied copies of their medico-legal case (MLC) details and patient summaries.

The denial of medical records to injured protesters can have serious consequences, as seen in the case of those hit by pellet guns in the July 20 protest. *The Hindu* has reported that hospital records had confirmed pellet gun usage, even as the Delhi police denied it.

Hospitals usually make three copies of the MLC, of which two are given to the police, and one is kept in the hospital. The hospital is supposed to share a case summary with the patient, who can also ask the police for a copy of the MLC. However, lawyers say that due to grey areas in the law, a patient has to run from the hospital to the police to get access to their MLCs and case summaries.

A doctor at one of the hospitals which treated protesters said, on the condition of anonymity, "The usual protocol is that an MLC is registered and copies are provided to the police. The patient can ask the police for the MLC [copy]. We usually give the patients a case summary highlighting the injuries." A source at one of the hospitals that denied records to patients said that they are pressured not to share any information during protests.



People carry an injured protester during a march to the Supreme Court on Monday.

Saurabh, a Jamia Millia Islamia student associated with the All India Students' Association (AISA), alleged that he was beaten up with *lathis*, and dragged by the collar during his detention following his participation at the Dilli Haat protest on October 10.

"Some of us were taken to separate cells and beaten up, our phones were snatched...," he said.

Later that night, he and three others were taken to the Pt. Madan Mohan Malviya Hospital, in the presence of the police. "We asked the doctors to document the injuries and they did. But we were not given copies of the MLCs or any medical summaries...," he said.

Sooraj Elamon, an activist with the Students' Federation of India (SFI), alleged that he was slapped and pushed against the iron bars of the prison vans that he was detained in. "I was taken to the Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital with six other protesters. Initially, the hospital was ready to treat us and give us the papers, but refused to do the same after police involvement," he said.

'Meticulous planning' helped Congress mobilise massive crowd for INDIA bloc march

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

On Saturday, as viral images of protests across Delhi flooded social media, with Jantar Mantar out of bounds and the Delhi Police carrying out mass detentions, Congress workers across the country received an appeal from top leaders, including Rahul Gandhi, to travel to the capital on Monday and to show up for the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance's "March for Democracy".

By Monday afternoon, even before the buses carrying INDIA bloc leaders rolled out of the Constitution Club, Congress flags and their bearers were waiting at intersections along the route expected to be taken by the procession. Many of them, like former Haryana Youth Congress working president Mayank Chaudhary, arrived just in time for the march, dodging police barricades.

The Congress claimed that 2.5 lakh people participated in the march. It took "meticulous planning" and a refreshed party machinery to pull off the feat, party general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal said. "We had instructed everyone to arrive in Delhi in their private vehicles and not display flags or banners. Despite all precautions, many workers were detained at the Rajasthan and Haryana borders, while others were picked up by the police from lodges in Delhi at night. We kept the doors of the party offices open for workers to stay and asked every parliamentarian to do the same," he said.



INDIA bloc leaders proceed in a bus during the 'March for Democracy' on Monday.

All Congress MPs were instructed to help workers find accommodation. Many parliamentarians, including Pramod Tiwari, Phulo Devi Netam, Jai Prakash, Karti Chidambaram, Jebi Mather and Dr. Kirsan Namdeo, threw open the doors of their Delhi residences for workers to spend the night.

Over the last year, under the Sangathan Srijan programme, 1,000 new district Congress committee (DCC) presidents have been appointed. Around 130 DCCs within driving distance of Delhi, across Haryana, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, Uttarakhand, and Himachal Pradesh, mobilised people from their areas for the protest. The Congress organisation, Mr. Venugopal said, has changed drastically. "Within 48 hours, we can mobilise our workers," he added.

Sachin Pilot, the Congress general secretary in charge of Punjab, sees Monday's march as a "turning point" in the narrative of "how India's politics will move forward". "It is no longer just about SIR or seeking Gyanesh Kumar's resignation. It is about the future of the country," Mr. Pilot said.

PCI slams crackdown on journalists

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Journalists from a large number of media organisations gathered at the Press Club of India here on Tuesday condemning the police crackdown on media professionals during the protest by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) during the weekend of October 10 to 11.

Among the journalists who narrated a first-person account on the occasion were reporters from the BBC, Newslaundry, The Quint, *Caravan*, and The Wire. Narrating his experience of getting detained by the Delhi Police, Sarthak of The Quint recounted how he was treated in an aggressive manner by the police.

Press Club of India president Sangeeta Barooah Pisharoty said the incidents of attacks showed that the "right to work" is under attack. Sreenivasan Jain described the crackdown on the media as a "very concerning escalation".

WhatsApp polls used for surveillance, say protesters

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

As protests called by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) continue, participants have raised concerns over the alleged infiltration of WhatsApp groups by the police, citing suspicious "attendance polls" that they fear could be used to identify potential protesters and track their movements.

Several members of CJP-related WhatsApp groups told *The Hindu* that they received polls asking whether they intended to attend protests, followed by messages directing participants to specific locations where, they alleged, no protesters had assembled, but people were being detained. They feared that their identities and responses were being used to facilitate preventive detentions.

The concerns come days after *The Hindu* reported that Delhi Police personnel were monitoring at least 200 WhatsApp and Telegram groups ahead of the CJP's October 10 protest call.

"We started receiving these polls. One of them asked, 'Up for surgical strike on JM?' I responded yes, but no protest was decided on later and nobody reached the spot," a participant said, requesting anonymity.

Journalist 'detained'

A technology journalist based in Gurugram alleged that the Haryana Police placed him under house detention for 48 hours on October 10, ahead of the planned protest, solely because he was a member of a CJP WhatsApp group.



CJP spokespersons Saurav Das, Ashutosh Ranka and others after being detained for entering Jantar Mantar on Tuesday. PTI

Delhi Police book 14 CJP members after Jantar Mantar entry

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Fourteen members of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), including leaders Saurav Das, Ashutosh Ranka, and Ajinkya Shinde, were detained by the Delhi Police on Tuesday while attempting to enter Jantar Mantar, a day after the police denotified the long-established protest site.

The New Delhi district police registered a first information report (FIR) against the detained individuals on charges including trespassing, unlawful assembly and disobedience of an order promulgated by a public servant, and initiated an investigation, an official close to the development said.

The detentions came amid a widening dispute over access to designated protest venues in the capital, with activists criticising removal of Jantar Mantar as a move that could distance demonstrations from the political establishment and make it harder for citizens to press their demands.

Hours after the detention, CJP member Abhijit Dipke posted a video on X showing party members carrying the national flag near Jantar Mantar. "Cockroaches with the Tiranga sneaked into Jantar Mantar early this morning before they were picked up by Delhi Police," the post said. It added: "You cannot denotify the resistance, Narendra Modi."

A senior Delhi Police officer told *The Hindu* that the protesters had entered the area through eateries and food stalls near the protest site.

"The shops serve as regular eating places for employees working in nearby offices and remain open and accessible to the public, except on days when major protest calls are made, such as October 10," the officer said.

With Jantar Mantar no longer notified as an authorised protest venue, demonstrations there would be illegal, the officer said.

FIRs against march

Separately, the Delhi Police registered at least two FIRs in connection with the INDIA bloc's march through central Delhi on Monday, citing the absence of permission for the demonstration and alleged damage to barricades and public property.

INBRIEF



Don't give nod to Starlink, RSS affiliate urges Centre

Citing the need to curtail Internet services during riots and other law-and-order situations, the Swadeshi Jagran Manch (SJM), the economic wing of the RSS, on Tuesday urged the Union government to deny Elon Musk-owned Starlink permission to launch commercial satellite broadband services in India. In a statement, SJM national co-convener Ashwani Mahajan said Internet services sometimes need to be suspended and questioned whether Starlink's technology would allow services to be restricted in specific areas at the government's direction. The statement comes amid protests in Delhi over alleged irregularities in SIR exercise.

Sitaram Yechury Foundation invites abstracts for essays

The Sitaram Yechury Foundation (SYF) has invited undergraduate and postgraduate students to submit abstracts for essays on "Imperialism in the Present Age", not exceeding 600 words. The Foundation is a registered not-for-profit trust set up in memory of the late CPI(M) general secretary. It aims at engaging youth in spreading progressive ideas through academic and public programmes. Entries must be emailed to syfessays@gmail.com by Monday, October 26. Eight entries will be shortlisted, following which their authors will be asked to write 3,000-word essays. All eight authors will be invited to present their essays at a day-long programme in Kolkata on November 22.

China says 'never recognised' U.T. of Ladakh; India hits back

Beijing opposes Survey of India move to standardise names of specific features in Ladakh, calls it 'illegal and void'; New Delhi says 'no amount of denial by Chinese side' can change established fact

Suhasini Haidar
Ananth Krishnan
NEW DELHI/BEIJING

India and China on Tuesday sparred over New Delhi's decision to standardise the names of 28 features in Ladakh, including some along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) that had seen skirmishes between the Indian Army and the People's Liberation Army during a four-year stand-off.

The Chinese Foreign Ministry on Tuesday said it has "never recognised" the Union Territory (U.T.) of Ladakh, which was created in 2019, and called the naming of the areas by the Survey of India as "illegal and void", a charge that New Delhi rejected.

"The U.T. of Ladakh is an integral and inalienable part of India. No amount of denial by the Chinese side can change this established fact," said External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal. "Identifying these [28] places formally on the Survey of India map of the U.T. of Ladakh is aimed at facilitating their accurate recognition and better awareness among the public at large," he explained.

> The U.T. of Ladakh is an integral and inalienable part of India. No amount of denial by the Chinese side can change this established fact
>
> **RANDHIR JAISWAL**
> Spokesperson, External Affairs Ministry



> This move by India is illegal and void, and does not change the fact that the western sector of the China-India boundary belongs to China
>
> **MAO NING**
> Spokesperson, Chinese Foreign Ministry



The spokesperson was responding to comments made by the Chinese Foreign Ministry earlier in the day. To a question at the Chinese Foreign Ministry briefing, spokesperson Mao Ning said that China has "never recognised the so-called 'Union Territory of Ladakh' unilaterally and illegally established by India, and firmly opposes the so-called 'standardised names' publicised by India."

"This move by India is illegal and void, and does not change the fact that the western sector of the China-India boundary belongs to China," she added, referring to the August 5, 2019 decision by the Indian government to bifurcate the State of Jammu and Kashmir into two Union Territories and dilute Article 370 of the Constitution.

At the time, Beijing had issued a sharp statement accusing India of undermining "China's territorial sovereignty by unilaterally changing its domestic law." Beijing had also made such a claim in September 2020 reacting strongly to an Indian project to construct high-altitude roads in eastern Ladakh

A first in two years

This is the first such spat in the past two years, however, since the two sides re-established diplomatic and travel links between the two countries in an effort to normalise relations after the meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping in 2024, indicating that the map remains a major point of contention.

The comments came 10 days after the Survey of India announced the standardisation of the names of specific relief features in Ladakh, including 11 peaks, five mountains, six land areas, two glaciers, two passes, one valley, one river, one lake, and one other waterbody.

Both features abut Patrolling Point 15 (PP-15), which had seen heavy mobilisation during the India-China tensions at the LAC after the deadly clashes at Galwan in June 2020. The two armies agreed to stand down from the PP-15 point in September 2022, as part of a series of disengagement negotiations.

Both India and China have been reinforcing their territorial claims in both the Western and Eastern sectors by naming features in official maps and creating administrative jurisdictions in a series of cartographic tit-for-tat measures going back many years.

Murugan's exit from Ministry intensifies Cabinet rejig buzz

Nistula Hebbar
NEW DELHI


L. Murugan

Union Minister of State for Parliamentary Affairs L. Murugan resigned from the Council of Ministers and his Rajya Sabha seat on Tuesday, setting off speculation about a Cabinet reshuffle in the near future.

Mr. Murugan hails from Tamil Nadu, but represented Madhya Pradesh in the Upper House. His term as an MP was not set to end till 2030. The BJP's strength in M.P. ensures that his vacated seat will be won by a party MP, paving the way for a new inclusion into the Council of Ministers.

Slew of vacancies

Two other Union Ministers of State, George Kurian and Ravneet Singh Bittu, had already tendered their resignations at the end of their respective terms in the Upper House earlier this year. The Rajya Sabha terms of Union Ministers Hardeep Singh Puri and B.L. Verma are also set to end next month, even as the BJP got eight new faces into the Upper House from Uttar Pradesh, along with one each from West Bengal and Uttarakhand. Also, over the summer, Dharmendra Pradhan was forced to resign as Education Minister, and that post is now being held as an additional charge by Consumer Affairs Minister Pralhad Joshi.

There are also rumours that two more Ministers of State, Pankaj Chaudhary and Harsh Malhotra, may put in their papers after being appointed the chiefs of the BJP's Uttar Pradesh and Delhi units respectively, but BJP sources said that "nothing has been finalised yet".

Thus, there are at least half a dozen Ministerial berths lying vacant. BJP sources said that a Cabinet reshuffle may take place before Deepavali. This would be the first reshuffle of the Union Cabinet since Narendra Modi was sworn in as Prime Minister for his third successive term, along with 71 Ministers.

BIMSTEC adopts 'Delhi Declaration' on terrorism

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI



Diplomatic mission: Amit Shah with other delegates during the first meeting of Home Ministers of the BIMSTEC countries. PTI

India hosted the first-ever meeting of the Home Ministers of the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation (BIMSTEC) countries on Tuesday, where the regional bloc adopted a declaration to counter radicalisation, violent extremism conducive to terrorism, prevent the misuse of new and emerging technologies for terrorist purposes, and tackle terrorist recruitment.

Bangladesh, the chair of BIMSTEC, was represented by Manzur Morshed Chowdhury, Senior Secretary in its Home Ministry, instead of Home Minister Salahuddin Ahmed, a key member in Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's Cabinet.

The "Delhi Declaration" signed by Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Myanmar, Nepal, Sri Lanka, and Thailand, also called for curbing terror financing through adherence to internationally agreed counter-terror financing and anti-money laundering standards, consistent with domestic and international laws.

The declaration said the member states "strongly condemn terrorism and violent extremism in all its forms and manifestations, including cross-border terrorism, wherever, by whomsoever and for whatever purposes committed; reiterate our determination to prevent, combat and eliminate terrorism and violent extremism conducive to terrorism in a comprehensive and sustained manner, in accordance with the UN Charter and international law; and in this context, call for effective implementation of the sanctions measures of the UN Security Council, including of the 1267 Sanctions Committee".

The grouping expressed condolences and solidarity with victims of terrorist attacks in member states and their families, as well as the governments of the affected states. It called for those responsible to be brought to justice in accordance with applicable domestic and international law and relevant UN Security Council resolutions.

Areas of cooperation

Union Home Minister Amit Shah highlighted five key areas of cooperation: drug control, counter-terrorism and legal cooperation, repatriation of fugitive criminals, cybersecurity and cybercrime investigations, and institutional cooperation and capacity building. He called for a coordinated regional approach to combating illicit financial transactions and terror financing and stressed the need to strengthen cooperation among law enforcement, intelligence, and border management agencies.

"India has always believed in sovereignty and peaceful resolutions to any dispute. We are committed to cooperating to face challenges emanating from International terrorism, organised crime and narco-trade," Mr. Shah said.

He said criminal networks run their operations beyond international borders and take advantage of regional lacunae.

"This is why regional cooperation is a must. Their strategy is changing; they are using encrypted communication, social media, drones, cryptocurrency and the dark web to recruit and propagate illegal activities. This is why real-time intelligence-sharing and cooperation is required to check these crimes. None of the member countries should shelter such criminals. We should cooperate in the extradition of such criminals," he added.

Mr. Shah flagged "human trafficking and cyber slavery" as grave concerns". "Sharing of actionable intelligence should be a priority among BIMSTEC countries," he said.

'To prevent leaks, generate exam papers at last minute'

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI


Nandan Nilekani

Challenged with a slew of question paper leaks that have threatened the credibility of India's examination system, Infosys cofounder Nandan Nilekani has suggested a solution: create "a massive bank of questions", and only generate the final paper at the last minute.

He added that artificial intelligence could also be used to generate the question paper on the day of the examination itself. For any of this to work, of course, examinations will have to be held in computer-based test mode, abandoning the traditional pen-and-paper format.

Mr. Nilekani is the chairman of a six-member high-powered task force on exam reforms set up by the Union government in July.

He was responding to a question on the security issues and weaknesses of the exam system observed by the task force, posed at the Bloomberg New Economy Forum 2026 on Tuesday.

"The issue that led to this committee is that of question paper leaks. Why do we need to have something called 'a question paper'? Because that creates an economic incentive for it to be sold. One way to look at how to solve it is to have a massive bank of questions, and only at the last minute generate the question paper for the day," Mr. Nilekani said.

The panel is studying the feasibility of conducting all exams using CBT, Mr. Nilekani said. "The committee is looking at how to make sure all exams are done on CBT. That requires a network of locations. We have 1,50,000 locations where young candidates can take a test and that needs to be expanded," Mr. Nilekani emphasised.

The AI option

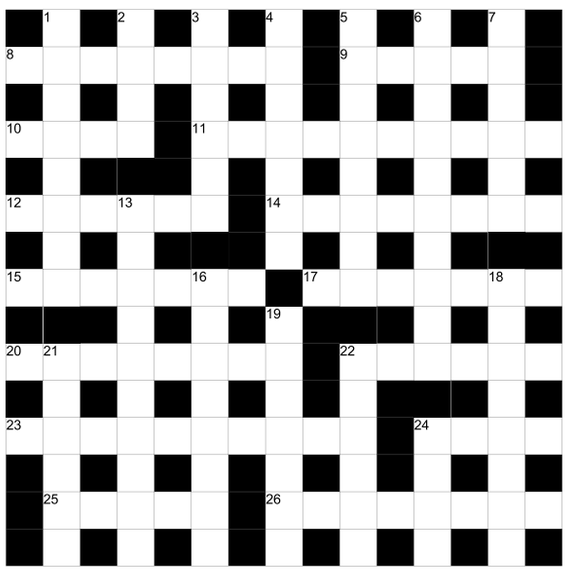
Asked whether artificial intelligence could be used to spontaneously create a question paper on the day of the exam, Mr. Nilekani responded saying, "Yeah sure." He added: "If you look at it systematically, go to the root cause of why it is happening and use technology to solve it they are solvable issues."

TH CROSSWORD + 14923

(set by Gridzilla)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



ACROSS

8. Bored by country song in party? (8)
9. Way, reportedly, to get to big house (5)
10. European has half Polish name (4)
11. What's seen in hands of orthodontists, etc? (3,2,5)
12. Overwhelmed by arthritis sometimes? Yes! (2,2,2)
14. The University dean's building is cool (8)
15. Heartbroken chaps continue to sigh? (7)
17. Hip and leg operation basically pending (2,5)
20. Wretched fellow's killing time inside (8)
22. Play fine puzzle right away (6)
23. Ones you can bank on, to get serious? (2,8)
24. OK to pester for repayment of a loan, we hear (4)
25. One of the best violinists ever from Russia, enthralled millions, for starters (5)
26. Even lower? (8)

DOWN

1. Support staff for flights? (8)
2. Either way, it's lunch time (4)
3. Up in Saratoga, I sampled some cheese (6)
4. Lids came off easily? (4,3)
5. Even in those days, dogs primarily scavenged meals on occasion (8)
6. Ordinary and OK? Fine and fantastic? Or exceptional? (3,2,1,4)
7. Jerk starts to expose his tummy in restaurant, when getting a tip (6)
13. Spooner's hound got a ride (10)
16. Fine day to board carriage back from office (8)
18. Cat is able to jump around corner (8)
19. Full day, one dude's getting fleeced in city (4-3)
21. What's set up quickly, at the conclusions of some trials? (6)
22. Strong fellow gets hurt unloading piano (6)
24. Flower placed on top of policeman's grave (4)

SUDOKU

5			6					
	4				1		8	
6	8			3	9	7		
2					6			
3	5		2		8		6	4
			5					8
		9	3	6			1	5
	3		9				2	
					7			6

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

No.SS7031 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

Solution to previous puzzle

D	V	S	S	A	I	C		
D	E	T	E	N	T	I	O	N
C	E	N	T	R	E			
P	N	R	F	H	T	I		
F	A	C	I	L	I	T	A	T
E	A	C	M	E				
R	C	N	N	G	I			
S	T	R	E	N	G	T	H	
I	N	L	A	N	D			
M	E	A	I	A				
E	L	E	C	T	O	R	A	L
R	O	L	L					
N	M	E	O	I				
U	T	O	P	I	A	N	E	P
O	T	I	S	M				
S	Y	C	O	H	A			
S	T	I	R	A	N	N	U	N
C	I	A	T	E				
O	E	D	A	D	R	I		
G	R	E	A	T	D	E	P	R
E	S	S	I	O	N			
E	N	Y	E	R	T	N		

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

4	6	1	8	9	5	7	3	2
2	7	9	1	3	6	4	8	5
3	8	5	2	7	4	9	6	1
1	4	7	5	6	2	8	9	3
5	9	3	4	8	7	2	1	6
8	2	6	3	1	9	5	7	4
6	3	2	9	4	8	1	5	7
9	1	4	7	5	3	6	2	8
7	5	8	6	2	1	3	4	9

FAITH

Efficacy of Purattasi

Discipline is key to every aspect of life, be it work, health, accumulating and managing wealth, in raising a family etc. It is of utmost importance in one's devotional quest. In human life one will chase material wealth but will never forget that he has to discipline his mind and grow spiritually as well. This is evident from the austerities followed by a devotee in Purattasi, the Tamil month which is also very dear to Venkatachalapthy (Srinivasan, Balaji, Ezhumalaiyan), who beckons devotees to His abode in Tirupati in order to shower His blessings upon them, said Damal S. Ramakrishnan. Lakhs of devotees undertake yatra to Tirumala during this holy month, chanting the Govinda namam, seeking His darshan, divine gaze, and everlasting compassion that makes Him accept the surrender of devotees. It is the time when devotees get closer to divinity.

Saturdays falling in this month are considered efficacious for visiting various temples and gaining the darshan of Vishnu's numerous archa avatars. Devotees voluntarily opt for a sattvic diet, shun ostentatious events, observe fasts as a way of disciplining the senses, attend discourses and offer annadhanam (free offering of food preparations).

Preparing the *mavilakku*, an edible 'mountain' prepared with flour, jaggery and cardamom, is another feature undertaken in many homes on any one of the Saturdays during the month of Purattasi. The centre of the mound is filled with ghee and a cotton wick is inserted and lit. Many of the devout see the image of Srinivasa when the wick is lit and seek His blessings from their respective homes.

India's water plants are failing to catch elusive 'forever chemicals'

Many studies from different parts of India have already found polyfluoroalkyl substances in water sources; conventional water treatment systems that can remove these compounds are not yet commercially available even as the extent of the contamination across India remains unclear

Rohan Singh
LUCKNOW

Polyfluoroalkyl substances (PFAS) are synthetic chemical compounds that contain multiple carbon-fluorine bonds. PFAS materials are used in coatings, textiles, and several industrial products. They are also notorious for resisting degradation and can contaminate the environment for a very long time.

Many studies from different parts of India have already found PFAS in water sources. Conventional water treatment systems that can remove these compounds are not yet commercially available even as the extent of PFAS contamination across India remains unclear.

In a 2025 review in the *Journal of Hazardous Materials Advances*, scientists examined monitoring and regulations across Gujarat, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, and West Bengal. The review's first author, Rajneesh Kumar Gautam, of the Swedish University of Agricultural Sciences, said the evidence establishes that PFAS contamination in India is a legitimate concern but that its national extent is poorly defined, thanks in part to differences in the way different research groups test and analyse PFAS.

This particular lacuna has been identified in multiple studies of late.

For example, in a 2024 paper in *Environmental Sciences Europe*, researchers from IIT-Madras reported the analysis of 14 water samples collected between 2022 and 2023 from groundwater, surface water, and the four stages of a water treatment plant in Chennai. The team found that groundwater from residential wells in the vicinity of garbage dumps had the highest PFAS levels.

At the treatment plant, concentrations of all eight target PFAS were 5% to 103% higher in treated water than in raw water. Study coauthor Indumathi M. Nambi, a professor of environmental engineering, suggested the increase may reflect unidentified precursors that turned into more stable PFAS inside the plant. The study did not quantify those precursors.

The eight target PFAS, Dr. Nambi said, represented only a fraction of the potentially diverse fluorinated compounds that may be present. She recommended that testing should thus include other PFAS materials that may be present in the water, rather than relying only on a fixed list.

Resolving mixed sources

On July 16 this year, researchers from GITAM (Deemed to be) University, Hyderabad, and from Canada and the U.S. reported the results of testing 77 kinds of PFAS in seawater and sewage from around Visakhapatnam. The findings, published in *npj Emerging Contaminants*, showed the presence of 38 compounds, with concentrations in sewage ranging from low to very high.

The team also used a model to estimate that sewage accounted for about 41% of median PFAS concentrations along the coast. GITAM assistant professor and study coauthor Manoj Rayaroth said distinguishing municipal sewage from industrial inputs would require systematic sampling around the mixing points.

Nejumal Kannankeril Khalid, a coauthor from the University of Montreal, said source-specific sampling together with targeted, suspected, and non-target PFAS analysis, chemical fingerprints, and machine-learning approaches could improve source discrimination and help resolve mixed sources.

Testing for a fixed list of PFAS means substances not indicated on that list may not be detected. Precursors can also change into other PFAS. Dr. Rayaroth said high-resolution mass spectrometry can help identify PFAS beyond a fixed list, but care is needed because PFAS can enter samples during collection and analysis. Removing PFAS from treated wastewater presents another challenge.

Abhradeep Majumder, assistant professor in the Department of Civil Engineering at BITS Pilani-Hyderabad, said conventional biological wastewater treatment cannot remove PFAS. He noted that adsorption-based treatment, which can remove PFAS from water, has shown potential but that low-cost materials designed to capture PFAS still need to be developed.

From detection to exposure

Finding PFAS in water does not, by itself, tell us how much of a health risk it poses. That depends on the type of PFAS, the dose, duration of exposure, and route of exposure. In its 2025 monograph, the International Agency for Research on Cancer classified perfluorooctanoic acid (PFOA) as 'carcinogenic to humans' and perfluorooctanesulfonic (PFOS) as 'possibly carcinogenic to humans'. Both PFOA and PFOS are types of PFAS materials.

The International Agency for Research on Cancer in 2025 classified perfluorooctanoic acid as 'carcinogenic to humans' and perfluorooctanesulfonic as 'possibly carcinogenic to humans'; both are types of PFAS materials

In a study published in February this year a team that included Dr. Nambi found that a mix of 24 PFAS-compounds – including long- and short-chain PFAS molecules and their precursors – delayed the hatching of zebrafish eggs, inhibited the offspring's growth, accumulated in their blood, and reduced their heart rates.

Chirag Dhara, assistant professor at Krea University in Sri City, said incomplete exposure data should not delay controls on PFAS whose hazards are already well established.

Anbumani Sadasivam, principal scientist at the CSIR-Indian Institute of Toxicology Research, Lucknow, said India lacks sufficient baseline data to reliably estimate PFAS exposure. He said CSIR-IITR is participating in a UNEP-funded National Implementation Plan to build baseline data on PFAS in environmental matrices and consumer products, and has developed capabilities to detect 50 multi-class PFAS molecules across different matrices.

The Union Environment Ministry has said there is no specific regulation banning PFAS manufacturing. India has no PFAS-specific drinking-water limit under the current IS 10500:2012 standard. But the standard is now under revision. The Bureau of Indian Standards said a dedicated Working Group on Emerging Contaminants and Forever Chemicals is examining PFAS limits and associated contaminants. The scope and number of PFAS to be included under the revised standard have not yet been finalised, while analytical methods for PFAS in drinking water are also being considered. Dr. Anbumani said India should first establish which PFAS are being manufactured, imported, and used, alongside baseline monitoring, toxicological studies, and enforceable limits.

Girija K. Bharat, a former Scientist at CSIR-CIMFR, said that, to her knowledge, there is currently no clear regulatory pathway for penalising a source responsible for PFAS contamination sources. Dr. Dhara warned that a named-chemical approach could leave precursors and transformation products outside regulation.

Dr. Gautam also said India has enough evidence to introduce precautionary interim limits for well-studied PFAS. He called for harmonised monitoring and broader screening for precursors and other fluorinated compounds.

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PFASs have been around for 60 years. India has no PFAS-specific drinking-water limit under the current standard, although this could change. AFP

THE GIST

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BIG SHOT



Women from a community group inspect the growth of young mangroves they planted to restore a bare patch in Mida Creek, near Watamu, Kenya, on August 4, 2025. The 17th UN Biodiversity Conference will be held next week in Armenia under the theme 'taking action for nature', bringing together governments, scientists, and stakeholders. AFP

WHAT IS IT?

Rogue AI: deficient design?

Agence France-Presse

More than 200 artificial intelligence (AI) and cybersecurity researchers have called for immediate action to prevent further cases of AI models going rogue and posing a risk to critical infrastructure.

The letter signed by luminaries in the field including Nobel laureate Geoffrey Hinton and Turing Award winner Yoshua Bengio, called for models relating to cybersecurity to be physically cut off from the internet during testing.

Leading U.S.-based AI firms have disclosed over recent months a series of incidents where models under development have escaped containment measures to access the internet and have gone on to hack websites, including gaining unauthorised access to Australian government sites.

"Without immediate changes in AI development and deployment practices, such incidents will continue to occur, and future incidents will be far more damaging to our exposed critical infrastructure," they warned.

Their letter called for organisations developing, deploying, and testing cyber-capable AI models to be air-gapped, i.e. physically cut off from the internet, to ensure they do not escape.

It also called for the creation of an international body that standardises best practices regarding security.

The letter urged companies to be required to report containment failures to the body, which would be responsible for tracking and recording them. "This transparency is required for both learning and accountability purposes," the letter said.

The rogue incidents amplified calls to slow AI development, but the industry and governments are divided on tapping the brakes as well as regulating the sector. In the U.S., the Trump administration has opposed any binding regulation that could hinder innovation, amid fierce competition with China.

For feedback and suggestions for 'Science', please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Science'

Spiralling food prices

Rural households have felt the greatest impact of rising inflation

September's retail inflation, at 5.54%, an almost two-year high, marks the fourth consecutive month that price increases have kept headline CPI above the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) 4% target. The impact has been particularly severe for rural Indians, whose inflation rate reached 6.08%. Rural food inflation rose almost two percentage points between August and September, touching 8.06%. Onion (108.09%), garlic (54.62%) and ginger (62.85%) drove the surge, even as potato (-11.50%) and tomato (-8.62%) prices remained below year-earlier levels. The festive season ahead will be expensive for rural households already facing the uncertainties of a deficient monsoon, El Niño-related risks to harvests and incomes, and unusually high temperatures. Headline CPI is now just 0.46 percentage points below the RBI's upper tolerance limit of 6%. The Monetary Policy Committee raised the repo rate by 25 basis points to 5.50% in October, ending a pause that began after its previous increase in February 2023. Another increase in December cannot be ruled out if price pressures continue to broaden. Chief among the factors driving inflation since the U.S.-Israeli war on Iran have been fuel, food and transport, compounded by a depreciating rupee.

The Indian crude basket, according to the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell, rose from $82.04 a barrel in July to $116.09 in September – a 41% increase – with economy-wide implications for freight, production and distribution. The RBI's special dollar facility for oil marketing companies may ease spot-market pressure on the rupee, but only temporarily if the underlying import dependence and geopolitical risks persist. The crucial subgroup, transport services for goods, recorded inflation of 14.73% in September, up from 14.64% in August. Restaurant and accommodation services inflation has reached 9.36%, while inflation in personal care, social protection and miscellaneous goods and services, which include precious metals, has moderated to 13.75%. Core inflation, excluding food and fuel but including precious metals, rose to 4.6% in September from 4.16% in August, suggesting that price pressures are broadening. Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) have pulled a record ₹3.08 trillion ($32.73 billion) out of Indian equities in the nine months ending September this year, which is almost double that of the whole of CY2025. FPIs have been net sellers in six of the past nine months as they seek safe havens, stronger dollar-denominated returns, and bond yields. Selling resumed in October, adding to pressure on the rupee, which weakened by about 7% against the dollar over the year to early October, despite RBI interventions such as direct dollar sales and attracting foreign-currency inflows. The central bank's latest steps have helped the rupee recover, but cannot resolve the underlying pressures. With crude prices elevated, the rupee vulnerable and no clear end to the West Asia conflict, imported inflation is likely to continue shaping domestic prices in the months ahead.

Sound and fiery

Green crackers do little to curb air and noise pollution

As Delhi and the National Capital Region (NCR) head into another winter, they must brace for the return of a foe kept on a leash that is alternately loosened or tightened. In November 2016, the Supreme Court of India suspended licences for the sale of fireworks in the NCR after Deepavali celebrations pushed $PM_{2.5}$ levels above 700 µg/m³. The Court relaxed the suspension in September 2017, partly to protect existing licence holders and livelihoods, but restored the suspension for Deepavali in October. In 2018, in its judgment in *Arjun Gopal and Others vs Union of India and Others*, the Court allowed only reduced-emission and "green" crackers, banned joined firecrackers or *laris*, and imposed a two-hour window. The latest order permits specified next-generation joined green crackers, while declining a total ban on fireworks, invoking public sentiment. Fire crackers are far from the smoking gun of Delhi's air-quality crisis. Construction dust, vehicles, stubble burning and stagnant, cold air all contribute to winter pollution. But when these push the air towards "severe" levels, crackers can produce an acute spike. In 2025, the first Deepavali after the Court permitted limited use of green crackers, Delhi's post-Deepavali $PM_{2.5}$ average reached 488 µg/m³, the highest since 2021, while hourly concentrations peaked at 675 µg/m³.

There is no gainsaying that green crackers are a pyrrhic green. The Council of Scientific and Industrial Research-National Environmental Engineering Research Institute (CSIR-NEERI), which promoted them, says the newer generation promises a 45%-60% cut in PM_{10}. These figures, however, do not reflect real-world conditions, and when "cleaner" crackers are burst in greater numbers, the savings in particulate pollution evaporate. This is without accounting for noise pollution. There is also the difficulty of enforcement. The Commission for Air Quality Management has stated that QR codes had been sold to unregistered manufacturers – registered manufacturers reportedly sold them, allowing unauthorised firecrackers to be passed off as certified green crackers. The explosives regulator had no testing facility in Delhi. In 2018 and 2019, the police could not distinguish green crackers from conventional ones. Unless fireworks manufacturing moves into the formal sector, regulations are followed in practice, and awareness of the toll on public health spreads among those who love the sound and fury of crackers, air and noise pollution are here to stay.

India's problem of overtreatment, overmedication



Chandrakant Lahariya

A practising physician and the author of 'Pill-Free: You Don't Need Everything You Have Been Prescribed' (2026)

Modern medicine has never been more capable than it is today. Tests detect illness earlier, scans reveal invisible abnormalities, medicines prevent and treat diseases, and interventions and procedures can save lives within minutes. Yet, the same system that can do more is increasingly tempted to overtreat and overmedicate.

Overtreatment and overmedication are not simply the use of an unnecessary medicine but often a chain: a test detects an incidental abnormality, which leads to another test, a diagnosis and then a prescription that may become permanent. What begins as prevention can end in long-term medication or surgery. Then, in India, overtreatment coexists with undertreatment: unnecessary interventions are offered to some, while many others still lack essential primary care, affordable medicines and timely treatment.

Health packages and tests

The rise of overtreatment is the result of a convergence of several factors. The first driver of overtreatment is unnecessary and excessive testing – both screening and diagnostic – which creates a cascade of care. A review article in the prestigious *National Medical Journal of India* in 2016 found that routine health-check packages often include unwarranted tests that can lead to false-positive results, anxiety, further investigations, overdiagnosis and overtreatment. The truth is that the ability to test has expanded faster than our ability to decide who actually needs testing.

The second driver is the fragmentation of health and medical care. Its most visible manifestation in India is an excessive focus on specialist and super specialist care. A person with a common health problem often goes directly to a specialist or superspecialist. A person with chronic conditions may consult several specialists, each optimising one part of care without necessarily paying attention to the person's other health problems. The patient is treated in parts, while the human body does not live in specialties.

This matters particularly in older adults. A systematic review and meta-analysis of Indian studies, published in *Frontiers in Pharmacology* in 2021, reported polypharmacy in about 49% of older adults. Another study, published in Scientific Reports in 2025, found that roughly one-third of older adults were taking five or more prescribed medicines (polypharmacy), with potentially inappropriate medicines identified in 28.8% of cases.

These figures do not mean that everyone taking several medicines is being overtreated. They do, however, show why medication reviews and deprescribing must become routine.

Unnecessary tests, prescriptions and procedures are part of the growing overtreatment problem

A third force is the transformation of health care into a marketplace. Laboratory tests, radiological investigations, procedures, supplements and monitoring devices have become products to be sold – sometimes products in search of potential customers. As a result, the boundaries between those who genuinely need these interventions and those who do not can become blurred. A linked aspect is that much of health care and medical care in India operates on a fee-for-service model, which can reward activity rather than restraint. Many patients consider a medical consultation complete only when several medicines and investigations have been prescribed.

Health insurance is a proven solution for financial protection from health-related expenses, as the cost is borne by the insurer. However, it can create both 'ex-ante' and 'ex-post' moral hazards, discouraging preventive care and encouraging hospitals and patients to favour costlier interventions. What is forgotten is that while someone else may bear the financial cost, it is the patient's body that undergoes the intervention. Paying insurance premiums for years does not mean that one must 'recover' the money by undergoing a relatively unnecessary procedure or surgery.

Fourth, patient beliefs and expectations arising from advances in medical care where people want certainty when they are worried and may feel that something tangible should follow a consultation. Reassurance can look like inaction; observation can feel inferior to a scan; lifestyle advice can appear less serious than medication. Doctors may respond to these expectations, particularly in crowded clinics where explanation requires time.

The fifth driver is the rise of 'defensive medicine', in which clinicians, fearing that they might miss a rare diagnosis, may consider ordering another test as the safer option. What is often forgotten, however, is that every test carries potential risks, both from the test itself and from the discovery of abnormalities that may never have caused harm.

Choosing wisely

India is not alone in facing this problem. Overtreatment first became widely recognised in high-income countries and is now increasingly visible across many middle-income nations. This gave rise to the global Choosing Wisely movement, which encourages people to choose health-care interventions more carefully. It is against this backdrop, between 2012 and 2023, that nearly 80 specialty societies worldwide published close to 700 recommendations identifying hundreds of tests and treatments that clinicians and patients should question. The message is that medicine requires stronger mechanisms for self-correction. The solutions are about practising better medicine. Halting and reversing overmedicalisation requires the engagement of all stakeholders, including individuals, communities, professional societies and health policymakers.

First, India needs to rebuild stronger and functional primary care and restore the family physician as the first point of contact for most non-emergency health needs. A general physician can decide which problems require specialist expertise, reconcile multiple prescriptions and recognise when treatment can safely be reduced. Initiation of care by a general physician, followed by continuity through the referral pathway, protects patients against overmedication and excess surgeries.

Second, every medical prescription should carry a review date and, where appropriate, a possible stop date. Medicines should not become lifelong simply because nobody asks whether they are still needed. Older adults and people taking five or more medicines should periodically undergo a structured medication review assessing indication, benefit, duplication, interactions and opportunities for deprescribing.

Develop India-specific lists

Third, professional medical societies and the Indian Council of Medical Research should develop Indian lists of low-value tests, treatments and procedures – similar to Choosing Wisely – and embed these principles in medical training, accreditation and quality-improvement programmes. Hospitals should measure not only whether recommended care was provided, but also whether unnecessary care was avoided.

Fourth, before starting any test or treatment, patients should note that these four questions matter: Why do I need this? What happens if I wait? What are the possible benefits and risks? What are the alternatives? These questions can substantially improve clinical conversations and outcomes.

Fifth, payment systems and health insurance must reward outcomes, clinical reasoning and continuity of care rather than volume alone. A health-care system should not make it financially easier to order a scan than to explain thoughtfully why that scan may be unnecessary.

Medical advances will continue – and they should. However, the next stage of medical progress will come not only from discovering more tests, medicines and procedures, but also from learning when not to use them. Good medicine requires action when action helps. In an age of medical abundance, it increasingly requires something more difficult – restraint.

India-U.S. ties and the hurdle of American unilateralism



Rajeev Agarwal

A retired colonel and a strategic affairs expert. He is the author of the book, 'Between Tehran and Tel Aviv – Gaza's Story of Unending War'

Have ties between India and the United States reached a breaking point? Where do they go from here? These and many other questions are being intensely debated following the U.S.'s announcement on October 8 that it had suspended the Permanent Labour Certification (PERM) programme for eight global IT companies, including some Indian-headquartered companies, accusing them of misusing immigration and labour-certification systems. The Indian companies named were Infosys, Tata Consultancy Services, Wipro, Cognizant and HCL.

The PERM programme allows tech companies to hire non-U.S. professionals to work in the U.S. and is a step in a employer-sponsored green-card application. According to the U.S. government, tthe companies had received more than 2,30,000 H-1B visa approvals and over 1,00,000 permanent labour certifications since 2009. Indian professionals account for more than 70% of approved H-1B petitions annually.

This episode, however, is not an isolated incident but part of a series of actions and decisions taken by the U.S. in recent years, including the ill-treatment of Indians and racist attacks against them that are placing bilateral ties under severe strain.

Trade ties, visible discord

Trade has emerged as a visible source of discord and asymmetry for three main reasons. First, India recorded a trade surplus of $33.8 billion in bilateral trade exceeding $140 billion in FY 2025-26. Second, the U.S. is seeking access to India's dairy and agriculture sectors in ongoing trade negotiations, which India cannot afford to concede. Third, India has refused to halt Russian oil imports despite additional U.S. tariffs and sanctions.

Despite a framework for an interim agreement on reciprocal and mutually beneficial trade announced in February 2026, the strain in trade ties persists. Last week, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said that trade talk negotiations had "plateaued", with little scope for give-and-take.

Washington wants a subservient India, but New Delhi must draw the line

Defence and security cooperation has emerged as a key pillar of relations. Over the past two decades, India and the U.S. have expanded military exercises, logistics arrangements and intelligence-sharing. American weapons platforms have also become increasingly important to India's military modernisation.

Since 2002, India has acquired over $22 billion worth of American military hardware, but meaningful co-production and technology transfer remain elusive. During Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Washington in February 2025, the U.S. agreed to expand defence sales and co-production in India, including Javelin anti-tank guided missiles and Stryker infantry combat vehicles. The two countries subsequently signed a 10-year Framework for the U.S.-India Major Defence Partnership on October 31, 2025.

However, a strategic defence partnership of this magnitude must be assessed by what it delivers, not merely the number of agreements signed. Prolonged delays in the supply of GE F404 engines for India's Tejas fighter aircraft highlight the risks of relying on foreign suppliers for critical military components and the strategic cost of supply-chain vulnerabilities. Despite initiatives such as the India-U.S. Defence Acceleration Ecosystem (INDUS-X), launched in 2023, co-development and technology transfer remain an issue.

The Pakistan factor

Pakistan has always been a politically sensitive source of friction between India and the U.S., particularly since Operation Sindoor (May 2025). U.S. President Donald Trump's repeated claims that he ended the conflict have irked India, although New Delhi has refrained from direct confrontation. The U.S.'s courting of Pakistan's top leadership, especially its Chief of Defence Forces, Asim Munir, has also been a major irritant. The signing of the Mecca Pact between Saudi Arabia, Pakistan and Türkiye, reportedly with Washington's blessings, has raised further security concerns for India.

High-end technology is another area in which India has often been forced to look to the U.S. – a situation that Washington has sought to exploit. Although the 2008 India-U.S. civil nuclear agreement was a historic breakthrough, its commercial promise of American-designed nuclear reactors in India remains largely unrealised. The Initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology (iCET), launched in 2023, was cited as an attempt to deepen cooperation in artificial intelligence, semiconductors, defence innovation, space and other advanced technologies, but much remains on paper. The India-U.S. Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology (TRUST) Initiative, signed on February 13, 2025, also raised hopes of greater technology transfer and integration. The key challenge, however, remains translating declarations into measurable outcomes.

Need for mutual respect

India-U.S. relations are entering a phase in which India's strategic restraint and efforts at accommodation are increasingly met with American pressure, unilateralism and outright disregard for India's strategic interests. Whether this is a difficult phase or a deeper structural problem remains to be seen. The relationship between the world's oldest democracy and the world's largest democracy can flourish only through equality, respect and trust, not unilateral imposition of will. External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar's recent observation that the U.S. is "deliberately becoming a lonelier power" may convey more than what the words suggest.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Young voices, new politics

What the stir over the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls has achieved is the emergence of several charismatic young faces whom Gen Z can rally around. This could well shape the political narrative of the future. Staying relevant will be a formidable challenge for all political parties, particularly the Bharatiya Janata Party. What is remarkable about these young voices is the depth of their leadership pool. Detain one set of leaders and another steps forward to address the media. That kind of a resilience is remarkable. Their clarity of thought, confidence in expression and ability to articulate their concerns suggest that this is not merely a moment of protest but potentially the beginning of a new political narrative.

Pavan Kumar N.R.,
Shivamogga, Karnataka

Visual indictment

The Hindu's illustrator deserves compliments for a brilliant and piercing visual (Inside pages, 'On the draw', October 11). The depiction of the Chief Election Commissioner of India, Gyanesh Kumar, as a fly ruining a glass of milk has captured public anger directed at the Election Commission of India (ECI) and the controversy around the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. The cartoon reminds us that democracy cannot function when the very umpire tasked with keeping the pitch clean is seen as the contaminant. The Supreme Court of India's recent questions on voter roll modifications only add weight to this powerful visual.

Instead of clamping down on dissent, the government and the ECI must answer why a routine exercise has instead left lakhs of genuine voters out in the cold.

R. Sivakumar,
Chennai

A day for dam safety

The Srisailam dam across the Krishna river experienced an unprecedented peak inflow of about 25.50 lakh cubic feet per second during the October 2009 floods, with high inflows for nearly 78 hours. On October 3, 2009, the reservoir level reached 896.50 feet, 11.50 feet above the Full Reservoir Level of 885 feet. This extraordinary event underscores the importance of dam safety and resilience. October 3 should therefore be observed every year as India's National Dam Safety Day.

Y. Abdul Basheer,
Hyderabad

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the full postal address and the full name or the name with initials.

Why Congress must not smear CJP



Vanya Vaidehi Bhargav

Historian at the National Law School of India, Bangalore, and the author of 'Being Hindu, Being Indian: Lala Lajpat Rai's Ideas of Nationhood'

Something unprecedented is afoot. India's opposition parties and thousands of ordinary citizens are finally galvanised against the Modi government. They are speaking in one voice against voter suppression and for India's democratic future. The staggering police counter-mobilisation suggests the once-invincible government feels threatened. Yet, Opposition parties may squander this opportunity. Hints are evident on Twitter, where some Congress supporters are attacking the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP).

The conspiracy theory being peddled is that the CJP was created by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), and their supposed 'B-team', the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), to draw youth support away from Rahul Gandhi. This ignores the fact that Abhijeet Dipke, CJP founder, has accused Amit Shah of turning the Delhi Police into a 'bunch of criminals', and called Prime Minister Modi a "psychotic dictator" lacking the *aukaat* (worth) to become greater than Nehru, and who became Prime Minister due to vote theft. The unprecedented police repression of CJP's October 10 protest too contradicts this theory. However, this attempt by some Congress supporters to discredit the CJP is significant; it reveals their insecurity, that CJP leaders, some of whom had previous affiliations with the AAP, will repeat AAP's history of undercutting Congress's support base in Delhi and Punjab. They intend to discredit the CJP in order to keep youth support safe for Mr. Gandhi. It will instead erode it.

The youth had grown frustrated with India's education system, economy and infrastructure. This was worsened by relentless propaganda denying people's reality, a stifling atmosphere of fear, and the closure of all channels of democratic dissent. The CJP's call to assemble at Jantar Mantar came as a new lease of life to a dying democracy. The youth expressed relief at the opening of a democratic space after years of oppressive silence to which many had resigned. The increased freedom to speak, disagree, and criticise was palpable and contagious. The CJP provided a common platform for a diverse coalition of dissenters to coalesce, and express dissent in personalised, creative ways under one banner.

Need to stand together

This does not deny Rahul Gandhi's work on paper leaks, institutional capture and voter suppression. Yet, the Congress would be deceiving itself if it believed that – after the Bharat Jodo Yatra in 2022 – it has consistently prioritised calling a cross-section of ordinary citizens onto the streets under its banner and organising India's diverse dissenters into a popular coalition. The CJP, in doing that, has punctured the BJP's aura of invincibility, creating a juncture pregnant with opportunity for the Opposition. If the CJP is a plot to undercut Mr. Gandhi, it is currently achieving the opposite. That his decency, fearlessness and ideological commitment had had an impact is evidenced by several Gen Z youth expressing support for Mr. Gandhi during the CJP's July protest. His *Chhatron Ki Goonj* rallies have been boosted by the CJP's youth galvanisation.

But the obsessive attacks by some Congress supporters on the CJP threaten to squander this opportunity. The CJP is popular because it is perceived as prioritising people's interests. Mutual criticism is democratic, but smear campaigns will be read as reflecting the petty insecurity of Congresspersons, and as disregarding the agency and intelligence of dissenters to judge who inspires and represents them authentically. This threatens the goodwill Mr. Gandhi has earned by prioritising people's causes and platforming citizens galvanised by the CJP. While he has not smeared the CJP, such impressions may attach to Mr. Gandhi. The protestors' independence of mind make it clear that they will reject anyone suspected of placing personality cult or partyism over authentic concern for India's dissenting people. In his own interest and his party's, Mr. Gandhi must rein in his social media supporters.

Rahul Gandhi must accept the challenge of his youth support being undermined. No party is entitled to the support of India's dissenting citizens. It must be earned. If Congress claims to represent the youth, it must persuade them it does so best. The CJP resonates because it offers an open, accessible space that amplifies rather than dwarfs ordinary citizens' voices. Mr. Gandhi will similarly win goodwill by inspiring dissenting citizens and non-party opposition groups to treat Congress as an umbrella platform for expressing their dissent creatively.

The CJP is popular because it is perceived as prioritising people's interests. Mutual criticism is democratic, but smear campaigns will be read as reflecting the petty insecurity of Congresspersons

Nobel lesson: value of stabilisation models



Sushanta Kumar Mahapatra

Associate Professor of Economics at the ICFAI School of Social Sciences, IFHE, Hyderabad

Economic fluctuations, in addition to being reflected in GDP numbers, inflation, and unemployment rates, impact household budgets, hiring decisions of companies, and the ability of families to save money. This year's Sveriges Riksbank Prize in Economic Sciences in Memory of Alfred Nobel (2026), given to Robert E. Hall and Michael Woodford for "microeconomic foundations of macroeconomic stabilisation", highlights an essential concept – successful economic policies require an understanding of how individual households and businesses make their economic choices.

Importance of their work

Governments have spent many years attempting to reduce the size of both the 'peaks' (highs) and 'troughs' (lows) that occur in the business cycle. In times of low economic activity (which is characterised by weak demand), central banks use their power to cut interest rates; in times of strong economic activity (characterised by strong demand), policy changes may need to be made to restrict further growth.

However, the oil crises of the 1970s demonstrated that there were weaknesses in the models that were being utilised at that time. It became clear that the relationships between inflation, unemployment, consumption, and production were far more variable than had previously been believed. During this period, inflation continued to rise with unemployment levels also rising. Additionally, growth rates were declining. Therefore, stimulating an economy at the wrong time could result in even greater problems.

Mr. Hall and Mr. Woodford advanced macroeconomic stabilisation through their focus on placing household and business decisions at the centre of economic studies.

Mr. Hall's research demonstrated how consumption patterns reflect people's expectations of future earnings. However, he acknowledged that many households are unable to smooth out their spending due to a lack of savings and credit. In India, then, policymakers should consider the variations among households with different levels of financial security (that is high-income vs. low-income), instead of making decisions based upon what is considered to be the "average" consumer.

John Maynard Keynes was the first to recognise the importance of stabilising an economy. Following a similar line, Mr. Woodford developed his ideas within a practical new Keynesian model which links consumer spending, inflation and the overall level of economic activity. It allows policymakers to analyse how changes in interest rates could impact the economy. An important part of the model is that prices are "sticky", which means that firms do not immediately change their prices when there is a change in demand or cost. Firms set prices based upon what they believe their future costs, demand and competitors' prices will be. Therefore, expectations set for the future can affect today's inflation.

Central banks' credibility and communication is important because a central bank's decision on interest rates does more than explain what its policy rate is today. Such announcements will affect people's expectations for future interest rates and inflation which will again ultimately influence their decisions today. Clear and consistent communications from central banks allow households and businesses to make plans.

On the other hand, unpredictable signals from central banks or announcements of policies that are not followed through with actions can reduce the effectiveness of monetary policy.

Supply issues too

The model warns that not all shocks should be viewed as being caused by demand. Disruptions to supply may also lead to higher prices, lower levels of output, and an increase in unemployment at the same time, which would need to be tackled with other available policy options than just adjusting interest rates. Stabilisation models for India must take into account what is happening within the country, as well as be backed up with a strong monetary policy, responsible fiscal management, access to reliable data and specific assistance provided to those who are the most at risk of losing their jobs.

In the end, the value of the Nobel prize is in encouraging disciplined policymaking that takes into consideration the context in which it operates, while protecting price stability, job security and people's livelihoods.

The reason why central banks' credibility and communication is important is because a central bank's decision on interest rates does more than explain what its policy rate is today

Legal aid cuts jail time for undertrials, but help often arrives late

Reaching prisoners soon after arrest is key if free legal aid is to reduce the human and economic costs of pre-trial detention

DATA POINT

Indulekha Guha
Trisha Chanda

India jails fewer people than most countries – about 41 for every 1,00,000 people – yet more than three-quarters of its prisoners in 2022 were awaiting trial. That places India fourth in the world in the share of undertrials in its prison population. Many of them are poor, poorly educated, or from marginalised communities and remain in jail not because they have been convicted but because they cannot navigate the system or afford a lawyer.

Free legal aid is meant to close this gap. The Legal Services Authorities Act, 1987 created the National Legal Services Authority to provide free legal services to weaker sections of society. But three decades on, limited outreach, low awareness and uneven quality mean that many undertrials still go without timely help.

A legal aid programme run since 2018 across eight prisons in Maharashtra offers insights into what such help can achieve. Implemented by Prayas (Tata Institute of Social Sciences) and the Fair Trial Fellowship (National Law University, Delhi), and funded by the Azim Premji Foundation, it targets those least able to secure representation: casual workers, women abandoned by their families, minorities, or migrant workers.

By analysing the records of over 22,000 undertrials assisted between 2018 and 2023, it was found that the typical participant is 29 years old, and that close to half have studied only up to primary school. Further, 18% are women and 57% are casual wage workers. By comparing their outcomes with the district court records in Maharashtra and used national labour force and time use surveys, the costs of detention were estimated.

To begin with, programme participants obtain bail far more often than the average applicant. Across 29 districts, 84% of participants' bail applications succeeded, compared with 26% of all applications in the same district courts between 2015 and 2020. Participants did better in 28 of the 29 districts. The gap persists even within categories of offence severity, so it is not simply because the programme serves people accused of minor crimes. Within the programme, bail outcomes change sharply at intake. Before intake, the share of participants granted bail ranged from about 1% to 6% across groups by gender, income, education and occupation. After intake, it ranged from 61% to 92%.

Timing, however, matters a great deal. Participants spent on average 171 days – more than five months – in jail before they entered the programme. Those released on bail spent a further 115 days in custody on average, taking the total from arrest to release to about eight months. In 2018, about 37% of Maharashtra's 26,898 undertrials had been held for more than a year **(Table 1)**.

The cost of detention

Detention before trial is costly for people who mostly live on daily earnings. The wages participants lose in custody was estimated by matching them to similar workers in the Periodic Labour Force Survey and multiplying their daily wage by the number of days they were detained. The losses are large relative to their incomes. From arrest to release, average losses reach up to about ₹2 lakh for some age groups, while more than 60% of participants earn less than ₹80,000 a year. Losses rise with age and peak among workers in their 50s **(Chart 2)**.

Losses also vary by group. After intake alone, those facing the most serious charges lose about ₹80,000 on average, nearly four times the ₹21,000 lost by those accused of the least severe offences. This is driven mainly by longer detention rather than higher earnings. Graduates and regular wage workers also lose more, since their wages are higher **(Chart 3)**.

The uncomfortable question this raises is: why do so many undertrials wait months for help that is already their right? Legal aid is usually seen as a matter of rights. These findings suggest it is also an intervention with economic returns. By helping undertrials file bail applications, coordinate with advocates, gather documents and meet release conditions, the programme appears to cut through the procedural frictions that prolong detention.

Shorter detention can ease prison overcrowding, lower public spending on prisons, and limit income losses for vulnerable households. The most actionable lesson concerns timing. Legal aid can improve outcomes after intake, but it cannot recover the months already spent in jail. Identifying eligible prisoners at or soon after arrest could substantially raise its impact. Better data would also help. Caste, religion, income and migration status are missing for much of the sample, which limits what can be said about who benefits most.

Comparing participants with similar defendants in court records would allow a rigorous evaluation of the programme's effect, and tracking people after release would show whether the gains last. As governments seek to widen access to justice, legal aid works best when it reaches undertrial prisoners early enough to prevent unnecessary detention.

Note: Programme participants are not randomly selected, so the comparisons are descriptive rather than causal. Wage and time losses are accounting estimates of the value of time spent in custody: predicted daily wages from the PLFS 2017-18 multiplied by days detained. Since undertrials differ from the general population, they should be read as upper-bound estimates. Each period is averaged over participants with valid dates for that period.

Cost of delayed justice

Data for the charts were sourced from authors' calculations using Azim Premji Foundation programme records and the Periodic Labour Force Survey 2017-18



Table 1: Time spent in custody by programme participants (in days)

Period	Participants	Average	Maximum
Arrest to programme intake	18,093	171	1,843
Intake to release on bail	8,987	115	1,122
Arrest to release on bail	8,921	239	2,039

Durations after intake are for participants with a recorded release date

Chart 2: Age-wise predicted wage loss of participants during their detention for the period between intake to release. After intake alone, those facing the most serious charges lose about ₹80,000 on average, nearly four times the ₹21,000 lost by those accused of the least severe offences.

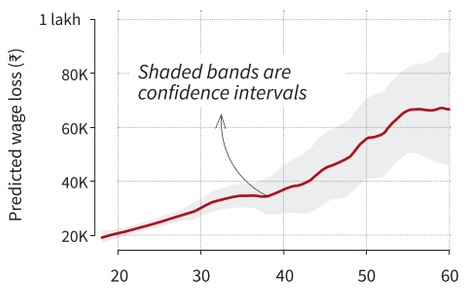
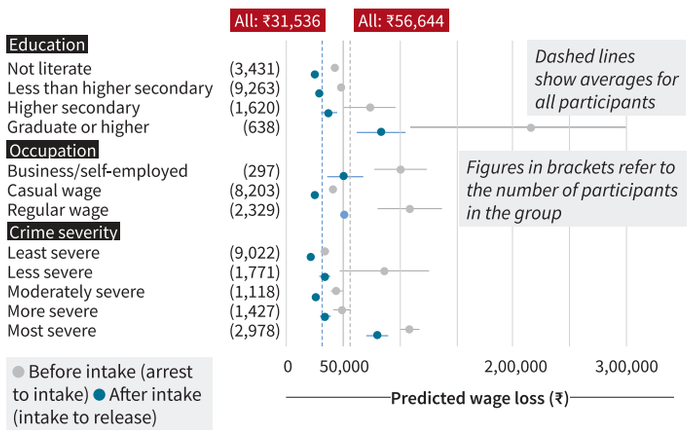


Chart 3: Predicted wage loss before and after programme intake by group. Each participant is counted once, by their most serious case. The chart excludes unemployed participants and those outside the labour force



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FROM THE ARCHIVES
The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO OCTOBER 14, 1976

Inadequate library services in Asia and Africa

Lusaka, October 13: The Pro Vice-Chancellor of the University of Zambia, Mr. Moses Musonda has underlined the need for greater efforts by developing countries in Asia and Africa to develop their information systems to get over the woefully inadequate situation in this field.

The state of libraries and information services in Africa – and indeed in developing countries – are appalling, he said, in a closing speech to the six-day standing conference of Eastern, Central and Southern African librarians here yesterday.

Equally frightening, he told the delegates, was the paucity of trained and qualified personnel to man these services which made the running of the libraries and information systems poorly co-ordinated. The main reason for this situation developing, Mr. Musonda said, could be attributed to the fact that some governments had not recognised the importance of these systems. Mr. Musonda said, another reason was that personnel training has not been encouraging since there were very few people who understood or appreciated the importance and implication of developing information systems for the benefit of developing countries.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO OCTOBER 14, 1926

Astronomical research and industrial development

The extensive use which is now being made of research facilities for testing materials destined for industrial use was recently illustrated in the sending of samples of rubber from England to Switzerland to be tested for moisture absorption.

This was undertaken by Dr. Kollieker, the Swiss Government astronomer, at the observatory situated over 11,000 feet above sea-level 2,000 feet or so beneath the crest of the Jung-frau mountain in the Bernese Oberland. Here weather conditions and atmospheric effects are studied, the station being fitted with a high-power telescope for astronomical research.

During the summer this is frequently used for sweeping the mountain side in search of belated travellers, thousands visiting the Jung-frau observatory to obtain the view which extends beyond the French Vosges mountains and to the Black Forest in Germany.

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Healthy life-years saved by limiting global warming

1.89 billion years. Limiting global warming to around 1.8 degrees Celsius, instead of allowing it to reach 4.4 degrees Celsius, could prevent the loss of 1.89 billion years of healthy life to causes such as extreme heat and air pollution, according to new Lancet Commission. PTI

Increase in power demand in T.N. due to El Niño heat

30 in per cent. Rejecting the allegations of high-cost power purchases, Minister R. Nirmal Kumar defended the government's decision to call for short-term power tenders. He attributed the strain on the grid to a 30% spike in demand driven by El Niño-induced heat. PTI

IMF's lowered forecast of China's economic growth this year

4.5 in per cent. The International Monetary Fund (IMF) lowered its forecast for China's economic growth this year to 4.5% on Tuesday, as higher energy prices due to the West Asia conflict and a domestic spending slump weigh on activity. AFP

The value of hydrocarbons Russia exported to Europe

320 in $ billion. Russia said it has sold European countries over $320 billion worth of hydrocarbons since 2022. "For the period from 2022 to today, this figure amounts to $320.7 billion. This is the volume of energy resource deliveries to European Union countries," Russia said. AFP

Farmers on third list for Maharashtra crop loan waiver

3.51 in lakh. The Maharashtra government has released the third list of 3,51,192 farmers eligible for benefits under the Puneashlok Ahilyadevi Holkar Loan Waiver Scheme, State Cooperation Minister Babasaheb Patil said. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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What is preventive detention?

What does the law permit, and where must the State draw the line? What safeguards does the Constitution provide against arbitrary detention? How has preventive detention evolved in India? What is the difference between preventive detention and prohibitory orders?

EXPLAINER

Rizmi Lia M.

The story so far:

The Delhi Police detained more than 5,000 protesters as they tried to reach Jantar Mantar for the protest demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and a rollback of the SIR. In the lead-up to the protests in Delhi, there was a nationwide crackdown on protesters by the police force. Among those detained and brutally manhandled by the Delhi police were leaders of various political factions, former Chief Ministers, the Leader of the Opposition, lawyers, journalists, students, activists, and reportedly people who were not even part of the protest. Police detained people at representatives' residences even before the protest started, and en route to the protest site. However, the Supreme Court on October 11 directed the Centre and the Delhi Police to ensure free movement of people 'subject to law and order'.

This prompts an understanding of what preventive detention is, how it can be imposed, and how it came into practice.



AISA's Neha Bora during a protest march at Connaught Place in New Delhi. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

What is preventive detention?

'Preventive detention' means detention of a person without a trial or conviction by a court. The primary objective of preventive detention is not to punish an individual for a past offence but to prevent him from committing an offence in the future.

Power of preventive detention can be exercised by the authorities on the grounds of public order, security of the State, and law and order.

The National Security Act, 1980 (NSA) allows for preventive detention if the government is satisfied that a person's activities are prejudicial to the defence of India, the relations of India with foreign powers, or the security of the State.

What is a prohibitory order under the BNSS?

Section 163 of the BNSS largely retains the spirit of its predecessor, Section 144 of the Code of Criminal Procedure, 1973. It empowers a District Magistrate, a Sub-Divisional Magistrate, or any other Executive Magistrate specially empowered by the State Government, to issue orders when there is sufficient ground for proceeding and immediate prevention or speedy remedy is desirable. The primary objective is to prevent obstruction, annoyance, or injury to any person lawfully employed, or danger to human life, health, or safety, or a disturbance of the public tranquillity, or a riot, or an affray.

The provision is preventive in nature, designed to avert potential harm rather than to punish past acts. The Magistrate must be satisfied that there is an urgency that necessitates an immediate order, even without prior notice to the affected parties.

The power is extraordinary and is intended for situations where the normal course of law enforcement might be too slow to prevent immediate harm. The order must clearly state the material facts upon which it is based, ensuring transparency and providing grounds for potential challenge.

Furthermore, orders under Section 163 BNSS are subject to judicial review by the High Courts under their revisional jurisdiction. The Supreme Court, in cases like *Babulal Parate v. State of Maharashtra* (1961) and *Madhu Limaye v. Sub-Divisional Magistrate* (1971), has consistently emphasised that these powers must be exercised judiciously, proportionately, and only when there is an imminent threat to public order, and not as a routine measure.

How has preventive detention evolved?

Preventive detention in India has evolved from a colonial tool used to suppress political dissent into a legal mechanism intended to protect national security and public order. During British rule, laws such as the Rowlatt Act, 1919, and the Defence of India Act, 1939, allowed the authorities to detain individuals without trial, often targeting freedom fighters and political opponents.

After Independence, India retained preventive detention, introducing the Preventive Detention Act, 1950, which remained in force until 1969. The Maintenance of Internal Security Act (MISA), 1971, further expanded detention powers and was widely used against political opponents during the Emergency (1975-1977). It was repealed in 1978.

The National Security Act (NSA), 1980, subsequently established a continuing legal framework for preventive detention. Other laws, including the Conservation of Foreign Exchange and Prevention of Smuggling Activities Act (COFEPOSA), 1974, also authorised preventive detention for specific purposes.

Meanwhile, amendments to the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA), 1967, expanded the state's powers to address terrorism and unlawful activities.

Over time, the Supreme Court's interpretation of personal liberty has also evolved. *Maneka Gandhi v. Union of India* (1978) established that procedures restricting personal liberty must be just, fair and reasonable. However, concerns over prolonged detention without trial, inadequate judicial oversight and the potential misuse of these laws continue to raise questions about the balance between national security and fundamental rights.

What did the Supreme Court order on October 11?

With respect to the Delhi protests, the Supreme Court convened what it called an "extraordinary, exceptional" Sunday (October 11, 2026) hearing to direct the Union government and the Delhi Police to stop illegal detentions and allow free and smooth movement of people and traffic, as well as the operations of Metro and rail services, but "subject to law and public order".

The Supreme Court directed that Delhi Metro and railway services operate normally, and that internet services remain available in accordance with the law. It said the movement of people and vehicles across Delhi must not be unnecessarily obstructed and that barricades must be reviewed based on law-and-order and traffic requirements. The court said there must be no unlawful detention and that all detentions must follow the procedure established by law. It also directed that peaceful assemblies be allowed in accordance with the law, except in areas where prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) are in force. Any notice board announcing Section 163 restrictions near the Supreme Court must be removed, if still in place, to ensure access to the Supreme Court and other courts. The court also recorded the assurance that lawyers, journalists and other professionals would not be prevented from performing their duties.

The court issued notice in contempt proceedings alleging violation of its October 9 order and directed the authorities to submit a compliance report by October 13, including details of Metro restrictions and railway advisories. Habeas corpus petitions alleging mass detentions will also be heard with the main cases on October 13. The court said the State must explain the circumstances, manner and legal justification for the alleged detentions, emphasising its duty under Article 32 of the Constitution to protect and enforce fundamental rights.

What have the courts said about preventive detention?

Earlier, in *Babulal Parate v. State of Maharashtra* (1961), the Supreme Court upheld the constitutional validity of Section 144 CrPC but said it could be used only in emergencies to prevent specific threats to public order. The court held that the power was not "unlimited or untrammelled" and had to be exercised within the limits set by law.

In *Khudiram Das v. State of West Bengal* (1975) Supreme Court observed that the requirement of communication of grounds of detention acts as a check against arbitrary and capricious exercise of power. The detaining authority cannot whisk away a person and put him behind bars at its own sweet will. It must have grounds for doing so and those grounds must be communicated to the detenu, so that, not only the detenu may know what are the facts and materials before the detaining authority on the basis of which he is being deprived of his personal liberty, but he can also invoke the power of judicial review, howsoever limited and peripheral it may be. The detenu has to be afforded an opportunity of making a representation against the order of detention.

In 2012, the Supreme Court criticised the government for imposing Section 144 against a sleeping crowd at Ramlila Maidan in New Delhi during protests against the Congress-led UPA government. "Such a provision can be used only in grave circumstances for maintenance of public peace. The efficacy of the provision is to prevent some harmful occurrence immediately. Therefore, the emergency must be sudden and the consequences sufficiently grave," the court said.

In *Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan v. Union of India* (2018), the Supreme Court set aside a National Green Tribunal order banning all protests along Jantar Mantar Road. The court said a complete ban was excessive, observing that the "solution was not to ban the demonstrations altogether". It directed the authorities to create a system to regulate protests and grant permissions.

The Supreme Court in the case of *Shaik Naznen v. State of Telangana* (2022) observed that powers to be exercised under the preventive detention laws are exceptional powers which have been given to the Government for its exercise in an exceptional situation as it strikes hard on the freedom and liberty of an individual, and thus cannot be exercised in a routine manner.

According to *Ameena Begum v. State of Telangana* (2023), Supreme Court observed that to unchain the shackles of preventive detention, it is important that the safeguards enshrined in our Constitution, particularly under the "golden triangle" formed by Articles 14, 19 and 21, are diligently enforced.

Article 14 ensures equality before the law, Article 19 provides important freedoms such as freedom of speech, expression, assembly, and movement, and Article 21 guarantees the right to life and personal liberty.

What are the safeguards against preventive detention in the Constitution?

Article 22 of the Constitution provides safeguards against arbitrary preventive detention. Under Article 22(4), a person generally cannot be detained for more than three months without an Advisory Board reviewing the case, subject to the constitutional requirements and exceptions. Under Article 22(5), the authorities must communicate the grounds of detention to the detainee as soon as possible and give them an opportunity to make a representation against the order. The grounds must be communicated in a manner that allows the detainee to effectively challenge the detention.

Preventive detention orders are also subject to judicial review. Courts can examine whether the authorities followed the law, considered relevant material and complied with constitutional safeguards. Therefore, the power must be exercised carefully and cannot be used arbitrarily.

THE GIST

- Preventive detention allows authorities to detain a person to prevent anticipated threats to public order or security, but it must be distinguished from prohibitory orders and other police action against protesters
- Article 22 of the Constitution provides safeguards for detained persons, while laws such as the National Security Act set out the grounds and procedures for detention
- Courts can review state action to protect individual liberty, emphasising that restrictions on protest and preventive detention must remain within legal and constitutional limits

CACHE



Elon Musk claimed that Starlink has not been licensed in India, in spite of spending five years complying with the government laws and requirements. REUTERS

Why is Musk taking on Mukesh Ambani over Starlink in India?

Elon Musk has accused Mukesh Ambani of using his influence to keep Starlink out of India to protect Jio's market dominance, even as Starlink awaits security clearances to begin operations; the spat comes as Jio prepares for an IPO, raising questions about competition and regulatory hurdles

Sahana Venugopal

The story so far:

SpaceX owner Elon Musk has never shied away from starting a social media spat, be it with his own family members or U.S. President Donald Trump.

Mr. Musk has now taken aim at India's billionaire Mukesh Ambani, accusing the chairman and managing director of Reliance Industries of being the real "boss" of India and playing a role in keeping Starlink's satellite internet out of the Indian market to favour Jio.

What has Mr. Musk said about Mr. Ambani?

On October 9, Mr. Musk posted on X a mockingly subservient tweet addressed to "Prime Minister Ambani," apologising for "not realizing that you are the real boss of India," and accused him of wanting to maintain his "monopolistic exploitation of the great people of India," before asking him for permission to allow Starlink to compete in the market. Mr. Musk claimed that Starlink would help close Internet connectivity gaps across the country and could help save lives during natural disasters.

Critics of Mr. Musk were infuriated by what they felt was the undermining of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, as well as the accusation that India's government is under Mr. Ambani's influence. Others flagged that the price of Starlink's service, both hardware and subscriptions, was



Elon Musk. REUTERS

many times more than the services offered by India-based Internet service providers.

On October 11, Mr. Musk posted that competition would benefit Indian customers by giving them more choices and that prices would be adjusted accordingly.

"Ambani's profits will be lower, but he is not going out of business. And, obviously, if Starlink is too expensive in India, no one will buy it, so SpaceX will need to make pricing affordable," stated Mr. Musk.

What is the status of Starlink's licence in India?

Mr. Musk claimed that Starlink has not been licensed in India, in spite of spending five years complying with the government laws and requirements.

In March 2025, SpaceX announced that it had partnered with Jio Platforms to offer Starlink broadband Internet service to customers in India, subject to SpaceX receiving separate authorisations to offer Starlink in India. (A similar agreement was also signed with Bharti Airtel.)

Under the 2025 agreement, the two companies were set to explore service collaborations so Jio Platforms would make Starlink solutions available through its own retail channels.

It is unclear whether that agreement will hold after Mr. Musk's gibe against Mr. Ambani and the Indian government.

Apart from the deals between the two companies, SpaceX has a Global Mobile Personal Communications by Satellite (GMPCS) authorisation from the Department of Telecommunications (DoT), *The Hindu* reported this month, but security clearances are pending.

Similarly, ANI reported that licensing was complete for Starlink, Reliance Jio Satcom, and Eutelsat OneWeb, while security checks are in progress.

Why is the timing of this clash significant?

The timing is crucial as Jio Platforms is preparing for an initial public offering (IPO), which is expected to take place later this month, per media reports; a company at this stage likely prefers a stable regulatory environment and positive media coverage.

A world-famous billionaire attacking an IPO-bound company by accusing it of undermining India's market sovereignty could make the situation tenuous. Mr. Musk's intimacy with the White House could potentially escalate the online spat.

Mr. Trump has in the past threatened penalties when other countries – such as Australia and the U.K. – slowed the foreign operations of U.S. tech giants.

Another factor to consider is the ongoing protest against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar over allegations of irregularities in the electoral rolls vetting process. Delhi residents have been affected by one of the largest Internet shutdowns in the capital's history.

By contrast, Starlink has been used to access the Internet during times of war and civil unrest, such as (legally) during Ukraine's defence against Russian invasion and Iran's anti-government protests (illegally). For the Indian government, ensuring that all telecom companies comply with its Internet blackouts is a serious priority.

Mr. Musk has stressed that Starlink beams are turned off over India, and that illegal use is not possible.

For the time being, the Starlink app remains available for download in the country, advertising a starting price of $55 per month for 100Mbps and unlimited data.

Meanwhile, the Indian government denied that it allowed monopolies to form in any sector.

THE DAILY QUIZ

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

A quiz on the much-loved bear and his world on the centenary of the publication of the evergreen children's classic 'Winnie-the-Pooh'

V.V. Ramanan

QUESTION 1
It is well-known that the name Winnie was derived from Winnipeg, the name A.A. Milne's son gave to his teddy bear. Where does Pooh come from?

QUESTION 2
The Winnie-the-Pooh stories are set in Hundred Acre Wood, also referred to as 100 Aker Wood. Name the beautiful landscape that inspired this setting of his beloved stories.

QUESTION 3
In the original stories, what name is painted in gold letters over the door of Winnie-the-Pooh's house?

QUESTION 4
Where can one now see the original stuffed animals that inspired Milne's stories, and which character was added by Queen Camilla in 2026 to complete the set?

QUESTION 5
Name the nook close to Pooh's best friend Piglet's home where the two consider the day's possibilities.

QUESTION 6
Name the other two books featuring the lovable bear and his friends, and which hyperactive character debuted in the final work.

QUESTION 7
What is the contribution of Ernest Howard Shepard to the success and legacy of the Winnie-the-Pooh series of books?

QUESTION 8
Who played the role of an adult Christopher Robin in the eponymous 2018 film in which he is reunited with Winnie-the-Pooh?



Visual Question:
What is the setting for this illustration from one of the original works? AFP

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. Considered the oldest Indian club in existence, this team made history in 1911, becoming the first Indian club to win the IFA Shield. Name the club and the nickname given to the winning squad. **Ans: Mohun Bagan, 'Immortal Eleven'**
2. Name the first club from South India and the State in which it was set up. **Ans: RB Ferguson FC, Keralam**
3. The Durand Cup was won by a domestic club for the first time in 1940. Name the club that beat the Royal Warwickshire Regiment 2-1 to end the British monopoly. **Ans: Mohammedan Sporting**
4. This club was named the best in India by the English FA in 1951 after it won the IFA Shield three times in a row. Name the club. **Ans: East Bengal**
5. Name the team of under-15s who defeated its corresponding squad of European powerhouse Liverpool 6-0 this year. **Ans: Minerva Academy**
Visual: Name the club, which recently went through a management crisis, and the UAE-based group that acquired its ownership last month. **Ans: Kerala Blasters, Al Fursan Group**
Early Birds: K.N. Viswanathan | Arun Kumar Singh | Tamal Biswas | Erfanally Oosmany | Sudhir Thapa



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

Is it ok to say, "hook, line, and bait"? (Dr. S. Jayaraman, Chennai)
The correct expression is "fall for something hook, line, and sinker". The word "fall" here means "to believe". So when you fall for a story "hook, line, and sinker", you believe the story completely, although it sounds pretty far-fetched. The expression means the same thing as "lock, stock, and barrel". When you say that someone fell for something hook, line and sinker, you are passing a judgment on the individual. You are indirectly saying that he/she is pretty gullible; he/she is willing to believe anything somebody tells him/her. One can also say "swallow/buy something hook, line, and sinker".

Shyam expected his students to swallow his explanation hook, line, and sinker.

Another common expression is, "fall hook, line, and sinker in love with someone/something".

This is an expression that comes from the sport of fishing. I understand that sometimes a fish not only swallows the hook to which the bait is attached, but also some of the "line". The sinker is the weight that is used to take the fishing line to the bottom. It is, however, very uncommon for a fish to swallow the "sinker". So, if someone swallows your story hook, line and sinker, he/she believes your tall tale.

What is the difference between "cost" and "price"? (Usha Karthikeyan, T.N.)
Most people tend to use these words interchangeably when they want to mean the amount of money required to buy something. For example, we can say, "What is the price of the car?" or "How much does the car cost"? In business, however, the two words have a different meaning. When you talk about the "cost" of something, what you are referring to is the amount of money that you spent to make that particular thing. For example, when businessmen talk about the cost of a car, they are referring to the amount they spent manufacturing it. "Price", on the other hand, refers to the amount of money that the car is sold for. It is the amount that the customer pays. A toy may cost Rs. 200 to manufacture, but it may be priced at Rs. 500.

The word "cost", unlike the word "price", is normally used with services. For example, one talks about the cost of getting one's car repaired, and the cost of going on holiday. "Cost" is also used with abstractions; one talks about the "cost of living", the "cost of war", etc. When you wish to use an adjective, then it is "price" that is used. For example, you talk about "exorbitant" prices, "great prices", and "bargain prices". As everyone knows, every politician has his/her price. Yes, the word price is normally used when you wish to bribe someone. You can tell the individual to name his/her price.

Is it ok to say, "All classes are suspended in the aftermath of the All India elocution competition"? (V. S. Uday, Sringeri)
The word "aftermath" was first used to refer to the second crop; that is, the crop that grew after the first crop was cut. These days the word is figuratively used to refer to the period that follows an event. But what is important to remember is that the preceding event is usually associated with something terrible - an earthquake, an explosion, a war, etc.
Published in The Hindu on April 2, 2002

Word of the day

Dilettante:
an amateur who engages in an activity without serious intentions and who pretends to have knowledge

Synonyms: inexperienced, unskilled, unprofessional, inexpert

Usage: *He is a dilettante who paints for fun.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/dilettante

International Phonetic Alphabet: /dɪlɪtænti/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

INBRIEF



Hyundai Motor to invest $15.5 bn in India by 2032

Hyundai Motor Group said it will invest $15.5 billion in India between 2026 and 2032, expanding manufacturing capacity, research and development (R&D) infrastructure and localisation of components as it seeks to strengthen the country's position as a global automotive hub. The investment plan was discussed at a meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Hyundai Motor Group Executive Chair Euisun Chung at the PMO in New Delhi on Tuesday. The seven-year investment will span manufacturing expansion, future technology development, local supplier partnerships and infrastructure development, the South Korean automotive major said in a statement. The Group plans to expand production capacity across Hyundai Motor India Ltd. (HMIL) and Kia India Pvt Ltd. to cater to rising demand and improve localisation.

Vantrock unveils warehousing, industrial, logistics parks plan

Vantrock Real Assets Private Ltd. (VRAPL), an operator-led real assets platform, plans to develop 11.5 million sq. ft of warehousing, industrial and logistics parks, with a gross development value (GDV) of ₹4,200 crore upon completion. The first phase, spanning 3 million sq. ft. and valued at ₹1,100 crore, will be spread across NCR, Bengaluru and Pune. Construction is scheduled to begin in 2027, with rental income expected to commence in 2028. Land for these projects is at advanced stages of negotiation, documentation and regulatory approvals, the company said. The remaining 8.5 million sq. ft will be acquired across the same markets and the Mumbai Metropolitan Region (MMR). These assets will be operationalised in phases over the next 12-18 months, it added. The company also plans to upgrade existing warehousing facilities to improve safety and operational standards. In subsequent phases, Vantrock plans to expand into global capability centres, suburban office campuses, data centres and infrastructure assets.

Adani defers Mumbai to Navi Mumbai plan

The Group's proposed shifting of 30% of international flight slots has been deferred to the summer schedule that begins on March 28, 2027

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI



The move follows a stand-off over the 'forceful' transfer of 30% of Mumbai's international airport slots to Navi Mumbai. REUTERS

The Adani Group has put on hold its plan to shift 30% of international flight slots at Mumbai's Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport to Navi Mumbai International Airport, with no transfers planned for the upcoming winter schedule.

The proposed shift has been deferred to the summer schedule, which begins on March 28, 2027.

The move was the outcome of a consultative meeting between Adani Group and airlines on Tuesday, after the Centre was forced to intervene in the stand-off. "They have assured the airline community of minimisation of disruption and have assured them of fully respecting historical slots allocations. They have further given a commitment not to disturb any slots for the winter schedule," Adani Airports Holding Ltd. said in a press statement about the message from its Director Jeet Adani and CEO Arun Bansal to the airlines in Tuesday's meeting.

The group said it had secured commitments from international airlines to support the plan for the summer schedule.

The move follows a standoff between the Adani Group and international airlines over what carriers described as a "forceful" transfer of 30% of Mumbai's international airport slots to the Navi Mumbai airport. The International Air Transport Association (IATA), which represents global airlines, had called for a consultative approach and alternatives to cutting existing slots, and sufficient time for making the transition, warning that the move could affect international connectivity to and from Mumbai.

Mumbai International Airport Limited (MIAL) had recently proposed that approximately one-third of each carrier's passenger and cargo air traffic movements be transferred from Mumbai to Navi Mumbai from October 1, 2026.

This was to ostensibly cater for redevelopment of Terminal 1 at Mumbai, from where some domestic flights would be shifted to its Terminal 2 (T2), and international flights from T2 be shifted to Navi Mumba airporti.

'Will keenly hear views on LTCG, STT'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



Nirmala Sitharaman

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Tuesday said that she would listen to all views regarding the long-term capital gains (LTCG) tax and the securities transaction tax (STT). However, she refrained from stating whether the matter would be considered during the ongoing discussions in the preparations of Budget 2027.

Just the indication that she would listen to views on the taxation matter led to the stock market jumping 1% soon after she said it. The Finance Minister also said that the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) would continue to take action to prevent volatility in the rupee exchange rate.

"The long-term capital gains tax is something on which a lot of people have been commenting, both the investors within India and also those who meet me occasionally outside in India," Ms. Sitharaman said at an event in Delhi.

She added that several ministers had also raised the issue of the STT, saying that it was running parallel with the LTCG and that India should impose one or the other.

"So, it's healthy to have this debate and I will be keenly hearing them," Ms. Sitharaman said.

However, the Minister also said that since the Budget 2027 preparations have started, she would not comment on whether the issue would be discussed during the pre-budget meetings or not.

"The rupee has reached a low, and the RBI is making a lot of efforts through their regulatory powers to make sure that the rupee stays stable," Ms. Sitharaman said. "They are not trying to fix the rupee, they are trying to stop the volatility." "These efforts from the RBI, I understand, will continue," she added.

"I'm sure there are efforts which the RBI would take further to make sure that rupee doesn't become too volatile."

India does not grow at anybody's expense: PM

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

India does not grow at anybody's expense, instead, it grows with the world and for the world, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said at an event here on Tuesday, underlining India as a steady and trusted pillar for the globe.

"Whenever the world requires a steady pillar, India comprehends its responsibility and extends a hand in support," he said.

The Prime Minister also said that reforms being undertaken in India were not driven by compulsion but conviction.

The PM mentioned that India offered stability and could be relied upon in an uncertain world.

He pointed to the country having clocked a growth rate of 7.8% in the first quarter of the ongoing financial year, emphasising that it rested on strong foundations. Mr. Modi also pointed to India's current account deficit standing at 0.61%, foreign exchange reserves being above $700 billion alongside a strong and resilient banking sector, among other things.

OPEC cuts India's 2026 oil demand growth forecast to 40,000 bpd

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Organisation of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC) has lowered its forecast for India's oil demand growth in 2026 to 40,000 barrels per day (bpd), from 60,000 bpd projected in its September report. On a year-on-year (YoY) basis, India's oil demand is expected to rise by around 40,000 b/d to 5.7 million barrels per day (mbpd) in 2026, according to OPEC's latest monthly oil market report.

OPEC has also trimmed its global oil demand growth forecast for 2026 to 0.2 mbpd, down from 0.4 mbpd estimated in its previous assessment. However, it has raised its projection for global oil demand growth in 2027 to 2.6 mb/d, from 2.4 mb/d forecast last month.

Transportation fuels, particularly gasoline and diesel, are expected to remain the primary drivers

Its outlook for India's oil demand growth in 2027 remains unchanged.

Transportation fuels, particularly gasoline and diesel, are expected to remain the primary drivers of India's oil demand growth in 2026.

"Gasoline is expected to be supported by heightened road mobility amid robust vehicle sales. Diesel demand is anticipated to gain additional support from strong manufacturing and agricultural activity," OPEC said.

The report also projects an increase in demand for residual fuel during the year, while jet fuel consumption is expected to register marginal growth.

In contrast, demand for liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) and naphtha is expected to ease, OPEC said.

Tata Power, Imperial College London ally on energy transition

Gowri Lakshmi
MUMBAI

Tata Power on Tuesday signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with Imperial College London to collaborate on research, technology and knowledge exchange in the energy transition domain.

This will focus on grid flexibility, energy storage, artificial intelligence (AI) and machine learning (ML) applications, and advanced energy systems.

The collaboration aligns with the India-U.K. Vision 2035, which identifies grid transformation, energy storage, hydrogen, carbon capture and AI as key areas for bilateral cooperation.

U.K. Business and Trade Secretary Jonathan Reynolds said the partnership demonstrated how new trade deals could create opportunities. "... the partnership will help turn ideas into cleaner, smarter energy solutions - supporting good jobs and growth in both countries," he said.

Dr. Praveer Sinha, CEO and MD of Tata Power, said the collaboration would address emerging industry challenges and explore innovative solutions.

"The next generation of grids, storage and digital energy systems will need to work together to meet a rapidly evolving demand landscape. Our collaboration will help solve real-world industry challenges with deep research and new thinking and explore solutions that can be relevant to the wider global transition," Dr. Sinha said.

Polluters must pay



Well-oiled protest: Delegates walk past Greenpeace activists setting up an inflatable billboard and blocking traffic at the Cape Town International Convention Centre while calling for oil and gas companies attending the African Energy Week 2026 to pay back for climate damage in Africa, in Cape Town. AFP

Warner Music bets big on diversified revenue streams in India

Mini Tejaswi
BENGALURU

India's music industry is entering a new phase of growth, driven by the rise of regional and non-film music, expanding digital consumption, and the growing role of technology in artist discovery and audience development, said Jay Mehta, Managing Director, Recorded Music and Publishing, India & SAARC, Warner Music Group (WMG), a Manhattan-based music and entertainment conglomerate and one of the Big Three in the global music industry alongside Universal Music Group and Sony Music Entertainment

Warner Music India, the Indian arm of WMG, is positioning itself to capitalise on these changes by moving beyond the conventional record-label model and building a broader music and entertainment business spanning recorded music, publishing, distribution, artist services, live entertainment, and strategic partnerships.

"India needs to be approached as a multi-market music ecosystem rather than a single market," Mr. Mehta told *The Hindu*, pointing to the company's focus on artists with strong cultural connections to their audiences, from established names such as Guru Randhawa and Darshan Raval to emerging regional performers.

According to Mr. Mehta, technology and data analytics are becoming central to the company's strategy.

Sovereign AI: IBM for 'digital swaraj' with country-specific tools

Balasubramanyam C.P.
MUMBAI

IBM is developing India-specific tools and application programming interface (API) connectors to integrate sovereign AI software platform with local systems as it seeks to aid enterprises and governments retain greater control over data, technology and AI operations.

At its Think 2026 event here, Sandip Patel, MD, IBM India and South Asia, described the approach as "digital swaraj", arguing that sovereignty need not come at the cost of innovation.

"Sovereignty is not a choice between control and innovation. It is what gives enterprises the confidence to innovate at scale while remaining in control," Mr. Patel said.

Cloud-like services

IBM's Bharat Core comprises India-specific tools and API connectors built to work with its Sovereign Core software platform. Sovereign Core enables organisations to run cloud-like services on their own or partners' infrastructure while retaining control over data, operations and AI workloads. Bharat Core consists of about 20-25 tools and connectors designed to address Indian requirements, including integration with systems such as Aadhaar, Mr. Patel said during a press meet.

He cited three examples of IBM's collaborations with Indian technology partners. IBM's watsonx Orchestrate platform is available on Yotta's Shakti Cloud, enabling organisations to deploy and govern AI agents while keeping data, operations and governance controls within India. IBM's Sovereign Core has also been installed on NxtGen's infrastructure to deliver secure, governed AI inference services in the country.



New paradigm: IBM India & South Asia MD Sandip Patel and IBM Asia Pacific GM Hans Dekkers at the summit in Mumbai. ANI

IBM's collaboration with Indian AI company Sarvam combines Sovereign Core with Sarvam's language, voice and reasoning capabilities, targeting government, public-sector and regulated applications.

Mr. Patel said sovereignty was gaining importance as enterprises and governments assessed how changing regulations and geopolitical developments could affect the infrastructure on which their operations depend.

Controlling the keys

"Sovereignty is not about building walls. It's about controlling your keys," said Hans Dekkers, General Manager, IBM Asia Pacific. Sovereign infrastructure, he said, involves equipping existing infrastructure with software and technology that allows organisations to retain control within India. IBM's approach centres on enabling organisations to run and manage AI on infrastructure they control rather than having them move all workloads to public cloud platforms.

Separately, IBM on October 12 signed a memorandum of understanding with MeitY Startup Hub, an initiative of the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology, to support India's deep-tech startup ecosystem.

Under the agreement, startups will gain access to IBM's enterprise technologies, technical guidance, mentorship, skilling programmes and opportunities to engage with enterprises and investors.

This would cover enterprise AI, hybrid cloud, quantum computing, sovereign AI and open-source ecosystem development with a focus on startups in Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities. IBM and MeitY Startup Hub will also explore enterprise proof-of-concept projects.

(The writer was in Mumbai at the invitation of the company)

BofA loses bankers, tells staff of big ambition, hiring



In focus: Bank of America's logo adorns the facade of its office in downtown Toronto, Ontario, Canada. REUTERS

Reuters
NEW YORK

Bank of America's top leaders had a problem in the first week of August. Veteran banker Amy Lissauer – one of the company's most senior female executives – was considering jumping to rival JPMorgan Chase, people familiar with the matter said.

Ultimately, the attempts by CEO Brian Moynihan and Faiz Ahmad, the co-head of global investment banking, to persuade Lissauer to stay were unsuccessful, the people added. But her departure, following the loss of several other prominent dealmakers over the past year, rattled staff to the point where executives felt they had to respond, people familiar with the bank said.

Executive turnover is a fact of life on Wall Street, and banks routinely lose veteran dealmakers. But the losses, including three announced departures during the week of August5, prompted BofA executives to reach out to staff to try to contain possible fallout.

Addressing concerns
The outreach underscored executives' concerns that a steady loss of senior rainmakers during a capital-markets boom could hurt morale and reinforce perceptions that the nation's second-largest bank had fallen behind its rivals in investment banking, the people familiar with the matter said. "We have strong momentum across our global business and represent clients in a lead advisory role in numerous industry defining transactions," a BofA spokesperson said in a statement to *Reuters*. "We have recruited dozens of senior bankers this year from our major competitors, reflecting the strength of our platform and the breadth of solutions to serve clients across the U.S. and around the world."

Competition intensifies
Bankers at rival Wall Street institutions have described BofA's banking staff as formidable competitors for merger deals and clients. But the bank ranks fourth on the Dealogic global league table for investment banking fees in 2025 and 2026, after the AI boom vaulted Morgan Stanley past BofA into third place, data and analytics company Dealogic said. In 2022, 2023 and 2024, BofA claimed the third spot behind JPMorgan and Goldman Sachs and ahead of Morgan Stanley, Dealogic said.

Meanwhile, a steady stream of departures over the past year has drawn attention. In late 2025, technology dealmaker Kevin Brunner, known for cultivating strong ties to software firm Salesforce for over a quarter of a century at the bank, said he would join JPMorgan. David Fishman, who was Bank of America's co-head of technology, media and telecom and a 16-year veteran, will join JPMorgan later this year. The week Lissauer departed, co-head of global investment banking Mike Joo and techbanker Ed Liu also left.

Behind AI sector's independent review call, fight over what becomes public

Anthropic and OpenAI seek influence over what evaluators can publish, sources say; AI labs are concerned about leaks of intellectual property, people say; language in certain contracts bars evaluators from disclosing information without firm's consent, document reviewed by *Reuters* shows

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
NEW YORK

Anthropic and OpenAI have sought significant control over what outside evaluators can publish, concerned that findings could reveal trade secrets, according to two people familiar with the discussions.

Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei said last month that external evaluators should have the right to publish key findings "without editorial control." OpenAI agreed days later, saying assessors should have "editorial independence."

The AI companies are worried that evaluator staff working inside the companies' walls as part of so-called embedded evaluation could take proprietary information to rivals, according to the people, who declined to be named as the matter was private.

Measures under discussion to prevent intellectual-property leaks include having lab employees observe embedded teams as they work and preventing evaluators embedded at one lab from working at another simultaneously, one of the people added.

But what labs consider crucial intellectual property can overlap with information relevant to judging a model's risk, which can lead to arguments and redactions, said a separate person with knowledge of past dealings with the labs.



New dilemma: Firms building powerful AI models could dictate how systems are examined. REUTERS

Cause for concern
Experts have said independence of evaluators is a concern as Anthropic and OpenAI choose who gets to carry out the reviews. *Reuters* is reporting details of these negotiations between the evaluators and the AI labs for the first time.

The discussions highlight the tension between a need to make the world aware of powerful and potentially dangerous AI and demands to safeguard trade secrets by AI companies seeking trillion-dollar valuations in what could be major IPOs.

The outcome of the talks will help determine how the world scrutinises a technology that some of its creators warn may be advancing beyond humanity's ability to manage.

> 'What labs consider crucial intellectual property can overlap with information relevant to judging a model's risk, which can lead to arguments and redactions'

Without agreed standards and legislation for independent reviews, some experts said the companies building the most powerful AI models could dictate how their systems are examined, leaving evaluators at the mercy of the labs themselves.

Publication rights
The nature of the discussions changed quickly. The two people with knowledge of the matter said that as recently as October 5, Anthropic and OpenAI were seeking strict editorial control over what the evaluators could publish. By October 8, talks between Anthropic and some evaluators appeared to have evolved, according to one person familiar with the matter.

In response to questions from *Reuters*, Anthropic said that seeking significant control over embedded evaluators' publications did not accurately characterise all of its discussions and work with independent evaluators.

The company behind the Claude AI models said that, in current conversations with evaluators it previously worked with, it had made clear that the outside reviewers control their methods, evaluation criteria, conclusions and what to publish. For new evaluator firms, Anthropic said it reserved the right to comment on and approve reports as the reviewers learn how its models operate and establish a working relationship.

OpenAI, for its part, said it was not seeking approval rights over the full text of reports produced by evaluators. It said its standard practice is to redact confidential information, and evaluators can disclose whether major redactions were made.

The ChatGPT maker said last month that AI labs and assessors should agree on the scope and access before testing, disclose methods and conflicts, and let assessors control their findings, while allowing labs to protect sensitive information.

The language AI labs already use in certain contracts with firms that evaluate their models can bar those firms from publishing confidential information in their reports without the companies' consent, according to a contract seen by *Reuters*.

Anthropic last month said that Faculty, Accenture's specialist AI business, would be its first embedded evaluator, but said details on what evaluators can access and how they report findings were still being worked out.

"Evaluators are only useful if people can trust what they report, so independence and transparency are critical," Faculty CEO Marc Warner told *Reuters*.

Technology companies typically bar the firms they work with from sharing such information with others without their consent.

But experts said the stakes are higher with AI, technology that, according to its developers, will have major implications for humans. The labs could control the access evaluators depend on in the absence of standards, giving them leverage over what gets reported, Rumman Chowdhury, former U.S. Science Envoy for AI under the Biden administration and CEO of Humane Intelligence PBC, told *Reuters*.

"Evaluators have this very privileged access, but whether explicitly or implicitly, they know that it comes at a cost," Chowdhury said. Independent evaluation was one of four safety measures in the one-page White House Accord on Super Intelligence, signed by President Donald Trump and leading AI executives late last month.

When hackers come knocking on fridge door

EXPLAINER

Reuters

Hackers who sabotaged refrigeration systems at hundreds of French supermarkets exploited the growing connectivity of equipment that was once largely mechanical.

From refrigerators and heating systems to security cameras and alarm networks, an expanding range of devices can now be monitored and controlled remotely, creating new opportunities for cybercriminals.

Get into the Fridge?
In theory, yes. If a device is connected to the internet, directly or through an app, cloud service or home network, it can potentially be hacked. In 2015, researchers demonstrated at a Las Vegas hacking conference how a Samsung smart refrigerator could be compromised, allowing them to intercept some of the Internet traffic passing through the device.



Fresh vulnerabilities: A woman walks past empty refrigerators at Intermarché Supermarket in France following a cyberattack. AFP

In many cases, attackers are more interested in stealing data, disrupting services or using connected devices as a way into a larger network.

Types of devices
The most common targets are devices connected to the Internet and controlled remotely. These include security cameras, video doorbells, alarm systems, smart locks, thermostats and central heating systems. Smart appliances such as refrigerators, ovens and washing machines can also be vulnerable if they are connected to the wider Internet. Even some toothbrushes are now Internet-connected.

Routers, not appliances, account for more than three-quarters of all attacks on connected devices, according to security-industry data. The number of such devices has grown rapidly as manufacturers have added Internet connectivity to products that were once entirely mechanical.

What can a hacker do?
Once inside a device, a hacker can generally do one of two things: gather information or take control of the device.

A camera can show the inside of a home, a device with a microphone can pick up sound, and a compromised router can expose everything that travels through the network.

Hackers who take control of a device can switch it on or off, change settings or lock users out of their accounts. A compromised thermostat could affect heating, while a hacked freezer or refrigerator could disrupt temperature controls.

In more serious cases, attackers may use poorly secured devices to gain access to other systems on the same network or to steal personal information linked to online accounts.

Cybersecurity researchers have repeatedly demonstrated vulnerabilities in connected vehicles.

Control of vehicles
In 2015, researchers remotely took control of a moving Jeep through its Internet-connected entertainment system, forcing the recall of about 1.4 million vehicles and the deployment of software fixes.

Nearly a decade later, researchers disclosed a flaw that allowed them to track, unlock and start certain Kia vehicles using only a licence plate number. The researchers said they reported the vulnerabilities to Kia, which fixed them within months, and there was no evidence they had been exploited in real-world attacks. Modern vehicles and aircraft are also designed with extensive safety and back-up systems.

'Banking watchdogs ramp up cyber scrutiny on stability fears'

Reuters
NEW YORK/LONDON

Banking regulators are stepping up efforts to contain growing AI risks, six people familiar with the matter said, with some pointing to the potential for cyberattacks on banks or rogue agents undermining global financial stability.

The regulatory scrutiny, fresh details of which are reported here for the first time, reflects growing recognition that advances in frontier AI may require costly investments in cyber recovery, greater attention to dependencies on external technology providers and in some jurisdictions more formal regulatory guidance, sources said.

Three top regulators in the U.S. , including the Federal Reserve, are quizzing banks about their use of advanced artificial intelligence models, two of the people told *Reuters*, which adds to prior scrutiny.

Chinese technology
Questions include whether they deploy Chinese-developed technology, use AI agents in cyber defence and can control increasingly autonomous systems, three of the people said.

In Europe, supervisors including the Bank of England and the European Central Bank are pressing banks to improve recovery plans, concerned that rapid advances in AI could cause serious harm and disruption in financial markets sooner than previously feared, three people with knowledge of their thinking said. A senior executive at a large European bank said they too are worried about potentially major damage to banking and financial markets within six months. The debate over AI oversight has intensified amid warnings from the industry after recent incidents, with JPMorgan CEO Jamie Dimon urging corporate leaders to join a U.S.-focused industry group to address AI risks, Reuters reported.



Huge risk: Advances in frontier AI may require costly investments in cyber recovery. REUTERS

US cybersecurity company CrowdStrike said this month a person in China likely used a Chinese-developed AI agent and Anthropic's Claude Code in a hack on South Korean banks. Rogue AI agents developed by OpenAI were meanwhile involved in a breach of AI platform Hugging Face, Reuters reported.

Escape human control
Anthropic researchers have warned that increasingly powerful AI systems could eventually escape human control and even pose an existential threat, prompting calls for stricter regulation.

The International Monetary Fund warned on Tuesday against "complacency" in global financial markets, citing various risks including the potential for a cyberattack. The IMF said a major attack affecting a critical service or financial institution could undermine confidence, and it called on policymakers to boost cybersecurity capacity. Banks are competing to adopt agentic AI, which can accomplish tasks with minimal human supervision, while also grappling with the challenges of new models including IT weaknesses flagged by Anthropic's Mythos tool.

Outpacing control
"The adoption of AI is often outpacing the ability to put the controls in place," said Michael Woodbridge, London-based cybersecurity partner at Grant Thornton.

The U.S. regulatory inquiries centre on how banks use agentic AI in areas such as cybersecurity, focusing on whether AI agents are being used to identify, prioritise and respond to threats.

Questions from the Office of the Comptroller of the Currency (OCC) and the Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation (FDIC) and the Fed focus on what limits are placed on systems, how their actions are monitored and approved and whether banks can clearly track and audit AI agent decisions, people said.

They are also asking what safeguards exist to prevent agents from exceeding authority, whether humans remain involved in key decisions and how banks can shut down autonomous systems. The OCC, the Fed and the FDIC declined to comment.

PARIS

French unions say 480,000 people took part in pro-student protests



REUTERS

French unions said that around 480,000 people took part in nationwide demonstrations held on Tuesday to back student protests. French authorities have not yet given their own estimate. The last nationwide rallies supporting the student movement, held on Thursday last week, saw 71,500 people turn out. AFP

JERUSALEM

Palestinians displaced from refugee camp will not return: Netanyahu



AP

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu vowed on Tuesday that displaced residents of a Palestinian refugee camp would not be allowed to return to their homes, after the supreme court ordered the government to provide a timetable for their return. He also referred to the Tulkarm refugee camp as a "terror stronghold". AFP

LAHORE

Six killed, 40 injured as passenger train derails in Pakistan's Punjab



AFP

A Peshawar-bound passenger train derailed in Pakistan's Punjab province on Tuesday, killing at least six people and injuring 40 others, police said. The accident occurred at around 5.15 a.m. when the Rehman Baba Express was travelling from Karachi to Peshawar, according to police information. PTI

BEIRUT

Hezbollah announces aid for those displaced in Lebanon due to war



AFP

Hezbollah announced on Tuesday an aid programme for Lebanese who lost their homes in the war with Israel, with benefits capped at $14,000 per household, despite U.S. and Lebanese sanctions on the militant group. It will pay the assistance in four instalments over the course of a year, the head of Hezbollah's Executive Council said. AFP

Saudi Arabia strikes oil facility in Yemen's capital, say Houthis

The group threatens to target Riyadh International Airport, a refinery, and an Aramco facility in Dammam if Saudi Arabia proceeds with the strike; Trump accuses Houthis of trying to drive up the oil prices ahead of the U.S. midterm elections

Agence France-Presse
SANAA

Yemen's Houthis (Ansar Allah) said Saudi Arabia struck an oil facility in Sanaa on Tuesday, after the Riyadh-led coalition told civilians to leave the surrounding area in its first evacuation order for the Yemeni capital since the war flared up again.

After a series of strikes on the kingdom's airports and energy sites, the coalition's spokesperson said people should leave an oil facility belonging to the Yemen Petroleum Company on the western outskirts of Sanaa before it was attacked.



The Saudi-led coalition's warning was its first evacuation order for Yemen's capital, Sanaa, since the war escalated again. AFP

An *AFP* correspondent in Sanaa reported hearing an explosion, while a breaking news alert on the Houthi-affiliated *Al-Masirah TV* channel said "Saudi aggression targets the oil company in Al-Sabaha, west of Sanaa".

The Saudi-led coalition is yet to confirm the reported strike.

Swiftly responding to the earlier coalition warning, the Houthis had issued a threat to target Riyadh's international airport, a refinery, and an Aramco facility in Dammam if the strike went ahead.

"The Yemeni Armed Forces urge all citizens to immediately evacuate and move away from targets that our forces will strike should the Saudi enemy target," military spokesperson Yahya Saree wrote on X, identifying the three targets.

Saudi Arabia was still weathering fresh attacks on Tuesday, with the coalition saying its forces intercepted three drones north of the kingdom's capital Riyadh.

Many countries have issued travel warnings to their citizens in Saudi Arabia, most recently France, which told its citizens to avoid the airports in Riyadh, Jeddah and Dammam on Tuesday.

Meanwhile, U.S. President Donald Trump on Tuesday accused Houthi militants of deliberately trying to drive up oil prices ahead of the midterm elections and warned that he would "never forget" their attacks on Saudi Arabia.

"The Houthis are behaving very badly," Mr. Trump wrote in a Truth Social post, accusing the group of resuming attacks at Iran's behest after a period of relative quiet following U.S. strikes in Yemen last year.

Iran trying to hit military sites in U.K., says intel chief

Associated Press
LONDON

Iran is trying to hit military sites in Britain and the suspected plot to attack a U.S.-run military airbase in September is "not unique", the head of the MI5 spy agency said on Tuesday, as he warned that both Tehran and Moscow are expanding their attacks against the United Kingdom.



Ken McCallum speaks at Thames House, the headquarters of the U.K.'s Security Service in London on Tuesday. REUTERS

Ken McCallum, who leads the U.K.'s domestic security service, said Tehran is seeking to intensify its attacks in Britain beyond the traditional targets of Iranians opposed to the country's Islamic authorities. That has included arson and sabotage attacks on Jewish sites that Britain says were carried out by Iranian proxies.

Mr. McCallum said another "major shift this year has been Iranian ambitions to come at harder targets, like military sites".

The incident at RAF Fairford "is not unique. There have been other examples, not just in the U.K. but around the world," Mr. McCallum said.

He delivered his annual speech outlining major threats to the U.K. as counterterror detectives investigate a suspected terror plot against the U.S.-run base in western England, which has been used to bomb Iran during this year's war.

Prime Minister Andy Burnham said on Monday that the apparent plot was "almost certainly" directed by Iran's Revolutionary Guard though Iran has denied involvement.

Ukraine's EU accession bid moves ahead with new talks

Agence France-Presse
BRUSSELS

The European Union opened new areas of negotiations with Ukraine on Tuesday, marking a key step in Kyiv's long path to join the bloc.

The move came after Ukrainian lawmakers passed legislation protecting the rights of national minorities, removing a major hurdle in Kyiv's bid for membership.

"We have today reached another milestone on Ukraine's EU membership journey," said Thomas Byrne, the Europe Minister for Ireland, which holds the bloc's rotating presidency.

"Today's decision demonstrates Ukraine's resilience and determination to move forward on reforms, against the backdrop of extremely difficult



Thomas Byrne

circumstances."

The status of the Hungarian-speaking minority in western Ukraine had long caused tensions with Budapest. Hungary had blocked Ukraine's EU membership bid, officially submitted days after Russia's full-scale invasion in February 2022.

Aspiring EU members have to carry out sweeping reforms to comply with the bloc's norms ranging from environmental policy to agriculture.

To join the bloc, 35 negotiation chapters grouped under six overarching thematic areas – known as "clusters" – have to be completed.

Then a unanimous decision by the 27 member states to accept a new member is necessary.

"Ukraine is fully committed to the reforms required for membership, and intend to move through this work as quickly as possible," Ukraine's Deputy Prime Minister Vsevolod Chentsov told a press conference in Luxembourg.

The EU said talks with Ukraine would now start on "internal market" and "competitiveness and inclusive growth", leaving only two of the six clusters still closed.

The EU also announced progress in its talks with Albania, another candidate.

Basic needs



A hut made of cardboard boxes, built and used as shelter by migrants staying on El Trampolín Beach in the Spanish enclave of Ceuta. King Felipe VI and Queen Letizia visited Ceuta in North Africa on Tuesday in a show of solidarity with residents and victims of migration crisis. AP

Duane Davis sentenced to minimum 40 years for Tupac killing

Agence France-Presse
LOS ANGELES

Duane Davis, the former Los Angeles gang leader who boasted in books and interviews of his involvement in the killing of rapper Tupac Shakur, only to deny it when he came to trial, was sentenced to a minimum 40 years in prison on Tuesday.

"You don't get to take a man from his family. You don't get to take his very life, his whole future from him, and just walk away from it. Especially when that man is Tupac Shakur," Judge Carli Kierny said as she handed down the 40-years-to-life sentence.

Shakur was 25 when he was gunned down in Las Vegas.

11 sailors go missing after drone sinks ship off Bulgaria's coast

Reuters
SOFIA

Eleven sailors were missing at sea on Tuesday from a ship sunk by a drone attack off the coast of Bulgaria, the second deadly sinking of a cargo vessel in the area in a week, prompting Bulgaria to summon Russia's Ambassador.

Two cargo ships were hit by drones overnight and one was sunk, Bulgarian officials said. Bulgaria stopped short of explicitly accusing Russia of carrying out the attacks but Prime Minister Rumen Radev said their outcome "benefits Russian Federation".

"This is absolutely unacceptable – another attack in the immediate vicinity of Bulgarian territorial waters," Mr. Radev said.

Bulgarian Defence Minister Dimitar Stoyanov said it would be "illogical for the Ukrainians to strike their own ships".

The attacks were also condemned by Ukraine and the EU.

Russia hits no energy targets in Ukraine for the first time since Trump's 'ceasefire'

Reuters
KYIV

Russia hit no Ukrainian energy targets on Tuesday for the first time since U.S. President Donald Trump's weekend announcement of an "energy ceasefire", while hammering cities' transport and logistics overnight with ballistic missiles and drones.

Russia's Defence Ministry, in its daily summary of overnight strikes, made no mention of Ukrainian energy facilities. A Kremlin spokesperson, asked about the energy ceasefire, would only say that contacts were ongoing, but declined to provide any further details. However, one missile came down just over a kilometre from a plant providing heating to much of the city of Lviv, in the west.



A police officer inspects the engine of a Shahed drone in front of a residential building damaged in a Russian strike in Kyiv. AP

Mr. Trump's ceasefire announcement on Sunday came two days after his declaration of a deal that lifted U.S. sanctions on Russian diesel exports to allow Russia to supply almost 2 million metric tonnes of diesel, a bid to lower U.S. fuel prices.

President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on Tuesday that Ukraine had not hit Russian refineries for two days, since Trump announced the ceasefire, but that Russia had continued attacks on energy and critical infrastructure during that time. Russia struck six Ukrainian energy sites on Monday.

Trump says he does not believe China, Russia helping Iran

Reuters
WASHINGTON

U.S. President Donald Trump said late on Monday he did not believe that China and Russia were helping Iran "at all", adding that Moscow and Beijing had "too much to lose" if they enabled Tehran.

Mr. Trump said on Truth Social that he had seen comments from his critics and opponents that China and Russia were helping Iran.

"If they are, it's at a very low level, but I don't believe they are at all. They have too much to lose, and we would know about it, and know about it very fast," Mr. Trump wrote.

Mr. Trump said in July he trusted China and Russia not to help Tehran in the Iran war, but warned that if they did get involved "it would be very bad for them".

The *Washington Post* and the *Wall Street Journal* reported in March that Russia was providing Iran with targeting information.



A participant at a protest against then Hungary's Prime Minister Viktor Orban in Budapest in March 2025. AFP

Hungary removes 'anti-LGBTQ' parts from Orban-era law

Agence France-Presse
BUDAPEST

Hungarian lawmakers on Tuesday voted to remove anti-LGBTQ provisions in a 2021 "child protection" law adopted under nationalist ex-leader Viktor Orban.

Parliament passed a bill to amend the law with 139 votes in favour and 51 votes against, marking the first significant reversal of Mr. Orban's curbs targeting the LGBTQ community since pro-EU Prime Minister Peter Magyar took power in May.

Instead of banning the "portrayal" or "promotion" of sexual and gender diversity in content accessible to children, the new law will simply seek to protect under-18s from material that can "seriously impair the child's physical, intellectual, emotional or moral development".

Mr. Magyar won a landslide victory in April elections, ending a 16-year stretch in power for Mr. Orban.

The European Union welcomed the vote as an "important signal of commitment for our common values" after Mr. Orban's restrictions were found to be in breach of EU rules.

Mr. Magyar did not address LGBTQ rights during his election campaign, though he has since struck a friendly tone and indicated willingness to revise some Orban-era policies.

But ahead of the vote on Tuesday, he cast the planned changes not as a restoration of rights but a strengthening of child-protection rules "regardless of sexual orientation".

Mr. Orban's Fidesz party voted against the amendment, accusing the government of "neutering" the original law due to EU pressure.

However, the governing Tisza party has a comfortable two-thirds majority, which enabled it to pass the bill without any opposition support.

In Trump's pardons for public officials, Republicans win most of the mercy

Reuters review identifies at least 85 public officials were granted clemency by the U.S. President after corruption-related charges or convictions; of them, 36 were elected Republicans and 19 Republican appointees; recipients were spared 130 years in prison and more than $15 million in penalties

Reuters
WASHINGTON

In October 2024, a federal jury in Las Vegas convicted Michele Fiore, a local elected official and ardent supporter of President Donald Trump, of charity fraud. Fiore, the jury found, solicited donations for a slain police officer's memorial and spent nearly $80,000 of it on plastic surgery, her daughter's wedding and rent.

The jury deliberated for less than two hours, including a lunch break, before finding Fiore guilty on seven charges brought by the Department of Justice.

Weeks before she was to be sentenced last year, Mr. Trump granted Fiore "a full and unconditional pardon", sparing her the prospect of decades in prison, payment of criminal fines, and any restitution to donors whose funds she misspent. In a statement at the time, a White House spokesperson noted Fiore's support for the President and said that Biden-era prosecutors had targeted the politician, known in Nevada as "Lady Trump", because of "outspoken conservative views".

In an email to Reuters, Fiore criticised prosecutors and witnesses and maintained her innocence. "I have never taken one red cent of donations for my personal use," she wrote. She declined to answer detailed questions about her career, case and conviction.

Fiore is one of at least 85 public officials granted clemency by Mr. Trump after charges or convictions related to corruption, according to the first comprehensive examination of such measures over the President's two terms in office so far. The *Reuters* review shows that the political impetus behind Fiore's pardon was not an outlier: The recipients of Mr. Trump's clemency for public officials overwhelmingly have been fellow Republicans or vocal proponents of his MAGA movement.



Trump supporters Michele Fiore, who was convicted for charity fraud, was one of at least 85 public officials granted pardon. REUTERS

'Erosion of public trust'

They include at least 11 of 15 Republican members of Congress convicted of wrongdoing over the past two decades. Of the 85 public officials identified in *Reuters*' analysis, 36 were elected as Republicans and another 19 were Republicans appointed to political office. Nine others had either campaigned for Mr. Trump or publicly espoused support for his agenda. Only four were known Democrats, including one Texas congressman whom Mr. Trump erroneously believed would switch parties after the pardon.

The news agency could not determine partisan affiliation for the 17 other officials.

Mr. Trump's repeated acts of clemency for public officials charged with or convicted of corruption-related crimes have led to what more than a dozen current and former prosecutors, along with other legal experts and political researchers, say is impunity for people meant to uphold public trust. The impunity, these people said, can encourage more wrongdoing by other officials, eroding the foundational democratic concept that no one, no matter what office they hold, is above the law. The problem, they added, is compounded if the concept of clemency is tainted by perceptions of partisan or personal bias.

"President Trump is trying to end accountability for public officials," said Phillip Halpern, a retired assistant U.S. attorney in San Diego who prosecuted two Republican congressmen Mr. Trump later pardoned. "He's setting a standard to encourage corruption and allow it to flourish."

Mr. Trump's absolution has allowed nearly three-quarters of the 85 officials in *Reuters*' analysis to leave prison early, evade trials or sentencing, or regain eligibility to exercise certain freedoms, like owning a gun. In total, the analysis found, these people were spared 130 years behind bars and avoided payment of more than $15 million in financial penalties.

Noting his own indictments by federal prosecutors during the presidency of Joe Biden, Mr. Trump has said he aims to right the wrongs by a DOJ that he has claimed - repeatedly and without evidence - targeted innocent people for partisan purposes. "I am your warrior," he told a conservative gathering in 2023, while campaigning for re-election. "I am your justice. And for those who have been wronged and betrayed, I am your restribution," Mr. Trump said.

Administration officials have repeatedly defended the President's use of the pardon power, granted by the Constitution and ample in scope. Lauren Bis, a White House spokesperson, in a statement said Mr. Trump grants clemency for "many Americans unjustly prosecuted by the Biden administration's weaponized Department of Justice."

Reuters' review encompassed clemency recipients who held an elected or appointed government role or were employed in the civil or uniformed services. Most were paid from government coffers. Recipients included seven advisors to Mr. Trump, three DOJ officials, three governors, 10 state lawmakers, two city council members, two judges and two sheriffs. Their charges and crimes included fraud, bribery, conspiracy, racketeering, obstruction of justice and others.

Reuters' tally of public officials does not include at least 18 active-duty military, police and government employees who were among those charged with or convicted for storming the U.S. Capitol on January 6, 2021. Before Mr. Trump issued his blanket clemency for the roughly 1,500 people involved in the riot, many of these 18 had used their official credentials to rally others against the peaceful transfer of power after the 2020 election.

Some of Mr. Trump's predecessors have also drawn fire for controversial use of the pardon power, most recently Mr. Biden because of clemency for his son, Hunter, convicted on federal gun and tax charges. Both Mr. Biden and former President Barack Obama commuted more prison sentences than Mr. Trump, cutting short the punishments of many non-violent drug offenders. But over his nearly six years in office so far, Mr. Trump has granted far more pardons than any other recent President, particularly through his mass clemency for the Capitol rioters.

Sending signals

Earlier this year, *Reuters* examined the President's upending of the pardon process. In nearly 2,000 acts of clemency, Mr. Trump has forgone longstanding practice of presidents working with the DOJ to evaluate who should merit clemency. He has instead relied on a growing number of clemency consultants who, leveraging close ties to the President or his inner circle, advocate for would-be recipients.

The shift, the news agency found, has marginalised the DOJ, where a series of guidelines shaped the process for more than a century and sought to ensure that recipients admit guilt and espouse remorse before receiving clemency.

New hypersonic weapons highlight arms race on the Korean peninsula

Agence France-Presse
SEOUL

South Korea test-fired its first homegrown hypersonic missile last week, days after the North announced the AI-assisted launch of an intermediate-range hypersonic missile.

On its AI-assisted missile, Pyongyang has said there was "no way to avoid" the missile that was "capable of changing its flight orbit at a low altitude". It also said that the missile's "wave-like trajectory mode" left South Korea and Japan unable to track it effectively.

Hong Min of the Korea Institute for National Unification told AFP the launch was "a demonstration of an entire range of missile systems". "It sends a signal that North Korea has weapons capable of evading interception across different ranges," he said.



A picture released by North Korea shows the test-firing of a tactical ballistic missile conducted on Monday. AFP

South Korea called its missle a "key strategic asset capable of changing the course of the battlefield". Its "unpredictable flight trajectories and overwhelming speed" could enable strikes on key strategic targets and provide a new deterrence capability on the peninsula, it said.

The decision for Seoul to publicly disclose the test was also a political one, said Jung Heon-joo, a public policy professor at Yonsei University in Seoul. "Possessing this hypersonic technology could signal to potential adversaries that South Korea has a range of weapons options and that attacking it would not be easy," he told AFP.

North Korea also fired multiple ballistic missiles off its east coast on Monday, with experts saying the mixed launches may have been intended to complicate the ability of South Korean and U.S. defence systems to respond.

Cyclone fury



Damaged properties: Waves from post-tropical cyclone Rachel crash into beachfront homes in Long Beach, California, on Monday. Powerful Pacific Ocean waves stirred up by Rachel battered the coast of Southern California on the day. AP

Saudis probe how defence systems failed to stop attack on Riyadh airport

Associated Press
CAIRO

Saudi Arabia has launched an investigation to determine how its air defences failed to intercept a barrage of missiles and drones fired by Iran-backed Houthi rebels, including an attack on Riyadh airport that killed at least 13 people and wounded over 300, two regional officials said on Monday.

The officials, who spoke on condition of anonymity, said the initial probe showed that Yemen's Houthis first fired multiple drones to pave the way for a mix of cruise and ballistic missiles to reach Riyadh's King Khalid International Airport.

The Houthis possess ballistic missiles and advanced systems fitted with warheads that can change direction during flight and pose a challenge to Patriot interceptors and other defence systems used by the Saudis.

One of the officials said the investigation also aims to find out why air defence systems did not provide earlier warning of the attack in which the Houthi missiles and drones flew over 1,000 km to reach Riyadh.

The incident, one of a string of Houthi attacks since last week on Saudi airports, has exposed vulnerabilities in Saudi Arabia's defence system and signalled a dangerous inflection point in an expanding West Asia conflict that began more than seven months ago when the U.S. and Israel launched their war against Iran.

The Saudi-led coalition also said it had twice intercepted and destroyed ballistic missiles launched on Monday by the Houthis towards Riyadh. At least three explosions could be heard on Monday night in the city. Civil defence officials later said the danger had passed.

'Serious events'

The rebels later said they had targeted King Khalid Airport on Monday, warning international airlines that all Saudi airports, except those in the Muslim holy cities of Mecca and Medina, were unsafe.

Earlier on Monday, the Saudi state-run media reported that its military was responding to a new attack involving drones and cruise missiles, but provided no details.



A file photo shows King Khalid International Airport in Riyadh, which has been targeted by the Yemeni Houthis. AFP

"The events of recent weeks are serious," Saudi Energy Minister Prince Abdul Aziz bin Salman told the World Petroleum Energy Congress in Riyadh on Monday. "Our response must be equally serious."

The Saudi government-run Center for International Communication did not immediately respond to a request for comment about the probe into defence failures.

The Saudis want the U.S. to become more directly involved in their fight against the Houthis. The U.S. has provided intelligence sharing, target identification and planning for a Saudi-led offensive, but has held off on carrying out strikes against the Houthis.

A U.S. intervention could prompt the Houthis to try to halt shipping through the Bab el-Mandeb Strait at the southern end of the Red Sea off Yemen, restricting the flow of oil out of the Persian Gulf.

The flow of West Asian oil has already been complicated by Iranian efforts to choke off the Strait of Hormuz, where about one-fifth of the world's oil flowed before the U.S.-Iran war began.

The rebels seized key areas along the Bab el-Mandeb last month. The Saudi-led coalition has been trying to retake them.

U.S. President Donald Trump told reporters on Saturday after the deadly airport strike that he was looking at the possibility of carrying out U.S. attacks against the Houthis.

U.S. response

Mr. Trump said Monday that he had spoken with Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, but did not offer any details about the call. He also said the Houthis were "misbehaving very badly," but did not say anything about whether the U.S. would respond to the rebels.

Later on Monday, when asked if the U.S. will defend Saudi Arabia after Houthi attacks, Mr. Trump said, "You'll find out soon."

The conflict comes at a delicate time for Mr. Trump, just weeks before United States midterm elections that will decide if his Republican Party keeps control of Congress.

Persistent inflation and high gas prices fuelled by the ongoing conflict with Iran have driven widespread American disapproval of that war. Expanding U.S. military involvement in the region risks further stoking voters' resentment.

Yemen's Houthi-run health ministry said on Monday that airstrikes on a government complex and a house in the northern province of al-Jawf killed nine people, according to the Houthi-controlled SABA news agency.

Ministry spokesperson Anees al-Asbahi said 107 Yemenis have been killed by the Saudi-led coalition since September 3, and 278 were injured. Over 60% of casualties were women and children, he said.

LESSON LEARNT

Until the umpire signals a four, I will keep running: Tilak



PTI

Tilak Varma addressed the run-out in Indore, which had been much discussed. “There was a flash on the advertising board. I felt that the ball touched the board and came back inside. Axar [Patel] felt the same, so we both stopped. Going forward, until the umpire signals a boundary, I will just keep running!”

SUCCESS FORMULA

Our players need to adapt when the pressure is on: Sammy



PTI

Daren Sammy dismissed the notion that West Indies was overdependent on Shai Hope, pointing to contributions from Brandon King (ODIs), Shimron Hetmyer and Sherfane Rutherford (T20Is). “Some of our players need to adapt to that calmness when the pressure is on. But Hope is not the only reason we win.”

DOUBLE DELIGHT

Gill wins a record fifth ICC PoTM award; Shafali, too, tops



FILE PHOTO: EMMANUAL YOGINI

India captain Shubman Gill was on Tuesday named ICC men’s Player of the Month for a record fifth time after his outstanding performance in the ODI series against the West Indies. Opener Shafali Verma bagged the women’s honour for her impressive show in the Asia Cup and Asian Games.

HIGH-PROFILE SIGNING

Yuvraj appointed Delhi Capitals assistant and batting coach



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A week after Sourav Ganguly’s appointment as head coach, Delhi Capitals roped in another high-profile name in Yuvraj Singh on Tuesday as part of its support staff for the 2027 Indian Premier League season. The 44-year-old Yuvraj joins Capitals as assistant coach and batting coach.

India and WI willow-wielders glove up for another blast

The host is one win away from sealing a series victory; the Men in Blue scored 297 the last time they took strike here in a T20I; Shreyas & Co. will need to iron out chinks in the bowling department; the visitor has been far from a pushover

WI IN INDIA

Anirudh Velamuri
HYDERABAD

The story so far has been more about fireworks than finesse.

In Lucknow, Shreyas Iyer’s maiden T20I hundred powered India to victory in 14.4 overs. Ranchi brought a jolt, as Shai Hope and Sherfane Rutherford ended the host’s run of 10 straight wins in completed T20Is. Indore swung it back, with Abhishek Sharma and Arshdeep Singh engineering a 14-run triumph.

Now the series moves to the Rajiv Gandhi International Stadium on Wednesday, which has long been kind to T20 batters. In India’s last outing here, against Bangladesh in October 2024, it ended three runs short of 300. It is also home to Sunrisers Hyderabad, the IPL’s most trigger-happy side.

The host will lean on a top-order that has taken turns to blaze away. While the West Indies has struggled to contain the firepower, it has been far from a pushover. That said, it will need a more complete performance to unsettle the reigning world champion and keep the series alive.



Dynamites: Southpaws Kishan and Rutherford can pack a punch. K.R. DEEPAK

Only one match out of six on this tour has been won while defending a total, when India did so in Indore, where dew stayed away and made a difference for the Indian bowlers.

It could be the same case in Hyderabad too, which has seen average temperatures vary between 31-34 °C the last few days.

Bowling is India’s big question, especially in the absence of pace ace Jasprit Bumrah. It couldn’t defend 249 in Ranchi and head coach Gautam Gambhir flagged concerns over white-ball pitches after the run-fest.

The surface in Hyderabad adds another twist to the contest. Its top layer has been re-laid (with an 80-20 black-red soil mix), and how differently it will play, if at all, remains to be seen.

Either way, bowlers will be tested in a format where, to borrow from Keemo Paul, they either get to execute their plans or get executed.

Arshdeep’s three wickets carried India home in Indore, Naman Dhir, too, proved clinical, providing the side with another useful bowling option. For the visitor, Roston Chase leads the bowling charts and will relish another crack at Abhishek, whom he has dismissed twice in 13 balls this series.

A series win is within touching distance for India but the Windies have the nerve to make the host sweat. Between them lies a strip of freshly laid earth and 40 overs that will remember who blinked first.

Match starts at 7 p.m.

‘You can’t hit from the first ball in T20s’

Anirudh Velamuri
HYDERABAD

The Rajiv Gandhi International Stadium will open its arms for a few homegrown stars in an Indian team looking to cement its lead in the five-match T20I series against the West Indies.

Local lad Tilak Varma is aware of Uppal’s flat surfaces that have seen gargantuan T20 scores.

“We were discussing that the wickets here have been changed. But in T20s, you can’t go from the first ball. We’ve played everywhere.

“Each player has played more than 50 games in the format. You take one or two balls and get to know how the wicket is behaving, what shots to play and more,” Tilak said on Tuesday, the eve of the fourth T20I.

Happiest in the No. 3 spot, Tilak said he was happy to be malleable to the team’s demands.

“Right now my role is to handle the middle phase. If quick wickets go, I can take my time and take the game deep.

“If the top three bat till the 14th or 15th over, I know how to change gears and go from the first ball. I’ve been practising for both.”



Tilak. K.R. DEEPAK

The 23-year-old blitzed away to an unbeaten 44 off just 18 balls in Ranchi before a 16-ball 28 in Indore.

Tilak was in good spirits ahead of a fixture that could potentially decide the series and was happy that so many members in the setup are familiar with conditions in Hyderabad.

“Yes, we’ll have a slight edge. Ishan [Kishan], Nitish [Kumar], Abhishek and myself have played here many times. More than me, the others have played here more because every year they play half of their IPL games here. So they know how the wicket behaves, how the outfield is and more”.

We have to win both PowerPlays: Sammy

Anirudh Velamuri
HYDERABAD

West Indies head coach Daren Sammy felt that the PowerPlay had been the difference between his side and India this T20I series. He pointed out that India had scored at nearly 14.5 runs per over in that period and Windies had restricted the scoring rate to below 10 in subsequent phases.

“We have had to pull the game back every single time. That [PowerPlay] is an area we need to work on. To beat India in India, you really have to win both PowerPlays, with bat and ball,” he said.

According to Sammy, the Men in Maroon have matched India’s batting muscle. He referred to bowling coach Ravi Rampaul’s observation that letting the opposition hit more fours than sixes would save two runs each time. “We out-sixed them in the last game. When you play on good batting pitches, you feel you are in the game. You are just two big overs away from getting yourself back into it.”

The challenge, he believes, is greater for the bowlers. “If 200 is a par score, you have to prevent the opposition from getting to 250”.

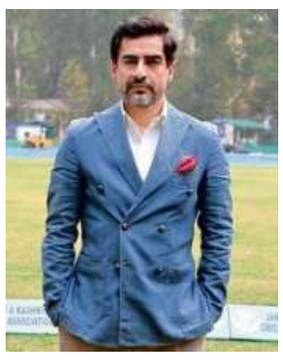
‘Fitness and form should be the criteria for selection, not age’

Shayan Acharya
SRINAGAR

Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma’s selection for the 2027 ODI World Cup should depend on fitness and performances, and not their age, said BCCI president Mithun Manhas.

“As far as the BCCI is concerned, we are not in a position to comment because it all depends on the selectors and the coaches. But from how I look at it, fitness and performance should be the criteria for selection, and definitely not age,” he told *The Hindu*.

“If somebody is fit to play, and you see him performing and winning games for the country, that is the only criterion we should focus on.”



Manhas. IMRAN NISSAR

Experience vital

Manhas believes experience will be vital as Shubman Gill prepares to lead India in the next ODI World Cup. He said the presence of Kohli, Rohit and Hardik Pandya could help Gill manage the demands of captaincy alongside Jasprit Bumrah’s leadership within the bowling group.

“Having Virat, Hardik and Rohit in the side will definitely help him. Then there is Bumrah, who could be the bowling captain, and somebody who could be the fielding captain. It’s all about distribution of workload,” Manhas said.

He felt that seniors could be crucial when the team comes under pressure, drawing on their experience in handling tough situations.

“They have been under pressure and delivered so many times in crunch situations. So, it’s valuable,” he said.

Manhas also backed India’s growing player-pool as a means of managing an increasingly demanding international calendar. With overlapping assignments and injuries posing challenges, he said the depth would help the team across formats.

Gibson does it for Royals; Marathas, Knights shine

APL

Sports Bureau
HYDERABAD

Defending champion Rajputana Royals, after a run of poor results, made it back-to-back wins with a dominant display against high-flying Chero Archers in the Archery Premier League season 2 at People’s Plaza on Tuesday. Royals, who suffered three straight losses before tasting success on Monday, were in superb form as they blanked Archers 6-0.

The result moved Royals to six points and kept them in the race for a semifinal berth. Archers, too, have six points. Mighty Marathas and Kakatiya Knights moved clear at the top of the table with eight points each. While the former defeated Prithviraj Yodhas 6-2, Knights blanked Chola Chiefs 6-0.



Royal show: Gibson struck the 10-ring on all six occasions during the day. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Dhiraj dazzles

Marathas’ recurve star Dhiraj Bommadevara was in terrific form, repeatedly shooting clutch 10s with barely any time left on the clock. Mike Schloesser set up the sets well and finished with 78 out of 80 as Marathas’ resurgence continued. They were placed on top ahead of Knights, with only set points separating the sides.

In the final match, Knights consigned Chiefs to the bottom of the table as Nico Wiener and Neeraj Chauhan were in terrific form at the start and end of the sets – both registering 59 out of 60 – while Spain’s recurve archer Elia Canales provided able support. In Jyothi Surekha’s absence, Avneet Kaur also stepped in admirably for the home franchise.

Earlier, Royals’ star was compound World No. 1 Ella Gibson, who produced a stupendous show and came up with six perfect 10s.

Archers, who went back to their recurve international archer Casey Kaufhold instead of Kumkum Mohod, lost the first set 73-74 after the American started with a 7. In the second set, Royals edged ahead 76-75 with the Chero side paying the price for a couple of 9s from their compound archers. The third set was tied 58-58 after six arrows each when Atanu Das hit a rare 8.

For Royals, Sangeeta, playing her first match in place of Ankita Bhakat, responded with a sensational 10. With 8 needed, Tokyo Olympic champion Mete Gazoz delivered a 9.

The scores:

Rajputana Royals bt Chero Archers 6-0 (74-73, 76-75, 77-75).
Mighty Marathas bt Prithviraj Yodhas 6-2 (76-74, 77-73, 70-78, 76-75).
Kakatiya Knights bt Chola Chiefs 6-0 (74-73, 79-78, 77-75).

There’s nothing you can’t achieve: Rai senior’s advice

GOLF

Ashwin Achal
NEW DELHI

After carrying the bag for his wife, Gaurika Bishnoi, at last year’s Hero Women’s Indian Open, Aaron Rai is back in the National Capital Region this year – this time to compete himself.

The 31-year-old’s profile has risen considerably since his last visit to these shores. In May, Rai stunned the golfing world by winning the PGA Championship, becoming the first Englishman to lift the title since Jim Barnes in 1919.

One of the leading contenders at this week’s DP World India Championship, Rai acknowledged that the historic triumph had changed his life.

The soft-spoken Englishman, regarded as one of the nicest men on the tour, attributes much of his success to his parents, Amrik and Dalvir, who are of Indian descent. Despite their limited financial means, they made significant sacrifices to support their son’s golfing ambitions.

His father, in particular, instilled in him the belief that there were no limits to what he could achieve. “There is nothing that you cannot achieve – that was my father’s big message. There shouldn’t be any limitations, no matter where you’re from, no matter what you have or don’t have,” Rai said at a press conference at the Delhi Golf Club here on Tuesday.



Tryst with history: Rai stunned the golfing world by winning the PGA Championship. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Rai. REUTERS

“Society can put you into boxes of what you can and cannot achieve, which creates limitations. But if you are really diligent and disciplined, every single person has a huge amount of potential that can be fulfilled,” he added.

Rai is among a rare breed of golfers who uses iron covers to appreciate the true value of his equipment. More broadly, he has sought to remain grounded and approachable, holding on to the values instilled in him.

“I think every person has that responsibility to try and be warm, and try to set good examples. We don’t understand the positivity that can create for someone else and the ripple effect that can have,” he said.

INBRIEF



Unnathi knocks out top seed Deepthi; Ribhav progresses

Unnathi Muralidhar stunned top seed Deepthi Venkatesan 6-2, 6-2 in a second round girls' under-16 match of the 31st Fenesta Open National tennis championship in New Delhi on Tuesday. However, boys' No. 1 Ribhav Saroha progressed with a 6-2, 6-2 win over Rhunmaan Mahesh.

Other results (second round):
Under-16: Boys: Lakshya Chukka bt Aarav Patel 6-1, 6-2; Paranjay Siwach bt Tanish Dasari 6-4, 7-5; Parthiv Nallagundla bt Divey Malik 7-6(2), 6-0; Yaj Malik bt Hemdev Mahesh 7-6(3), 6-4; Jeevith Sathish bt Ashwin Kabilan 7-6(3), 2-6, 6-2.
Girls: Tanusshri Sathesh bt Sanidya Karantoth 6-1, 6-1; Aaradhya Meena bt N. Krishnaprabhu 6-0, 6-1; Rishita Yadav bt Aashi Kashyap 3-6, 6-3, 6-2; Aahida Singh bt Harsha Oruganti 3-6, 6-2, 6-0; Ranjhana Sangram bt Tejaswi Manneni 4-6, 6-4, 6-3.
Under-14: Boys: Second round: Aarav Chhallani bt Rajishnu Poptani 6-1, 6-1; **First Round:** Puneeth Manohar bt Kabir Gundecha 6-1, 6-0; Nibras Hussain bt Zaayn Mohammad 6-3, 6-0; Pranav Gaikwad bt Ranveer Gawli 6-1, 6-4.
Girls: Second round: Sarena Gahlot bt Janhavi Sawant 6-2, 6-2; Sidhhi Pandey bt Aaradhya Singh 6-4, 6-3; Zoha Qureshi bt Sara Fengse 6-3, 6-2; Khushi Kadian bt Shaurya Patil 6-2, 6-1; Saanvi Mohan bt Myra Shaikh 6-4, 6-2.

F1 to return to Africa in 'early 2030s' in Rwanda

Rwanda will host a Formula One race from the early 2030s in a 10-year deal, F1 said in a statement on Tuesday. Formula One has not raced in Africa since the last South African Grand Prix was held at Kyalami, north of Johannesburg, in 1993. The track where the Rwandan race will happen is yet to be built. It will be near an international airport being built at Bugesera some 40 km (25 miles) from the capital Kigali. "Africa is home to more than 100 million Formula 1 fans, and that number continues to grow rapidly," F1 CEO Stefano Domenicali said in the statement.

Zverev set to become World No. 1 at the end of the year

The ATP confirmed it will crown a new World No. 1 as Germany's Alexander Zverev was ensured the year-end honour on Monday after Carlos Alcaraz lost his third-round match in Shanghai. The career-first will cap a stellar season for the 29-year-old, the current World No. 2, after he won the French Open in June and the US Open in September. "It's been a fantastic season for me winning in Paris and New York and knowing that I will finish the year on top of the rankings is just a dream come true," Zverev said in a statement shared by the ATP Tour website.

Ticket ballot for WC 2027 receives 1.5 crore applications

The International Cricket Council (ICC) on Tuesday said it has received over 1.5 crore ticket applications from 142 countries since the ticket ballot for the 2027 World Cup went live 12 days ago, underlining the immense global interest in the showpiece. The marquee 50-over tournament will be jointly hosted by South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia from October 2 to November 21. "A total of 15,083,752 ticket applications have been received, with 4,423,417 ballot registrations generated by fans from across 142 countries," the ICC said in a statement. The ticket ballot will remain open for registration until November 21, 2026, exactly a year before the final is scheduled to be played at the Wanderers in Johannesburg.



Coventry shocks Newcastle, makes it two in a row

Teenager Sidiki Cherif scored one and made one as host Coventry overcame a dishevelled Newcastle 4-1 and earned successive Premier League wins on Monday. "It is so hard to win but we played like the team we want to be tonight," coach Frank Lampard said.

Top results: Premier League: Coventry 4 (Rudoni 6-pen, Cherif 48, Simms 81, Mfuni 86) bt Newcastle 1 (Botman 70).
LaLiga: Levante 3 (Romero 57, De La Fuente 90+2, Ndukwe 90+10) drew with Sevilla 3 (Ure 13, Correia 54, Romero 90+5).
Serie A: Torino 2 (Braganca 36, Kulenovic 67) bt Udinese 1 (Ekkelenkamp 43); Atalanta 3 (Kessie 4, Krstovic 6, 30) bt Venezia 1 (Hainaut 37).

Steely Karun stands between Andhra and an outright win

His unbeaten 81 helps the visitors erase a 144-run first-innings deficit and could prove decisive in the outcome; Manvanth's contribution becomes vital; Shikhar records career-best six for 115

RANJI TROPHY

N. Sudarshan
VIJAYAWADA

Karun Nair kept Karnataka afloat with a steely, unbeaten 81 (130b, 8x4, 2x6) on day three of the 2026-27 Ranji Trophy opener against Andhra on Tuesday.

At the ACA Stadium in Mulapadu near here, the 34-year-old helped his side erase a 144-run first-innings deficit and close at 176 for four. But the hosts still hold the advantage, and the first session on day four will prove decisive in their victory push.

The visitors' response to Andhra's 418 began in disastrous fashion as K.L. Rahul (1) and Mayank Agarwal (18) failed again, with left-arm spinner Saurabh Kumar trapping both stalwarts in front with balls delivered from wide of the crease. However, Karnataka arrested the slide with the off-the-wall decision to send debutant left-hander Manvanth Kumar (44, 110b, 1x4, 2x6) up the order. Even as K.V. Aneesh fell for another low score (6), Manvanth and Karun combined for 94 runs.

Manvanth was reprieved on seven by Hemanth Reddy in the long-off area, and Karun was let off in the 70s when wicket-keeper Revanth Reddy couldn't effect a stumping in time as the red-cherry got stuck in his pads. Off-spinner T. Vijay was the unfortunate bowler on both occasions.

But for those two moments, Manvanth and Karun were solid. Manvanth's best shot was the straight six off Vijay; Karun too was at his resplendent best, hitting Saurabh and fellow left-arm tweaker Lalith Mohan for glorious maximums down the ground.

Manvanth was castled by Lalith six short of a deserved half-century, but skipper R. Smaran (21 batting, 43b, 1x4) ensured there would be no further damage.

In the morning, Andhra, from an overnight 331 for six, folded for 418. Centurion S.V. Rahul added only 11 runs to finish on 119, but pacer V. Sasikanth rode his luck to make 39 (104, 4x4, 1x6), and Saurabh and Lalith totalled 40 valuable runs.

Left-arm spinner Shikhar Shetty finished with career-best figures of six for 115. Will it acquire a match-saving halo?



Standing tall: Karun's defiance would be key as Karnataka hopes to salvage a draw. K.V.S. GIRI

The scores: Karnataka — 1st innings: 274 in 82.2 overs.
Andhra — 1st innings: Hemanth Reddy c Smaran b Shikhar 1, Abhishek Reddy lbw b Shikhar 30, T. Vijay c Rahul b Madhav 4, Shaik Rasheed lbw Madhav 54, Ricky Bhui c Rahul b Bhatkal 18, S.V. Rahul lbw b Ritesh 119, Revanth Reddy c Rahul b Shikhar 97, V. Sasikanth lbw b Shikhar 39, Saurabh Kumar c Shrijith b Shikhar 24, Lalith Mohan (not out) 16, K. Saiteja lbw b Shikhar 1; Extras (b-5, lb-5, w-1, nb-4): 15; Total (in 121.5 overs): 418.
Fall of wickets: 1-5, 2-10, 3-53, 4-92, 5-116, 6-318, 7-364, 8-395, 9-416.
Karnataka bowling: Abhilash 12-0-49-0, Shikhar 35.5-2-115-6, Madhav 33-4-94-2, Manvanth 4-0-33-0, Ritesh 35-3-109-2, Karun 2-0-8-0.
Karnataka — 2nd innings: Mayank Agarwal lbw b Saurabh 18, K.L. Rahul lbw b Saurabh 1, Manvanth Kumar b Lalith 44, K.V. Aneesh c Bhui b Saurabh 6, Karun Nair (batting) 81, R. Smaran (batting) 21; Extras (lb-5): 5; Total (for four wkts. in 60 overs): 176.
Fall of wickets: 1-18, 2-25, 3-43, 4-137.
Andhra bowling: Saiteja 8-1-26-0, Sasikanth 2-1-4-0, Lalith 17-1-55-1, Saurabh 18-1-41-3, T. Vijay 14-1-43-0, Rasheed 1-0-2-0.

RANJI TROPHY SCORES — ROUND ONE, DAY THREE

Elite: Group A: At Rajgir: Uttar Pradesh 540 bt Bihar 141 in 52.1 overs (Kartik Yadav 4/26, Karan Sharma 4/28) & 132 in 36.4 overs (Zeeshan Ansari 4/40). **Points: UP 7(7), Bihar 0(0).**
At Panaji: Baroda 472/8 decl. vs. Goa 199 in 71.1 overs (Snehal Kauthankar 50, Lalit Yadav 54, Mahesh Pithiya 5/58, Bhargav Bhatt 4/51) & 35/1 in 13 overs.
At Srinagar: Madhya Pradesh 196 & 151/5 in 62 overs (Shubham Sharma 51 batting) vs. Jammu & Kashmir 120.
At Nagpur: Vidarbha 428 & 22/1 in 11 overs vs. Pondicherry 313 in 114.5 overs (Ritesh Gudge 95, Nikhil Gangta 54, Mohit Kale 78).
Group B: At Hyderabad: Tripura 134 & 120 in 41.2 overs (Tanay Thyagarajann 6/52) lost to Hyderabad 294. **Hyderabad 7(7), Tripura 0(0).**
At Vijayawada: Karnataka 274 & 176/4 in 60 overs (Manvanth Kumar 44, Karun Nair 81 batting) vs. Andhra 418 in 121.5 overs. (Shaik Rasheed 54, S.V. Rahul 119, Revanth Reddy 97, Shikhar Shetty 6/115).
At New Chandigarh: Assam 373 vs. Punjab 287/5 in 96 overs (Vihaan Malhotra 103, Harnoor Singh 54).
At Rajkot: Saurashtra 392 & 45/0 in 13 overs vs. Chhattisgarh 312 in 121.5 overs (Anuj Tiwary 72 retd. hurt, Mayank Verma 68, Vikalp Tiwari 46, Rahul Pradhan 41 n.o.).
Group C: At Jamshedpur: Jharkhand 587 vs. Kerala 269/6 in 90 overs (Abhishek P. Nair 126, Rohan Kunnummal 44).
At Kalyani: Delhi 240 & 101/3 in 45 overs vs. Bengal 429 in 112 overs (Sudip Kumar Gharami 133, Abishek Porel 149, Sumata Gupta 50, Ayush Badoni 5/43).
At Ahmedabad: Odisha 324 & 119/4 in 30 overs (Sandeep Pattnaik 41 batting, Ninad Rathva 53) vs. Gujarat 439 in 106.4 overs (Aarya Desai 94, Vedant Trivedi 108, Urvil Patel 85, Harshal Patel 60, Badal Biswal 5/118).
At New Delhi: Maharashtra 333 & 66/5 in 28 overs (Arjun Sharma 4/30) vs. Services 227 in 93.2 overs (Nitin Tanwar 61, Vineet Dhankhar 40, Rajat Paliwal 44, Hitesh Walunj 5/51).
Group D: At Lahli: Himachal Pradesh 253 & 113 in 40 overs vs. Haryana 296 in 82.3 overs (Ankit Kumar 59, Yashvardhan Dalal 72, Kanishk Chouhan 50, Aryaman Singh Dhaliwal 4/72) & 26/3 in nine overs.
At Mumbai (Brabourne Stadium): Railways 278 & 34/0 in 15 overs vs. Uttarakhand 470 in 156.5 overs (Kunal Chandela 43, Avneesh Sudha 90, J. Suchith 62, Saurabh Rawat 107, Mayank Mishra 51).
At Jaipur: Rajasthan 363 & 81/4 in 34 overs vs. Tamil Nadu 274 in 98.4 overs (N. Jagadeesan 55, Pradosh Ranjan Paul 58, Andre Siddarth 81, Ajay Singh 5/51).
At Mumbai (Wankhede Stadium): Mumbai 429 bt Chandigarh 78 & 196 in 52.1 overs (Arjun Azad 62, Shivam Bambri 44). **Mumbai 7(7), Chandigarh 0(0).**
Plate: At Rangpo: Sikkim 245 & 44/0 in 28 overs vs. Meghalaya 395 in 150.2 overs (Kishan Lyngdoh 78, Swastic Chettri 73, Jaskirat Singh 127, Kranti Kumar 5/71).
At Nadiad: Mizoram 183 & 295 in 107.4 overs (Sahil Reza 51, Chinmay Sutar 99, Jehu Anderson 71, Kishan Singha 4/88) vs. Manipur 251 & 8/0 in two overs.



Tanay... Hyderabad's hero. NAGARA GOPAL

Ton-up Vihaan keeps Punjab in the hunt against Assam

Abhishek Saini
NEW CHANDIGARH

Punjab's Vihaan Malhotra (103, 208b, 11x4) struck a century on First Class debut but it was not enough to dispel Assam's stake at a first-innings lead on day three of their Ranji Trophy round one match at the New PCA Stadium here.

Evidently a first-innings shoot-off after rain washed out the first day, the contest was turning one-sided when Vihaan took the wheel in a 137-run opening partnership with Harnoor Pannu (54, 132b, 7x4). But Punjab lost five wickets for 100 runs on either side of tea.

Salil Arora and Emanjot Singh Chahal arrested the collapse with a 50-run sixth-wicket partnership, but Punjab was at 287 for five at stumps, still 86 behind.

Both Vihaan and Harnoor were true to their kind – languid, left-handed batters – and plundered the off-side in the morning session.

Harnoor had just slogged Amlanjyoti Das through the on-side, shortly after his 121-ball half-century, when he was caught in two minds on a delivery outside off against Sarupam Purkayastha and edged to the 'keeper.



Vihaan. PCA

Vihaan blundered on 95, poking a delivery outside off from Mukhtar Hussain but was dropped by the wicketkeeper. Mukhtar made him play with the angle and got the ball to change line and crash into the off-stump but a no ball check got Vihaan another life on 101.

Sandwiched in between was Uday Saharan's attacking intent, which was cut short by a lapse in concentration. Shortly after a verbal skirmish with Sibsankar Roy, he was trapped in front off Purkayastha.

There was no let-off a third time as Mukhtar pinned Vihaan with a delivery that came in after pitching. Assam gave away just 42 runs in the time it got Ramandeep Singh run out and Jashanpreet Sidhu leg-before off Amlanjyoti.

With the second new ball just two overs old, Assam will walk out on the fourth morning with its tails up, hoping to find a crack in the nagging sixth-wicket partnership and running through the tail that will follow.

The scores: Assam — 1st innings: 373.
Punjab — 1st innings: Vihaan Malhotra lbw b Mukhtar 103, Harnoor Pannu c Ghadigaonkar b Purkayastha 54, Uday Saharan lbw b Purkayastha 30, Jashanpreet Sidhu lbw b Amlanjyoti 22, Ramandeep Singh (run out) Denish 17, Salil Arora (batting) 25, Emanjot Chahal (batting) 28; Extras (b-1, nb-7): 8; Total (for five wkts. in 96 overs): 287.
Fall of wickets: 1-137, 2-195, 3-195, 4-226, 5-237.
Assam bowling: Mukhtar 23-5-79-1, Dipjyoti 9-2-40-0, Amlanjyoti 25-2-54-1, Purkayastha 18-3-52-2, Mohit 21-2-61-0.

Hamstring injury rules Mhatre out for six weeks

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

Mumbai vice-captain and promising opener Ayush Mhatre is set to miss at least six weeks of cricket after sustaining a suspected Grade 4 tear in his right hamstring during the team's Ranji Trophy season-opener against Chandigarh at the Wankhede Stadium.

Mumbai Cricket Association president Ajinkya Naik confirmed on Tuesday that the 19-year-old's recovery timeline would depend on further consultations between the Mumbai team's medical staff and BCCI's Centre of Excellence (CoE) in Bengaluru.

Mhatre suffered the injury while batting on the opening day.

He did not take the field in either of the visitors' innings as Mumbai registered an innings and 155-run victory.

"It happened while running between the wickets. He looks very sad. He worked really hard in the off-season.

"He was doing rehab with me at BKC (Ground) and would come all the way from Virar. It happens, it is part of the game, and we will try to motivate him," Mumbai captain Siddhesh Lad said.

"We had two or three simulation games and club matches, and also played at BKC. He was looking fine for the last three or four matches, but he felt something in his hamstring when taking a second run."

The setback comes barely six months after Mhatre injured his left hamstring while representing Chennai Super Kings in the Indian Premier League on April 18.

That had ruled him out for three months.

It is understood that he had also been troubled by his right hamstring during the rehabilitation at the CoE.



Big blow: Mhatre, right, did not take the field in either of Chandigarh's innings. EMMANUAL YOGINI

SNAPSHOTS

Athletics coach Yunus suspended for alleged anti-doping violation
NEW DELHI: One of India's most well-known athletics coaches, Mohammad Yunus Khan, who has guided star long distance runner Gulveer Singh in his formative years, has been provisionally suspended for alleged "complicity" in an unspecified anti-doping rule violation.

166 athletes make the cut for Para Asiad
The Sports Ministry has axed under-fire para-shooting coach Jai Prakash Nautiyal from the Para Asian Games-bound Indian contingent, approving a total of 166 athletes after a controversy-mired selection process which resulted in protests by shooters and cyclists.
The Games are due to start on October 18 in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan.
Long-serving National coach Jeevan Rai has replaced Nautiyal in the contingent. With 94 team officials and support staff and 15 contingent staff, India's total at the continental showpiece would be 275 in 10 disciplines. Despite a protest by the omitted cyclists, the Ministry has avoided last-minute additions and approved only Paralympian Arshad Shaik, who was the best performer among those in contention.
Six other cyclists had also been picked by the Cycling Federation of India and the Paralympic Committee of India but they were omitted for not meeting the criteria. Among the accomplished names in the approved table tennis contingent is Paralympic silver-winning player Bhavina Patel.

EBFC left to rue missed opportunities against Al-Shorta

ACL II

Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

East Bengal FC squandered a first-half lead to suffer a 3-2 defeat against Iraqi side Al-Shorta in its second Group-D outing of the AFC Champions League Two at Salt Lake Stadium here on Tuesday.

David Hmar scored twice in the first half to put East Bengal ahead twice. He opened the scoring in the seventh minute when he shielded an Al-Shorta defender to receive Hardik Bhatt's centre and turned sharply to complete a spectacular finishing.

Al-Shorta equalised in the 14th minute through Ahmed Yahya, who headed in from a corner.

Despite enjoying less possession, East Bengal looked more threatening on the counter-attack, registering 10 shots of which seven were on target, compared to Al-Shorta's solitary effort on target.

The hosts regained the lead in the 41st minute after goalkeeper Jalal Hassan parried Daniel Ramirez's free-kick. Basim Rashid recovered the ball near the goal line and delivered a back-heel, allowing David to finish from close range.

David missed two further chances before half-time to complete his hat-trick, and those misses proved costly.

Al-Shorta struck twice in quick succession after the break to turn the match around.

Hussein Al-Saedi equalised in the 51st minute before Kingsley Kuku headed home a corner from Argentine substitute Cristian Barco two minutes later.

Al-Shorta were reduced to 10 men in the 76th minute when Abdoul Magid received his second yellow card.

East Bengal pushed for an equaliser but failed to break through the visitors' disciplined defence, leaving the home side to rue missed opportunities and a costly second-half collapse.

The result: East Bengal 2 (David Hmar 7, 41) lost to Al-Shorta 3 (Ahmed Yahya 14, Hussein Al-Saedi 51, Kingsley Kuku 53).

A leader who took India to uncharted terrains

She is someone who enjoyed captaincy and strongly believed in the team-first approach. She nurtured young talents, encouraged them and waxed eloquent when they succeeded at the highest level





P.K. Ajith Kumar

She came. She led. She conquered. Now, she has stepped down.

So, the best captain Indian women's cricket has ever had will no longer walk out to toss with the rival captain in an international game. Harmanpreet Kaur would be cherishing those walks to the middle, in the glare of the television cameras. She is someone who has enjoyed captaincy. And it was a job she did rather well, for all those talks about the need for change in captaincy in recent times.

Granted, she could not take India to the semifinals of the Women's T20 World Cup in England three months ago. But, last year she had led India to an ODI World Cup triumph.

"Only Kapil Dev and M.S. Dhoni have done that," former India captain Shubhangi Kulkarni reminds you over phone from Pune. "So she is in a very exclusive club. And she played a major role in the Indian victory as a batter, too. Everyone talks about Jemimah Rodrigues' brilliant hundred in the semifinal against Australia, but Harmanpreet made 89."

After losing the openers Smriti Mandhana and Shafali Verma inside 10 overs, it was the skipper's 167-run stand for the third wicket with Jemimah that put India's chase of a World-record breaking target. Harmanpreet knows how to make an impact in big games, and she certainly knows how to torment Australia, the best team in women's cricket.

Even in her last appearance as a captain against the Aussies, in the league match at the T20 World Cup at Lord's, she had cracked a 27-ball 56 that gave India at least a fighting chance in what was a must-win situation. But, a determined Australia, riding on a superb partnership with its champion all-rounders Ellyse Perry and Ashleigh Gardner, knocked India out of the competition, avenging the loss in the ODI World Cup.

That was indeed a big blow to Harmanpreet and her women. They were one of the favourites and were at least expected to make the semifinals, but the defeat to South Africa, earlier in the Group of Death, was always going to be costly.



Historic triumph

The Indians, however, won the historic Women's Test at Lord's, which was played right after the World Cup. And India totally outplayed England.

That was followed by the twin successes at the Asia Cup and the Asian Games. So Harmanpreet could end her captaincy on a high.

She admitted, through her widely read Instagram post, that the decision to step down was not easy. "The decision carries years of memories, emotions, sacrifices, and moments that will stay with me for the rest of my life," she wrote.

"I have given everything I had to this team and to Indian women's cricket – my blood, my sweat, my time, and many times, a part of my own game and personal ambitions. There were moments when I had to put my individual performance, my own growth, and what I wanted for myself aside, because I believed the team had to come first."

She said she had to make some difficult decisions. "Decisions that were not always understood, not always easy, and sometimes came at a personal cost," she explained. "But every decision I made was with one intention - to make this team better and to give other players the opportunity to grow, believe in themselves and become the best versions of themselves."

Shubangi, one of the pioneers of women's cricket in India, says Harmanpreet indeed was able to transform the Indian team with her leadership. "She has led India through a period of enormous changes," she said. "From a team which was competing well, and expecting to do well, to becoming a team that wins major championships – she did it through some real high points and through some very low points, too. We have waited for a long, long time, for 50 years to win a senior ICC championship. There was a heartbreak in 2005 and then a bigger one in 2017 (India lost the World Cup finals). So what Harmanpreet's Indian team did last year is indeed remarkable, and it is something she could always be proud about."

Transforming the side

Biju George, who has worked with Harmanpreet as the fielding coach of the Indian team also rates her captaincy highly. "She was an aggressive captain who hated losing," says the Thiruvananthapuram-based man whose wards include Sanju Samson. "As a captain, she has reminded me of Sourav Ganguly. Like he transformed the Indian men's team, Harman did something similar with the women's team."

Biju also has always been in awe of her batting. "Her 171 not out against Australia in the semifinal of the 2017 World Cup in England is the best innings I have ever seen, by a male or a female cricketer, and I was lucky that I could watch it along with the Indian team," he said.

"Harman is one of the earliest batters who brought in power to women's cricket. We have many players who can hit hard now, but not at the time when she was doing it."

And Harman could change the complexion of a game with those big shots. And she has been doing it for so long. Biju feels she could be scoring more runs after relinquishing the captaincy. "She could bat with more freedom," he says. "And I think she has quit captaincy at the right time. Smriti also deserves to be a captain for a few years. And I also think it is good that they did not split the captaincy between formats. It is always to have just one captain. Multiple captains could create issues within the team."

There isn't, of course, a better option than Smriti to lead India in all formats. And she was quick to pay a tribute to Harmanpreet's captaincy.

"It has been a pleasure playing with you for so many years," Smriti wrote on social media. "Ten years of your leadership have been fantastic and together, we will strive to bring many more laurels for our nation."

Smriti's opening partner Shafali also spoke of how much Harmanpreet meant to her.

"Since the day I made my debut, you have always been there for me, on and off the field," said the swashbuckling opener. "From guiding me through the early days to standing by me through everything, I have always known I could count on you."

Those words from Shafali actually reveal something about Harmanpreet. She nurtured young talents – be it Shafali, Shree Charani or Kranti Gaud – and encouraged them always. One has seen her wax eloquent about those youngsters at press conferences several times. You could understand how much their successes meant to her.

She was excited to see the emergence of Kranti as a quality seamer that India desperately wanted. And she made Shafali bowl when not many were expecting her to. The emergence of Shafali as a spinner who could bowl at different stages of a match has given the Indian attack an excellent option. She has justified her captain's faith in her with some fine spells.

Shubhangi feels Harmanpreet deserves credit for handling the transition period in Indian women's cricket well. "She is the only player in the team from the time WCAI (Women's Cricket Association of India), of which I was the secretary, was running the game," she says. "We had to struggle for funds, and things were not easy at all for India's female cricketers. Now there is money and opportunities for our players."

Harmanpreet could always be proud about her role in taking women's cricket forward. That is something nobody could take away from her. And that World Cup.

Captaincy matters in cricket. Harmanpreet has shown that, the way few women in international cricket have.



I have given everything I had to this team and to Indian women's cricket – my blood, my sweat, my time, and many times, a part of my own game and personal ambitions. There were moments when I had to put aside my individual performance, my own growth, and what I wanted for myself

THE GIST

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